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CONTENTS

***SPRINGS* - ENGLISH COURSE BOOK**

1 - 149

Romeo and Juliet		1
Too Dear!		10
On Children		19
Everything I Need to know I Learned in the Forest		30
A Sunny Morning		43
When You Are Old		55
The Gardener		63
To the Foot from its Child		77
I Believe that Books will Never Disappear		90
Heaven, If you are not her on Earth		98
Japan and Brazil Through a Traveller's Eye		103
The Voters		113
Where there is a Wheel		129
Water		138

Romeo and Juliet - William Shakespeare

A Note On The Poet :

William Shakespeare was an English poet and playwright, widely regarded as the greatest writer in the English language. He is often called England's national poet and the 'Bard of Avon'. He was born in Stratford-upon-Avon, Warwickshire, in 1564. Very little is known about his life, but by 1592 he was in London working as an actor and a dramatist. Between about 1590 and 1613, Shakespeare wrote at least 37 plays and collaborated on several more.

Many of these plays were very successful both at court and in the public playhouses. In 1613, Shakespeare retired from the theatre and returned to Stratford-upon-Avon. He died and was buried there in 1616.

Shakespeare wrote plays and poems. His plays, 37 in number, were comedies, histories, and tragedies. His 17 comedies include 'A Midsummer Night's Dream' and 'The Merry Wives of Windsor'. Among his 10 history plays are 'Henry V' and 'Richard III'. The most famous among his 10 tragedies are 'Hamlet', 'Othello', and 'King Lear'. Shakespeare's best-known poems are 'Venus and Adonis', 'The Rape of Lucrece' and the Sonnets, 154 in all.

Romeo and Juliet Summary :

Background-I

'Romeo and Juliet' presents the tragic story of two young lovers Romeo and Juliet, who belong to two powerful noble families of Verona, the Montagues, and the Capulets. The two noble families harbour grudges against each other and have been fighting each other as sworn enemies for a long time.

The action starts with a street brawl between the servants of the two rival families, who are later joined by the heads of the families, the Montagues and the Capulets, themselves. Prince Escalus, who arrives on the scene, admonishes them, restores order, and threatens death to any member of either family found indulging in street fights, in the future. Then he leaves the place taking Lord Capulet along with him. Only Lord and Lady Montague and Benvolio, their nephew, remain there as the others depart. Lord Montague tells Benvolio that Romeo has been in a bad mood for quite a

while, weeping and mooning, staying out all night but going into the house as soon as the sun rises, locking himself in his room with the curtains drawn as if to make 'himself an artificial night'. Benvolio assures him that he will attempt to find out what is bothering Romeo.

Next, we find Paris, a young relative of Prince Escalus, engaged in a conversation with Lord Capulet. Paris wishes to marry 14-year-old Juliet, the only daughter of the Capulets. Lord Capulet tells Paris that Juliet is yet too young to marry, but tells Paris that he will not oppose the marriage if Paris can win Juliet's consent. Incidentally, Lord Capulet invites Paris to a feast to be held at his house that evening.

Meanwhile, Benvolio meets Romeo and learns that Romeo is madly in love with Rosaline, who does not love him and insists on remaining chaste.

Next, we learn that Lord Capulet has given his servant a list of guests whom he has to see and ensure that they are invited to the Capulets' party that evening. But the servant cannot read the names in the list and hence asks two strangers in the street to read. The two strangers are none other than Romeo and Benvolio. Romeo reads out the names of the guests and incidentally learns that fair Rosaline, with whom he is madly in love, is also one of the guests in the party. Romeo and Benvolio decide to 'crash' the party. As planned, Romeo and Benvolio gain entry into the party along with a retinue of masked entertainers and torchbearers.

While the guests are engaged in dancing, Romeo happens to see Juliet dancing with a gentleman. Romeo is awestruck by her beauty and tries to find out from a servant, who she is. It is at this juncture that Romeo says these lines.

The lines spoken by Romeo are taken from Act I Scene V when Romeo happens to see Juliet for the first time in the party hosted by the Capulets. Both Romeo and Juliet do not know each other.

Summary – I Romeo's Speech

Romeo stands apart and rapturously praises her beauty. His words appear to come from someone who has not seen anyone so beautiful as Juliet before. It is night and the room is lit with torches. Romeo exclaims and says that Juliet is brighter than the blaze of the torches. It implies that her brightness outshines the torches and has lit up the hall. In the next two lines again there is a reference to the darkness of the night and the brightly shining lady. Romeo compares Juliet to a jewelled earring hanging against the cheek of an African.

Here again, it implies that Juliet is conspicuously seen amidst others because of her brightness. Romeo is so enchanted with her goddess-like beauty that he declares that she is too beautiful for this world and too beautiful to die and be buried. In the next line, he eulogizes her beauty saying that she outshines the other women like a white dove in the middle of a flock of crows.

Romeo is so overwhelmed by her beauty that he tells himself that when that dance is over, he will watch her where she stands and will touch her hand and make his coarse hand (compared to Juliet's) blessed. Then he asks himself a question whether his heart loved anyone before that moment. Then he tells himself that if it was true then he would renounce it because he had never felt so much in love because he had never seen anyone truly beautiful like Juliet until that night.

Background-II

(Having slipped away from his friends, Romeo lingers in Capulet's garden under Juliet's window, and overhears her confess to the stars that she loves him. He reveals his presence to her, and in an ardent love scene, they resolve to be married secretly. The next day, Juliet sends her nurse, of whom she has made a confidante, to make final arrangements, and the wedding is performed at the cell of Friar Laurence, Romeo's friend. The two lovers depart hoping to meet each other in Juliet's chamber that night. Returning from his wedding, Romeo comes upon his friends, Benvolio and Mercutio, in an altercation with Tybalt, who has been seeking Romeo because of his intrusion at the ball. Tybalt does his best to pick a fight, but Romeo, remembering that now Tybalt is his kinsman, refuses to quarrel.

Mercutio, however, who does not understand Romeo's softness, takes the quarrel upon himself, and when Romeo and Benvolio try to beat down their weapons is slain by Tybalt. Aroused by the death of his best friend, Romeo throws aside his lenity, slays Tybalt, and flees as the angry citizens begin to gather.

Then we come to Act III Scene II, where we find Juliet waiting in her father's orchard for her husband, Romeo's, arrival. Juliet, unaware of what has just happened, waits out the passing of the day. She is more impatient than ever, for, that night Romeo is to come to her as her husband. At the opening of the scene, Juliet delivers an impassioned soliloquy, popularly known as 'Juliet's invocation to the night'. In her soliloquy, Juliet urges the sun on to its setting in the West, so that night may arrive sooner. She longs for the shelter of darkness when Romeo can come to her unseen. The dark suits lovers,

for love, is blind and the beauty of lovers is enough light for them. There are 31 lines in this soliloquy but only 9 lines (lines 17 to 25) are prescribed for your study.

Whereas Romeo's speech highlights the mesmerising physical beauty of Juliet, Juliet's soliloquy highlights Juliet's intensity of love for Romeo.

Summary-II Juliet's soliloquy :

In these nine lines, Juliet invokes both 'night' and 'Romeo' as well. She addresses Romeo as 'day in the night' because his presence will shine out against the darkness. She visualizes night like a bird and believes that Romeo will come gliding on the wings of the night like 'new snow' on a raven's back. She addresses the night appealingly calling it 'gentle night' and 'black-browed night'. She implores it to bring her Romeo to her. After that, when she dies, she asks the night to take him and set him up in heaven with the stars so that he will make the face of heaven beautiful and charming. She hopes that when that happens 'all the world will be in love with night, and it will not pay attention to the overbright or lurid sun.

The soliloquy is based on the unifying images of night and light. Juliet courts this night, which by its darkness will allow Romeo's safe journey to her. The only light she needs is Romeo himself, who is 'day in the night'. The light of the day and the 'garish sun' offer nothing to her; they are only 'tedious'. It is a night that is 'loving', for it blesses her love with its darkness and silence and lets that love shine out. Even the stars, emblems of the fate she does not recognize, seem to be good to her. Romeo will be made eternal by the stars. Juliet's speech is like singing in the face of death. Thus, Juliet hastens the coming of her wedding night.

In short, love belongs to Juliet, now that she is married, but she does not own it, and she can't own love until Romeo possesses her. That is why she is waiting now as impatiently as a child waits for a festival.

Romeo and Juliet Comprehension I :

1.The phrase, “teach the torches to bum bright” suggests:

- a. Juliet’s glow is brighter than the light of the torch.
- b. her beauty is capable of enabling the torches to bum bright
- c. her beauty surpasses the brightness of a light

Ans: (c) her beauty surpasses the brightness of a light.

2.‘For earth too dear’ suggests that the lady’s beauty is

- a. divine.
- b. rare.
- c. expensive.

Ans: (a) divine.

3.‘The measure has done’, connotes the completion of

- a. Romeo’s admiration of Juliet’s beauty.
- b. the dance organised by Lord Capulet
- c. the glorification of Juliet’s charm.

Ans: (b) the dance organised by Lord Capulet

4.The line, ‘Did my heart love till now?’ conveys

- a. Romeo feels he has fallen in love.
- b. Romeo has been attracted before.
- c. Romeo feels this is true love.

Ans: (c) Romeo feels this is true love.

5.The phrase ‘new snow’, suggests

- a. love as pure as snow.
- b. description of Romeo’s charm.
- c. Juliet’s discreet love for Romeo.

Ans: (b) description of Romeo’s charm.

6.What do you think the phrase ‘face of heaven’ signifies?

Ans: The phrase ‘face of heaven’ signifies the moonlit night sky.

Romeo and Juliet Comprehension II :

1.What similes does Romeo use to convey Juliet’s beauty?

OR

Romeo's appreciation of Juliet's beauty is expressed through images. Explain.

Ans: Romeo uses two similes to describe Juliet's extraordinary beauty.

The first simile is deployed in the lines :

**It seems she hangs upon the cheek of night
As a rich jewel in an Ethiop's ear.**

In these lines, the phrases 'cheek of the night' and 'Ethiop's ear' apparently refer to the darkness of the night personified as an African/Ethiopian lady. As we know, an African lady is black in complexion. Juliet stands out conspicuously amidst others in the dark night, lit up by torches in the room. There is a stark contrast between the bright and shining complexion of Juliet and the dark night.

The second simile is deployed in the lines :

**So shows a snowy dove trooping with crows
As yonder lady o'er her fellow's shows.**

In these lines, the comparison is between the 'snowy dove' and the 'crows'. Obviously Juliet is the snowy dove and the other ladies in the room are crows. 'Dove' is a symbol of 'love' and beauty; crows have always been considered black and ugly. Naturally, for Romeo, Juliet is the personification of love and beauty. It also implies that the other ladies including Rosaline, with whom he had fallen in love, appear ugly and gross to him. That is why he uses the phrase 'her fellows, to describe them. These two similes highlight how enchanted Romeo is with her beauty.

2.How, according to Juliet, would Romeo be immortalised to the world?

OR

How does Juliet intend to make Romeo immortal?

OR

How does Juliet express her feelings about Romeo?

Ans: In her invocation speech to 'Night' Juliet invokes night and along with 'night' her Romeo also. To her, Romeo is the 'day' in the night. It also implies that Romeo is her life and so when the night falls, she imagines that he will come gliding upon the wings of night. In these lines 'night' is personified as a raven and Romeo is likened to 'new snow' on a raven's back Juliet favours the arrival of the night because it is in the night that Romeo has promised to come. That is why Juliet praises night calling it 'gentle night' and 'loving black-browed night'.

Love belongs to Juliet now that she is married, but she does not own it, and she can't own love until Romeo possesses her. Once she gets her Romeo she does not fear death. Like all mortals, if she dies, Juliet begs fate to set him in heaven with the stars. His presence will make the face of heaven so beautiful that the world will fall in love with 'night', and the sun will no longer be worshipped. It also implies that their love will end in their tragic death because of the enmity that exists between the two families. Consequently, the world will come to know about the tragic death of the two lovers and thus Romeo will be immortalized.

Romeo and Juliet Comprehension III :

1.Comment on the contrasting imagery in the poem. What purpose does it serve in highlighting the intensity of love?

OR

How did Romeo and Juliet express their romantic love feelings to each other?

OR

Both Romeo and Juliet employ contrasting images in their expression of appreciation and admiration for each other. Elaborate.

Ans: The two stanzas in the poem, one by Romeo and the other by Juliet, highlight the intensity of love of the young lovers. This intensity of love is brought out by using the contrasting imagery of night and day, black and white, bright jewel and a dark surface, snowy dove, etc. Factually speaking, the words 'bright' and 'night' appear in Romeo's praise of Juliet's brightness when he sees her for the first time in the feast hosted by Lord Capulet. Romeo uses the phrase 'snowy dove' to refer to and to distinguish Juliet from other ladies in the room. Romeo uses the word 'crows' to refer to the other ladies in the room.

Furthermore, Romeo compares Juliet's brightness with 'a rich jewel' hanging upon the cheek of an Ethiop's ear. Romeo uses these words to highlight her beauty. It also symbolizes the emotional intensity that he shows towards Juliet.

Similarly, Juliet uses the phrase 'day in the night and 'whiter than new snow on a raven's back' to refer to Romeo. Secondly, she uses the words 'stars in the night sky' to refer to Romeo. Literally speaking, both the meetings between Romeo and Juliet take place at night. Secondly, their meeting has to be a closely guarded secret because of the 'hostility' and the 'enmity' that exists between the two rival families the Montagues and the Capulets.

When Romeo goes to the Capulet's party, he goes wearing a mask at night. Similarly, he promises to meet Juliet in her chamber on the wedding night, so as not to be seen by anyone. That is why the word 'night' symbolically stands for 'secrecy' and 'caution' that needs to be exercised in their love affair. Thus the playwright has used the word 'black' and 'night' to strengthen the emotional situation. Thematically speaking, the words 'day and night', 'black and white', 'night' and 'raven' are used to evoke the image of 'death' whereas 'white dove' is a symbol of purity, peace and 'love'. A raven or a 'black crow' is considered a bird of ill-omen.

Furthermore, 'When I shall die' and 'cut him out in little stars', and 'heaven' are expressions that clearly refer to death and immortality. Thus, the playwright is hinting that the secret love affair between the two rivals will culminate in the tragic death of Romeo and Juliet. It can also be inferred that probably Juliet has a premonition of their impending death because of the fatal attraction between them and the enmity that exists between the two families. Thus, the contrasting imagery serves to highlight the intensity of their love.

2. Between Romeo and Juliet, whose love, do you think, is more passionate and intense?

Ans: It is clear from their expressions that, of the two lovers, Juliet's love is more passionate and intense. It is well-known that when Romeo goes to the Capulet's party, it is with the intention of seeing Rosaline and not Juliet. When he sees Juliet for the first time his exclamations are of one who is overwhelmed by the sight of someone who is mesmerizingly (bewitchingly) beautiful and are not the yearnings of someone deeply in love.

On the other hand, when Juliet gets to know Romeo after he had touched her hand and kissed her, Juliet comes to understand what it means to be in love and from then onwards starts feeling the pangs of love. Finally, she expresses her love firmly, asking Romeo to marry her. Her love for Romeo goes on increasing in intensity and finally in her 'invocation tonight' we find someone yearning to be possessed in love by her husband. She has a premonition of their tragic death which finds expression in her request to 'night to set up Romeo amidst the stars in heaven after death so that their 'love' gets immortalized.

It is also true that, of the two, though Juliet is younger than Romeo, she is more mature and passionate in deciding to get married to Romeo. She accepts Romeo as her partner despite being fully aware of the enmity that exists between the two families.

On the contrary, Romeo, though older than Juliet, is infatuated with Rosaline and is disappointed that she does not reciprocate his love. Only when he meets Juliet who reciprocates his love does he understand what it is to be really in love. Therefore, it can be concluded that it is Juliet who is more passionate and intense in love than Romeo.

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Too Dear! - Leo Tolstoy

A Note On The Writer :

Count Lev Nikolayevich Tolstoy (1828-1910), also known as Leo Tolstoy, is a Russian writer who primarily wrote novels and short stories. Tolstoy is a master of realistic fiction and is widely considered one of the world's greatest novelists. He is best known for two long novels, 'War and Peace' (1869) and 'Anna Karenina' (1877).

Tolstoy first achieved literary acclaim in his 20s for his 'Sevastopol Sketches' (1855), based on his experiences in the Crimean War, and followed by the publication of a semi-autobiographical trilogy of novels, 'Childhood', 'Boyhood', and 'Youth' (1855-1858). His works include two additional novels, dozens of short stories, and several famous novellas, including 'The Death of Ivan Ilych', 'Family Happiness', and 'Hadji Murad'.

The story 'Too Dear!' is based on an absurd situation in which a small state finds it much too expensive to either hang a criminal or to keep in prison for long. Finally, the criminal has to be rewarded with a pension to save the kingdom some money!

Too Dear! Summary :

'Too Dear!' is a fascinating short story by Count Leo Tolstoy, a famous Russian writer. It is adapted from an episode in Guy de Maupassant's work 'Sur L'eau' in French (translated into English 'Afloat') and translated from Russian by Louise Maud and Aylmer Maud.

The story is a parody of one of the modern systems of governance. It ridicules ways of bringing criminals to book and dispensing justice in modern states. The story is narrated in a matter of fact tone but with an undercurrent of sarcasm.

The story begins with the description of a place, its people, and its system of governance. There is a tiny little kingdom called Monaco near the borders of France and Italy. There are only about seven thousand inhabitants in Monaco. The kingdom is so small that if all the land in the kingdom were divided among its inhabitants, there would not be even an acre of land for each inhabitant. But this toy kingdom has a real kinglet and like any other real king, he lives in a palace with courtiers, ministers, a bishop, generals, and an army of only sixty men in all.

The king lives by collecting taxes from the people. There are taxes on tobacco, wine, and spirits and a poll tax too. However, the number of people living in his kingdom being very small, the taxes the people pay for their 'drinking' and 'smoking' are not adequate enough to feed the king's courtiers, and officials and to keep himself. Therefore the king had hit upon a new source of revenue. It came from a gaming house, where people play roulette. The keeper of the gaming house got a percentage on the turnover irrespective of whether people lost or won. Out of his profits, the gaming housekeeper paid a large sum to the kinglet.

Incidentally, it is the only gaming house that is left untouched by the rulers in Europe and hence the gambling housekeeper pays so much money to the prince. There were many such gaming houses run by German sovereigns but some years ago they were forbidden to do so. The rulers stopped such gaming houses because they did a great deal of harm to the people. Many a time, it so happened that a man would come and try his luck, then he would risk all he had and lose it. He would finally drown or shoot himself. However, there was no one to stop the Prince of Monaco, and he remained with a monopoly of the business. So now, whoever wants to gamble goes to Monaco and the prince gains a lot of money this way. The Prince of Monaco knows that earning revenue this way is a dirty business but he feels helpless because he has to live.

Though the kinglet knows that collecting taxes on people's 'drinks' and 'tobacco' is bad yet he is collecting taxes. In the same way, the Prince is living on the revenue he gets from the gaming house. He lives, reigns, rakes in the money, and holds his court with all the ceremony of a real king. He has his coronation and his levees. He rewards, sentences, and pardons. He also has his reviews, councils, laws, and courts of justice just like other kings, but only on a smaller scale.

In the next part of the story, we see the moral conflict faced by the Prince and his people. A murder was committed in the Prince of Monaco's domains. The people of Monaco were peaceable and such a thing had not happened before. Like in other countries there was a legal system in place in Monaco also. The criminal was tried according to the procedures of law. The lawyers argued and the judges finally decreed that the criminal be executed as directed by the law. The prince read out the sentence, confirmed it, and ordered the execution of the criminal.

The story now takes a serious and interesting turn. There arose a problem in the execution of the king's order. Monaco was a toy kingdom and it did not have either a guillotine for cutting heads off or an executioner, the man designated to carry out the execution. The ministers sent a letter of inquiry to the French Government, asking

whether they could lend them a machine and an expert to cut off the criminal's head and also inform the cost involved in it. They received a reply a week later informing them that the French Government would lend them a machine and an expert as well, and it would cost 16000 francs. The king felt that sixteen thousand francs was a lot of money and it was utterly a waste of money to spend so much on beheading a wretched criminal.

The king felt that the people would not accept his decision and if he forced them there might be a riot. Therefore, the king called a council and asked them their suggestion. It was decided to send a similar inquiry to the King of Italy. They wrote to the king of Italy and they received a prompt reply. The Italian government informed them that they would supply both a machine and an expert at a cost of 12000 francs including travelling expenses. Though the price quoted by the king of Italy was cheaper than that of the French government, still the price was too much for a toy kingdom like theirs. Therefore, the ministers called another council and discussed the matter.

The council asked the General of the army to find a soldier who would be ready to cut off a man's head. The members of the council believed that the soldiers have been trained for such a job. The general discussed the matter with his soldiers to see whether one of them would agree to do that job. But the soldiers did not agree to do it because they had not been taught how to behead a criminal.

The king and the ministers met again and discussed the matter thoroughly. Finally, they came to the conclusion that the best thing to do was to alter the death sentence to one of imprisonment for life. This way it would enable the prince to show his mercy and it would also be cheaper. The prince agreed to this and so the matter was arranged accordingly. Though there was no suitable prison for a man sentenced for life, they managed to find a place that would serve as a prison and put the criminal in it. They also placed a guard over him. The guard had to watch the criminal and had also to fetch his food from the palace kitchen. This way, they kept the prisoner imprisoned for more than a year. The whole arrangement of keeping a guard to watch over the criminal and feeding the criminal cost more than 600 francs a year.

One day, while the kinglet was examining the account of his income and expenditure, the new item of expenditure caught his eye. He got worried and so he summoned his ministers and urged them to find some cheaper way of dealing with the criminal. The ministers again met and discussed ways of reducing the expenditure. Finally, they all came to the conclusion that the guard could be dispensed with so that the expenditure on his salary could be saved. They went to the extent of saying "let the prisoner run

away and be hanged". The ministers conveyed their decision to the kinglet and the kinglet gave his consent to it.

Accordingly, the guard was dismissed; but they all waited to see how the prisoner would react. At dinner time the criminal came out, and not finding his guard, he went to the Prince's kitchen to fetch his own dinner. After collecting his dinner, he returned to the prison, shut the door on himself, and stayed inside. He did not show any signs of running away and this got the ministers worried. The criminal was brought before the Minister of Justice. He suggested to the prisoner to run away. He even told him that if he ran away, the prince would not mind it. The prisoner told the minister that he had nowhere to go and accused them of ruining his character by sentencing him to death.

Secondly, he told them that having been confined to the prison, he had given up his habit of working. He actually resented their action in not executing him. He finally told them that he would not like to agree to their proposal that he should run away and escape. The minister felt helpless.

Once more the council was summoned and the criminal's issue was discussed again. They came to the conclusion that the only way they could get rid of him was by offering him a pension. The ministers decided to pay the prisoner a fixed sum of 600 francs as a pension. On receiving the news, the prisoner told them that he would go away on that condition but they must undertake to pay it regularly.

Finally, the prisoner received one-third of his annuity in advance and left the king's dominions. He emigrated to another country just across the frontier. He bought a bit of land, started market gardening, and lived there comfortably.

The narrator comments jovially that it is a good thing that the prisoner did not commit his crime in a country where they do not grudge expense to cut a man's head off, or to keep him in prison for life. The author seems to question the very conviction of the rulers about the system of law and governance instituted by the rulers of big nations. The author seems to appreciate the courage and open-mindedness of Monaco in acknowledging their limitations and letting free the prisoner on humanitarian grounds. It is worth noting that the writer puns on the words 'Too Dear!'. It means either 'too expensive' or 'of great value'. The author leaves it to the reader to decide whether 'Too Dear!' refers to executing a criminal or saving a criminal's life.

Too Dear! Comprehension I :

1.Why was 'Monaco' called a 'toy kingdom'?

Ans: Monaco was called a toy kingdom because it had such a tiny landmass that if all the land in the kingdom were divided, there would not be even an acre for each of its seven thousand inhabitants.

2.Name the commodities that were taxed in Monaco.

Ans: The commodities taxed in Monaco were tobacco, wine, and spirit. The people also paid a poll tax.

3.What was the source of the King's special revenue? Who were its beneficiaries?

OR

Name the special source of revenue in the kingdom of Monaco.

Ans: The percentage of profit given by the gaming housekeeper to the kinglet was the source of the king's special revenue. The king, his ministers, courtiers, his servants, a bishop, his generals, and his army were its beneficiaries.

4.Why did the Germans stop gaming houses in their country and how did it benefit Monaco?

Ans: The Germans stopped gaming houses because those gaming houses did much harm to people. If a man went to a gaming house to try his luck, risking all he had and lost it, then he would even risk money that did not belong to him. If he loses that also, he would be forced to commit suicide by drowning or shooting himself in despair. It benefitted Monaco as it was the only Kingdom that allowed a gaming house to run.

5.What was the punishment given to the murderer?

Ans: The murderer was sentenced to death.

6.The death sentence was converted into imprisonment for life because

- a. Monaco had abolished the death penalty.
- b. carrying out the death sentence was expensive.
- c. Monaco wanted to show mercy to the criminal.

Ans: (b) carrying out the death sentence was expensive.

7.How much did the king spend on the criminal annually?

Ans: The king spent 600 francs on the criminal annually.

8.On what condition did the criminal agree to go away from the prison? How was his demand fulfilled?

Ans: The criminal agreed to go away on condition that he be paid 600 francs as pension for a year regularly until his death. His demand was fulfilled because the prisoner refused to run away from the prison. If he had remained there the king would have been forced to keep a guard over him to watch and also feed him until his death. The criminal left the prison and the king's dominions as well, as soon as he received one-third of his annuity in advance. He emigrated to another country just across the frontier and settled there comfortably.

Too Dear! Comprehension II :

1.Though gambling is a dirty business, why does the king of Monaco resort to it?

Ans: The king of Monaco resorted to letting the gaming house run in his kingdom because the gaming housekeeper paid a large sum of money out of his profits. This money helped the kinglet to live and enjoy his life, holding court with all the ceremony of a real king.

2.Why did the king of Monaco keep changing his mind in dealing with the criminal?

OR

**What problems did the authorities of Monaco face in dealing with the criminal?
How did they resolve them?**

OR

What made the king of Monaco alter his decisions in dealing with the criminal?

Ans: The king of Monaco kept changing his mind in dealing with the criminal because, every time he took a decision, he faced a problem to execute it. First, the king accepted the judge's verdict and ordered the execution of the criminal, but he cancelled it and changed the sentence to 'imprisonment for life' because there was neither a guillotine machine nor an executioner in his country. Moreover, if he had decided to borrow one from the King of Italy, he would have been forced to levy 2 francs per person as additional tax which he did not like.

Secondly, after keeping the criminal in prison for one year, he realized that he had to spend 600 francs on the maintenance of the criminal until his death, which would have proved to be again a financial burden to his people. Therefore, as advised by his council of ministers, he dismissed the guard hoping that the prisoner would run away. But the prisoner refused to run away because he had nowhere to go and he had stopped the habit of working. Once again the king faced a new problem. Then, as suggested by his council of ministers, the king ordered payment of 600 francs a year as pension and got rid of the criminal.

3.Why was the criminal reluctant to go out of the prison?

Ans: The prisoner was reluctant to go out of the prison because his character had been ruined by the death sentence given to him and he had nowhere to go. Secondly, by being imprisoned and given food in his cell every day, he had given up working to earn his living. So he had become lazy. Therefore he felt helpless and so refused to go.

4.How did the criminal lead his life after his release?

Ans: After his release from prison, the criminal emigrated to another country and settled just across the frontier. With the money he had received as an annuity in advance, he bought a bit of land, started market-gardening and lived comfortably.

Too Dear! Comprehension III :

1.“You can’t earn stone palaces by honest labour.’ Justify with reference to the story.

OR

“You can’t earn stone palaces by honest labour”. How does the author relate this statement to the actions of the king of Monaco?

Ans: The King of Monaco levied taxes on tobacco, wine, and spirit. He also levied a poll tax. This was the source of his income. But, with the revenue collected this way, the king found it difficult to feed his courtiers, his officials, and to meet his own expenses. Nobody could live a king’s life with the meager income as the Prince of Monaco got from his subjects. Therefore, to drive home the truth of this statement he quotes the proverb, ‘You can’t earn stone palaces by honest labour’. It only means that if one wants to live beyond his means, honest labour alone cannot fetch him enough money for his luxuries.

It implies that one has to take recourse to earn extra money by some dishonest or unethical means. The King of Monaco also had a source of additional or alternative revenue. He used to receive a large sum of money regularly from a gaming housekeeper, who paid it out of his profits earned from his gaming house.

The king knew that earning one’s living by running a gaming house where people risked their money at the roulette table was a dirty business. Yet, he had allowed it to run because he needed more money. Also, he knew that collecting ‘tax’ on tobacco and ‘drink’ was also unethical but, anyhow he had been doing it for a long time and so he did not mind collecting additional revenue by this dirty business as well.

2. Though the trial and imprisonment of the criminal is depicted in a comic mode in this story, it does give rise to serious questions. What are they?

Ans: 'Too Dear!' tells the story of Monaco, a small kingdom in Europe. The author's intention is to parody the efforts of the modern state to violently restrain crime.

Monaco had a small population, a small army and was ruled by a kinglet. Since it was a very small kingdom, it had meagre financial resources. The people lived peacefully but somehow a murder was committed. The criminal was tried as per the existing rules of the state and was finally sentenced to death. But, there was neither a guillotine machine nor an executioner in the state.

Therefore the king and the ministers made sincere attempts to borrow them from their neighbours the French Government and the King of Italy. After weighing the pros and cons of incurring a huge expenditure the king gave up the idea of getting the criminal executed and changed it to imprisonment for life. This cost the king 600 francs. When the king reflected over the cost, it struck him that the cost would become a big burden if the criminal lived another fifty years.

Again, the king and his ministers met discussed the issue and dismissed the guard believing that the criminal would run away on his own. But the criminal refused to go. Finally, the criminal was offered a small pension and paid one-third of his annuity as advance. He left the prison and emigrated to another country. Thus, there is a streak of humour in the story throughout

The author's intention is to prod the reader with the following serious questions:

Why should 'violence' be punished with violence only?

What is the purpose of trying the criminal in a court of law and decreeing punishment?

Why are crimes committed and how can they be prevented?

What is the role of the government in crime prevention?

What guarantee is there that the 'truth' is revealed when the criminal is tried in a court of law?

How can the miscarriage of justice be prevented?

How can the court ensure that the convicted criminal is given punishment commensurate with the crime?

What is the role of the government in ensuring that the family of the criminal is not put to hardship after the execution of a criminal?

How much time should a country, like Monaco, whose resources are limited, spend on trial and punishment of criminals?

3. Were there other ways of dealing with the criminal? Discuss in the light of the story.

Ans: Monaco was a very small kingdom, with a small population and a small army. Also, its revenue was meagre. Yet, the king managed to rule like any other king with courtiers, judges, and ministers enjoying the luxuries and privileges of a king. The king managed to enjoy his kingship, utilizing the additional revenue generated from monopolizing the gambling business. It is highly condemnable that a king should resort to doing a dirty business to enjoy royal comforts. One can only say the king is too self-centered.

As regards the 'murder' committed by a criminal, the kingdom did not have either a guillotine machine or an executioner. Secondly, the government could not afford to spend even 12000 francs on borrowing the same from the King of Italy. In such a situation it is quite preposterous to put in place a system of inflicting violence to eliminate violence.

One possible alternative punishment would have been sending the criminal into exile. Another alternative punishment would have been to condemn such criminals to hard, physical labour for life or for a limited period until they reformed their behaviour. It would be far more practical, economical, and humane to use the state's resources to reduce crimes, this way.

On Children - Kahlil Gibran

A Note On The Poet :

Kahlil Gibran (1883-1931) is a Lebanese-American artist and poet. His poems are considered 'poetic essays', as they do not adhere to the usual verification. 'The Prophet' is his best-known work and has been translated into more than 25 languages including Kannada.

'On Children' is a selection from 'The Prophet', which offers a critique of the usual expectations of parents about their children and urges them to introspect.

Background :

'On Children' by Kahlil Gibran is an excerpt from 'The Prophet', one of his most popular works.

'The Prophet' occupies a unique place in world literature. It is a work of remarkable compassion, insight, hope and inspiration, with a timeless message that combines the dignity of the Christian Bible and the wisdom of the Sufis of Islam, phrased with simplicity and rhythmical quality that renders it accessible to a wider readership.

It represents an appeal for a return to and reconciliation with nature, emphasizing the relationship that binds individuals to their environment and their fellow creatures. They all become denizens of one world bound together by life and death. The speaker in 'The Prophet' speaks in the persona of 'Almustafa'. Almustafa sets out his own version of the golden rule common to all great religions that we must do as we would be done by. What he voices is not some unattainable ideal, but practical wisdom and simple moral and spiritual values.

The keynote of 'The Prophet' is pantheism. Its central article of belief is that God is latent within everyone as a Greater Self, and that, this is attained through aspiration, or 'yearning', which is comparable to prayer in religion, and also through successive reincarnations. Life is a journey, and God is both 'starting point' and 'destination'. The journey represents the condition of full awareness when the soul has embarked on the path leading to its desired union with God. The journey is an inner one, a spiritual one, in contrast to the travels of the twenty-first-century man or woman, which are all physical.

On Children Summary :

'On Children' is an excerpt from 'The Prophet', one of Kahlil Gibran's most popular works. 'The Prophet' includes twenty-six sermons on varied topics like Love, Marriage, Children, Houses, Clothes, Laws, Crime and Punishment, Buying and Selling, etc. The sermons are given by Almustafa who speaks in the persona of the poet.

'Almustafa' means the 'chosen one'. The name also implies that he possesses spiritual knowledge and divine characteristics. Almustafa is a man of inner purity and is believed to be the 'Perfect man' or the universal man'.

In the opening sermon titled 'The Coming of the Ship', we learn that Almustafa has waited twelve years in the city of Orphalese for the ship that was to return and bear him back to the isle of his birth. The ship has arrived and he is about to go onboard. Before he boards the ship he is met by a woman named 'Almitra', who is a seeress. She prays to him to speak to the people of Orphalese about all that he has been shown about what lies between birth and death. Each of the 26 sermons is the reply given by Almustafa to all those who request him to speak about a particular topic.

'On Children' is one such sermon given by Almustafa to a woman holding a babe against her bosom, when she asks him to speak to the people 'Of Children'. Almustafa begins his sermon with the opening line 'Your children are not your children'.

In this imaginary conversation, there are fourteen lines of which five lines are devoted to enlightening the parents about what / who the children are and the remaining lines to explaining what role the parents should play in bringing up their children.

Your children are not your children.

They are the sons and daughters of Life's longing for itself

They come through you but not from you,

And though they are with you, yet they belong not to you.

They have their own thoughts.

The speaker wants to make the parents aware that a child is a gift from the abundance of existence and it is eternal life itself. Just as we have seen eternal life flowing through mountains, through forests and through plains, children are born as sons and daughters as Life's longing for itself. Life longs to reproduce itself, and we are its servants who carry out that master plan.

Parents do not create them and hence parents cannot possess them. Parents may have brought them to this world because they have been chosen to serve as 'passage' or vehicle to bring the children to this world. They are only the medium through which life expresses itself. Children are closer to the very source of life than old people. Furthermore, children have their own thoughts because they have the free will to do as they please.

In the next few lines, the speaker educates parents as to how they should treat their children.

You may give them your love, but not your thoughts

You may house their bodies but not their souls

For their souls dwell in the house of tomorrow, which you cannot visit, not even in your dreams

You may strive to be like them, but seek not to make them like you

For life goes not backward nor tarries with yesterday.

Almustafa tells parents that they can only act as 'Stewards' and their role is one of stewardship'; parents should not treat their children as their puppets but shower their love as much as they can and take good care of them as we do to someone who is given to our charge. Parents should take care of their needs only and should not impose their thoughts and ideas on them. They should not do so because our children belong to the future whereas we belong to the past generation.

As parents, our days are over. Parents may try to be like their children but their past acts like a barrier. On the contrary, children belong to the future. Since parents belong to the yesterdays, and their children belong to the tomorrows, parents cannot conceive of their future. Hence they should not burden their children with their dead past, their scriptures and their saints. The children will have their own scriptures and saints, parents should only give them as much love as they can. The present is a meeting point but also a point of departure. Every day the gap between parents and their children will become bigger and bigger.

And so, parents should not thrust their past as an inheritance on their children. The children have their own future and we should let them grow according to their own potential. The children are closer to existence than we are. Since life looks forward and does not linger on, parents should let their children build their future, realize their potential and resist the temptation to force their children to be like their carbon copy.

In the next few lines, Almustafa, the speaker, tries to give a visual account of how we should play our role as parents and how we can win God's love:

**You are the bows from which your children as living arrows are sent forth
The archer sees the mark upon the path of the infinite, and He bends you with His
might that His arrows may go swift and far
Let your bending in the archer's hand be for gladness;**

For even as He loves the arrow that flies, so also He loves the bow that is stable. Almustafa tells the parents that God uses parents as his instrument to send 'living arrows' to the earth. God or the Supreme Being is the archer, the parents are the bows and the children are his living arrows. An arrow does not have its own power nor does it create its own path of direction. Both these are provided by God. The archer is God and the path is infinity. Just like the archer, God decides the mark on the infinite path for each child as its destination and using the parents as bows, shoots the arrows. Like an archer, God bends the bows (which are the parents) testing them for stability. The bows must help the arrows to reach their destination.

Existence wants parents to bend like a bow before their own children because they have to travel far and they have to give them strength. Parents should not despise the tests God provides in the image of children, for these tests only make God love the parents more. The speaker wishes us to know that existence loves both parents and children because parents are also children of the same existence. God loves not only parents who are stable, but he also loves children who as arrows will be bows in the future and shoot their own arrows.

At the end of the sermon, the speaker says that while the archer loves the arrows (the children), "He also loves the bow that is stable", which presents before the reader a paradox. As parents involved in the care of children, Gibran appears to be asking us to be strong and bendable at the same time.

This may seem like a contradictory idea, but if we examine the metaphor of the bow, it begins to make sense. The bow has to be able to withstand the force of its string being drawn back. To do this without snapping in two, the bow also has to have strength. This tensile strength allows the arrow being held on the string to be released with optimal energy as it creates balance through resistance and tension, not unlike the kind of discipline we try to adjudicate in the making and breaking of boundaries for our children either at home or in the classroom. Such discipline uses rules and regulations as guides that will hopefully enhance a child's sense of freedom by engendering a balanced sense of responsibility within him or her as well.

**Let your bending in the archer's hand be for gladness;
For even as He loves the arrow that flies.
So He loves also the bow that is stable.**

These lines imply that God, the archer, loves parents who give their children roots to grow in and the freedom to fly when their time has come to do so. He loves those who slowly step back and set them free as their children grow up, encouraging them to learn from their own experiences and to dream their own dreams. He expects parents to do all they can to help their children to fulfill their own highest potential.

The archer expects wise parents to tell the children in their care that they are the children of God and that therefore each child is as precious and unique as the other. Further, God expects parents to respect their children because they know that even when a child is still living in a smaller body than their own, it has nonetheless come into their world as a fully developed soul and spirit in its own right, who may have a long history of evolution behind it that could have taken more lifetimes than those of its parents.

God expects wise parents to tell their children that they have come into this life to learn, evolve, and grow some more through their own experiences. When their children go to school, wise parents point out to them that they are learning for themselves and for life itself, not only for this lifetime but for Eternity. He expects wise parents to explain to their children the laws of the universe and that because of this, whatever anyone sends out to life has to return to them. Finally, God expects parents to teach children by their good example.

In conclusion, we may say that in this sermon ('On Children') Gibran illustrates how love works in the intimate relationship of parenthood.

On Children Comprehension I :

1.And a woman who held a babe against her bosom said, “Speak to us of Children.” And he said: Here ‘he’ refers to

- a. her child.
- b. the Prophet
- c. the poet

Ans: (b) the Prophet.

2.‘Your children are not your children’ means

- a. they do not belong to their parents only.
- b. the children should have their own space.
- c. parents should not be possessive of their children.

Ans: (b) the children should have their own space.

3.‘They come through you, but are not from you’ means

- a. though parents give birth to their children they do not own them.
- b. children have independent personalities..
- c. parents should be indifferent to their children.

Ans: (a) though parents give birth to their children they do not own them.

4.According to the prophet, what may be given to the children?

OR

What can be given to the children by their parents, according to the prophet?

Ans: According to the prophet, the parents can give only their love and affection to their children.

5.‘their souls dwell in the house of tomorrow’ means

- a. children belong to the future.
- b. parents cannot shape their children’s future.
- c. children have a different vision of life.

Ans: (a, c) children belong to the future/children have a different vision of life.

6.‘The bows’ and ‘living arrows’ refer to ____ and ____

Ans: parents and children.

7.‘For even as He loves the arrow that flies, so He loves also the bow that is stable.’ Discuss the contrast between the underlined words.

Ans: In the last four lines of the poem, Gibran uses the metaphor of archer-bow-and-arrows to explain the role of parents in bringing up children. In this metaphor, God is the

archer, the parents represent the bow, and the children are the living arrows. Like an archer, God bends the bows testing them for stability to aid the arrows as they try to reach their destination. "It is the archer who decides the target, which is marked upon the path of the infinite, and He bends the parents (bows) with His might that His arrows may go swift and far".

Children are life's longing for itself and it is the parents who serve as a passage for them to come to the earth. Once they are born, it is the parents' responsibility to see that the 'living arrows' (children) reach the intended target which has been decided by the archer himself. Each arrow is ready to fly but the bow must be able to withstand the strain or pressure caused on it and remain stable or firm so as to enable the arrow to reach its target. The arrows have to fly and the bow has to be stable because the bow must be flexible enough to bend according to the will of the archer. This contrast between the role of the arrows and the role of the bow is brought out in the last line of the poem in the word 'flies' which refers to the arrows and 'stable' which refers to the bows.

On Children Comprehension II :

1. Why does the prophet categorically state "Your children are not your children"?

OR

'Your children are not your children'. How is this statement relevant with reference to 'On Children'? Explain,

OR

'Your children are not your children'. Why? What does the prophet mean by this?

Ans: According to Kahlil Gibran, love occupies the most important place in God's creation. Love is not created by us but is sent from above and it directs everything in our life as it sees fit. In this poem, Gibran illustrates how love works in the intimate relationship of parenthood. Gibran wants us to understand that our role as parents is only 'stewardship' and nothing else.

In the line 'Your children are not your children' Gibran tells parents to be aware that a child is not a thing to be possessed by us because we have not created 'life'.

A child is eternal life itself and is a gift from the abundance of existence. As parents we may have brought them to the earth. This has happened so because we have been chosen to be a vehicle and so we are nothing else but a passage. It is life's longing for itself that brings children to earth, as sons and daughters. Since children are not lifeless things we cannot possess them. That is why the prophet categorically states that 'Your children are not your children'.

2.What does the metaphor of bow and arrow signify with regard to the parent-children relationship?

OR

What do the bow and arrow signify in the poem 'On Children'?

OR

How is the parent-child relationship brought out using the metaphor of bow and arrows?

OR

Bring out the significance of the metaphors 'bows', 'arrows'and 'archer'.

OR

"Parents are bows, children are arrows and God is the archer". How does the poem 'On Children' highlight these images?

OR

'On Children' refers to children as arrows and parents as bows. Explain.

Ans: In his sermon on children, in the first part, Gibran explains to parents how they should take care of their children as 'stewards'. In the last part of the sermon, Gibran uses the metaphor of the bow and the arrows to help parents visualize their role in bringing up children.

In this metaphor, God, or the supreme power, is the archer, parents are the bows and the arrows are the children. The archer uses the bow only as an instrument to send the arrows to their target. The archer decides the trajectory and the target on the infinite path and pulls the string with all his might. As he pulls the string, the bow has to bend and yet withstand the strain and pressure caused in shooting the arrow. The bow should not snap in two. From this metaphor, it becomes clear that parents serve only as an instrument or as a vehicle to help the arrow fly to its destination and parents cannot own them.

3.According to the prophet, what attitude should parents have towards their children?

OR

How does the poet describe the responsibility of parents in the poem 'On Children'?

Ans: Kahlil Gibran tells the parents that they are not the owners of their children. He argues that children have come to this earth as Life's longing for itself and are born as sons and daughters and they are not created by parents. Hence, parents cannot possess them. Parents should consider themselves as 'stewards' and their role is only stewardship. Gibran wants parents not to look upon their children as their puppets and so as not to impose their religion, politics, and ideas on the innocent children. Parents

may give their own love but not their thoughts, because the children have their own souls. They have the free will to do as they please and have a mind of their own. They are free to think for themselves.

Parents merely act as 'guiding lights' for their children. They have the will to act as who they are and lead their own life and not how their parents want them to. The children have their own future, parents belong to the yesterdays, but children belonging to the tomorrows. We should only give as much love as we can and should let them grow according to their own potential. We may strive to be like them but we should never trust our past on them. We should resist the temptation of making our child a carbon copy of ourselves.

On Children Comprehension III :

1. In this poem, 'parents could' stand as a metaphor for

- (a) the older generation
- (b) leaders
- (c) religious heads
- (d) teachers.

Having considered the above options, offer different readings of the poem.

Ans: (a) In the poem 'On Children' by Kahlil Gibran, 'parents' could stand as a metaphor for the older generation. The poem could be taken as a dialogue between Almustafa, the prophet, and the older generation. As advised by the prophet, the older generation must understand that the children of this generation are born as life's longing for itself. They have their own souls. Therefore, the older generation must only strive to protect their bodies until they become adults so that they grow up as mature individuals and fulfil god's mission for which they have come to this earth. The older generation should not indoctrinate the younger generation to lead a life as their parents like because the souls of the younger generation dwell in the house of tomorrow to which the older generation cannot enter. However, their duty is to make the younger generation realize that they have been sent to the earth by God to fulfill his mission.

(b) Similarly, 'parents' could also be taken as a metaphor for 'leaders'. As leaders, they can only protect their children physically, until they come of age. They should not compel them to accept their ideologies and live to fulfill their mission. On the contrary, the leaders must understand that their souls dwell in the house of tomorrow, and hence the ideas of the older generation leaders will only take them backward. But the leaders also are god's children and have been utilized by God as his instrument to send the children to the earth. Therefore, they must see to it that they protect the younger

generation until they grow and become mature individuals. They must also be made aware of god's purpose in sending them to the earth.

(c) The word 'parents' could also be taken as a metaphor for religious heads. The poem can be taken as a dialogue between the prophet and the religious heads. The religious heads are also children of God. They must realize that God wants them to protect their children when they are young and lead them in such a way that the children should have full freedom to obey the yearnings of their souls. The religious teachers should not force their children to obey and accept their ideas of God and his creation. They must only make them realize that as children they have been sent by god to this earth to fulfill god's mission. Like his obedient children, they must be made aware that they have to fulfill god's mission on this earth.

(d) Similarly, the word 'parents' could be taken as a metaphor for teachers and the poem could be taken as a dialogue between Almustafa, the prophet, and the teachers. The teachers must understand that they are expected to serve only as guardians and protect their children until they grow up and mature into fully grown adults. As teachers, they should only make them aware that they have come down to fulfill god's mission. Teachers should not think that they should punish and make them do what he or she likes. On the other hand, their only job is to see that they are taken care of physically and are given complete freedom for their souls to grow and mature and understand god's mission in sending, them to this earth.

2. In light of the poem, think of different levels of freedom children must have in shaping their lives.

Ans: The parents must understand that God expects them to work as guardians to protect their children physically until they grow up and mature and realize god's wishes. In their childhood, instead of getting overly attached to them, the parents should treat them as guests in their homes. They must love and respect them. They should help create an environment conducive for their growth and see that they grow and remain physically, emotionally, intellectually, and spiritually healthy. All-round development is important.

Care for their mental health is equally important. Parents can do this by creating an environment allowing the inborn talent and goodness of the children to blossom. Children are not born bad, the environment makes them so. Therefore, it is necessary to create a healthy environment for the children at home, in school, and in society. Parents should not treat their children as their puppets but shower their love as much as they can and take good care of them as we do to someone who is given to our charge.

Parents should take care of their needs only and should not impose their thoughts and ideas on them.

The parents superimpose ideas, thoughts, and even their pride upon their kids. Instead of imposing philosophies and thoughts on the children, they should give them love and create an atmosphere for their inner talents to flower.

As they grow into adults, the parents must exercise all the more patience and give them the freedom to make their own decisions and let them do what they like for a living. They must also strive to make them aware of the pitfalls in their path if they choose the wrong path.

Finally, when they attain a marriageable age, parents should not influence their decisions by highlighting their lineage or wealth or caste. They must allow full freedom to love and marry a girl of their choice.

3.The poem 'On Children' does not focus merely on the lives of children but also talks about the responsibility of parents. Explain.

Ans: The poem 'On Children' is a sermon on parents. It does not focus merely on the lives of children but also talks about the responsibility of parents. In the first part, Gibran argues that children take birth as life's longing for itself. Since we do not create children, we cannot possess them. However, Gibran argues that parents do have a role in the life of children. He says that we should give our children as much love as we can but never our thoughts. The children must be let free to think for themselves, and parents must not thrust their ideas on them.

Next, Gibran talks about the responsibility of parents. He states that God is the archer, and his parents are his bows. The archer decides on the target, bends the bow to suit his target, and shoots the arrows. The arrows are the children. Thus the archer wants the parents to serve as his instrument. If the bow remains rigid and inflexible, the arrows may not reach the desired destination. Therefore, as parents, it is our responsibility to be flexible enough to allow our children to live their own lives.

Everything I Need to Know I Learned in the Forest - Vandana Shiva

A Note On The writer :

Born in India in 1952, Vandana Shiva is a world-renowned environmental leader and thinker. Director of the Research Foundation on Science, Technology, and Ecology, she is the author of many books, including 'Staying Alive: Women, Ecology and Development', 'Soil Not Oil: Climate Change, Peak Oil and Food Insecurity', 'Earth Democracy: Justice, Sustainability, and Peace', 'Water Wars: Privatisation, Pollution and Profit', 'Biopiracy: The Plunder of Nature and Knowledge', 'Monocultures of the Mind', and 'The Violence of the Green Revolution'.

Vandana Shiva is a leader in the International Forum on Globalization. In 1993, she won the Alternative Nobel Peace Prize (the Right Livelihood Award). In 2010, she was awarded the Sydney Peace Prize for her commitment to social justice. The founder of Navdanya ('nine seeds'), a movement promoting diversity and use of native seeds, she also set up the Research Foundation for Science, Technology, and Ecology in her mother's cowshed in 1997. Its studies have validated the ecological value of traditional farming and been instrumental in fighting destructive development projects in India.

Background :

This lesson is based on two articles written by Vandana Shiva. The first part of the lesson titled, 'Everything I need to know I learned in the forest*' was published in the winter issue of 'Yes!' magazine 2012. The title of the winter issue was 'What Would Nature Do?' The second part titled, 'Right of Nature on the Global Stage', was adopted by the author from her own article 'Forest and Freedom', which was published in the May-June 2011 edition of 'Resurgence Magazine'.

The two parts are thematically interlinked and supplement each other. In the first part, the author tells the reader how she learnt the basic principles of environmentalism from the uneducated women of Garhwal, Himalaya and how she became a proactive environmentalist.

In the second part, she presents a historical account of how the concept of Earth as a living entity got transformed to Earth as dead matter and its consequences.

The whole lesson talks about environmental concepts like bio-diversity, Earth as a living organism, Earth Democracy, ecological sustainability etc.

Everything I Need to Know I Learned in the Forest Summary :

In the first part of the lesson, the writer narrates how she learnt the basic principles of ecology. She says that her study of ecology started in the forests of the Himalaya because her father was a forest conservator. Hence, she declares that whatever she knows about ecology was learned from the Himalayan forests and ecosystems. Incidentally, her mother who was brought up in Lahore (which became Pakistan later) settled in India after partition and became a farmer.

In the next few paragraphs, she narrates the history of the Chipko' movement. It was a non-violent response to the large-scale deforestation that was taking place in the Himalayan region in the 1970s. In this context, Vandana Shiva tells us that her involvement in the contemporary ecology movement began with the Chipko movement. During this period, the peasant women from the Garhwal Himalaya had come out in defence of the forests protesting against the ruthless cutting down of trees on a large scale for logging. This had resulted in landslides and floods, scarcity of water, fodder and fuel. Consequently, women had become the worst sufferers because they were in charge of fulfilling the daily requirements for cooking, washing and other household chores. They had to walk long distances for collecting water and firewood which was a heavy burden.

Fortunately, the women had realized that the forests were the real source of springs and streams, food for their cattle and fuel for their hearths. Therefore, the women declared that they would hug the trees, and the loggers would have to kill them before killing the trees. They appealed to the loggers not to cut them and to keep those trees alive. In 1973 she went to the Himalaya to visit her favourite forests and swim in her favourite stream. She wanted to see these spots before leaving for Canada to do her Ph.D., but the forests were not there and the stream had become a trickle. It was at this moment that she decided to become a volunteer for the Chipko movement. She spent every vacation doing padayatra (walking pilgrimages), documenting the deforestation, the work of the forest activists and spreading the message of Chipko.

Next, the author narrates the Chipko action that took place in the Himalayan village of Adwani in 1977. She recalls how a village woman named Bachni Devi led a movement

of resistance against her own husband who had obtained a contract to cut trees. When the logging officials arrived at the forest, the women held up lighted lanterns although it was broad daylight. The forester admonished them saying that they were foolish women and did not know the value of the forest. He added that the forests produced a profit, resin and timber. The women sang back in chorus replying that the forests bore soils, water and pure air and also sustained the Earth and all that she bears.

In the next section titled 'Beyond Monocultures', Vandana Shiva tells the readers that she learned about bio-diversity and bio-diversity-based living economies, from the Chipko movement. Further, she remarks that our failure to understand biodiversity and its many functions is the root cause of the impoverishment of nature and culture. Then she says that the lessons she learned about diversity in the Himalayan forests she transferred to the protection of bio-diversity on her farms. She started saving seeds from farmers' fields and incidentally realized that they needed a farm for demonstration and training. This led to the establishment of Navdanya Farm.

She declares that now they conserve and grow 630 varieties of rice, 150 varieties of wheat, and hundreds of other species. She proudly says that they practice and promote a bio-diversity intensive form of farming that produces more food and nutrition per acre. Finally, she observes that the conservation of biodiversity is, therefore, the answer to the food and nutrition crisis being faced in our country.

The Navdanya organisation helps farmers make a transition from fossil-fuel and chemical-based monocultures to bio-diverse ecological systems nourished by the sun and the soil. She concludes saying that bio-diversity has been her teacher of abundance and freedom, of co-operation and mutual giving.

The second part of the lesson begins with the title 'Rights of Nature on the Global Stage'.

In the first section, she suggests that we accept nature as a teacher and when we do so we co-create with her and also recognize her agency and her rights. Incidentally, she says that Ecuador has recognized the 'Rights of Nature' in its Constitution and calls it a significant step. As a sequel, the United Nations General Assembly organized a conference on harmony with nature as part of Earth Day celebrations in April 2011. She makes a reference to the report of the UN Secretary-General titled 'Harmony with Nature', that was issued in conjunction with the conference. The report highlighted the importance of reconnecting with nature.

Vandana Shiva opines that separatism is indeed at the root of disharmony with nature and violence against nature and people. The author supports her statement citing the opinion of Cormac Cullinan, a prominent South African environmentalist. According to him, “apartheid means separateness”. The author says that the whole world joined the anti-apartheid movement in order to end the violent separation of people on the basis of colour. Now that apartheid in South Africa has been put behind us, we need to overcome the wider and deeper apartheid – an eco-apartheid based on the illusion of separateness of humans from nature in our minds and lives.

The author makes an attempt to trace the origin of the idea of separateness. The author recalls our beliefs about the Earth in the pre-industrial era when ‘Man’ believed that living beings were an inseparable part of nature. But, later with the advent of scientific thinking man came under the illusion that the living Earth was dead matter and there was no connection between the living Earth and the other living creatures. Vandana Shiva remarks that it was at this moment in history that the war against the Earth began. She observes that the seeds of separateness were sown when the living Earth was considered as a dead matter to facilitate the industrial revolution.

She adds here that monocultures replaced diversity; ‘raw materials’ and ‘dead matter’ replaced vibrant earth. The Earth came to be termed as Terra Nullius, which means ‘empty land’, ready for occupation regardless of the fact that the Mother Earth (Terra Madre) was home to tens of thousands of indigenous peoples (people of different races, tribes, ethnicities).

Vandana Shiva next mentions Carolyn Merchant, a philosopher and historian, in her support and says that “this shift of perspective from nature as a living, nurturing mother to inert, dead and manipulable matter” was well suited to the activities that led to capitalism. Furthermore, Vandana Shiva says that the images of domination of the Earth by scientific methods, created by Francis Bacon and other leaders of the scientific revolution replaced the idea that the Earth nurtures life/living beings. They also successfully removed a cultural constraint on the exploitation of nature. Until then, people did not dare to “readily slay a mother, dig into her entrails for gold, or mutilate her body” as observed by Merchant.

It is to be inferred here that once Francis Bacon popularized the idea that the Earth can serve as a source of raw materials for scientific experiments, many new scientific discoveries and inventions were made which later led to the exploitation of iron, gold, copper, wood and metals from the earth and heralded the industrial revolution, modernization, growth of cities, increase in the number of rich people and urban culture, displacing other cultures.

In the next section titled 'What Nature Teaches', Vandana Shiva tells the reader what we need to do now. She says that we are facing multiple crises and hence we need to move away from the paradigm of nature as dead matter and move towards an ecological paradigm. Vandana Shiva tells us that to understand what an ecological paradigm means, we need to go to 'nature' herself and nature is the best teacher.

Vandana Shiva presents a model of the Earth University which she says is located at 'Navdanya', a bio-diversity farm. She says that Earth University teaches Earth democracy. The concept of Earth Democracy symbolizes "freedom for all species to evolve within the web of life". It also refers to the freedom and responsibilities of humans as members of the Earth family, to recognize, protect and respect the rights of other species.

Vandana Shiva explains that the idea of 'Earth Democracy' is a shift from anthropocentrism to eco-centrism. Anthropocentrism is a school of thought which argues that humans are the central element of the universe. Now we need to accept that 'eco-systems' are the main elements of the universe and not Man, and the Earth nurtures diverse eco-systems. It also means that it is man's responsibility to preserve these ecosystems. Since we all depend on the Earth for our survival, Earth democracy gives every human being rights to food and water, to freedom from hunger and thirst. Vandana Shiva mentions the activities at Navdanya. She says that it is a bio-diversity farm where participants learn to work with living seeds, living soil, and the web of life.

In the next section titled 'The Poetry of the Forest', Vandana Shiva talks about the original source of the idea of 'The Earth University'. She states that the concept of Earth University originated from Rabindranath Tagore's Shantiniketan in West Bengal. Tagore started a learning centre in Shantiniketan in West Bengal as a forest school. The school became a university in 1921, growing into one of India's most famous centres of learning. Vandana takes this forest school as a model and tells the readers that just as in Tagore's time, we need to turn to nature and the forest for lessons in freedom. Then she refers to Tagore's essay 'Tapovan' (Forest of Purity) in which Tagore has expressed his understanding of the Indian civilization.

Tagore asserts that India's best ideas have come from where the man was in communion with trees and rivers and lakes, away from the crowds. He adds that the peace of the forest has helped the intellectual evolution of man. Furthermore, he says that the culture that has arisen from the forest has been influenced by the diverse processes of renewal of life and these processes of renewal of life are always at play in

the forest, varying from season to season, in sight, sound and smell. This culture of the forest has fueled the culture of Indian society.

Vandana Shiva says that unity in diversity is the basis of both ecological sustainability and democracy. She adds that this is true of both nature and culture, and through our relationship with the forest we are united with nature.

Vandana Shiva further elaborates the features of the culture of the forest. She refers to Tagore's writings and says that in his writings the forest was not just the source of knowledge and freedom, but was also the source of beauty and joy, of art and aesthetics, of harmony and perfection. It symbolized the universe. Vandana Shiva says that the forest teaches us union and compassion. It also teaches us 'enoughness'. It means, it teaches us the principle of equity. It shows us how to enjoy the gifts of nature without exploitation. Furthermore, she says that no species in a forest takes away the share of another species and every species sustains itself in co-operation with others. She concludes saying that the end of consumerism and accumulation is the beginning of the joy of living.

Finally, Vandana rounds off her article saying that the conflict between greed and compassion, conquest and co-operation, violence and harmony continues even today and in this situation, it is the forest that can show us the way beyond this conflict. Thus, Vandana Shiva wants to assure us that the forests teach us the values of diversity, freedom and co-existence.

Everything I Need to Know I Learned in the Forest Comprehension I :

1.Trace the childhood experiences that shaped the author's interest in ecology.

Ans:Vandana Shiva's father was a conservator of forests in the Himalaya region. This implies that she lived and was brought up in forest surroundings. Hence she declares that whatever she knows about ecology was learned from the Himalayan forests and eco-systems. Her mother was a farmer and she used to compose songs and poems about trees, forests and India's forest civilizations. Thus, her parents and their profession undoubtedly shaped the author's interest in ecology.

2.How does the scarcity of water, fodder and fuel affect women?

Ans: The ruthless cutting down of trees results in floods, landslides, scarcity of water, fodder for cattle and fuel. This affects the womenfolk in particular because they have to walk long distances for collecting water and firewood which is quite burdensome.

3.What features of the 'Chipko' movement does the author highlight?

Ans: The features of chipko movement are that it was a nonviolent response to the large scale deforestation like doing padayatras, documenting the deforestation, and the work of the – forest activists, hugging the trees to prevent them from being cut down. One such Chipko action took place in the Himalayan village of Adwani in 1977. A woman led the resistance against her own husband, who had obtained a contract to cut trees. She protested with lighted lanterns in bright daylight.

4.The real value of the forest for women was

- a. timber from dead trees.
- b. source of basic needs.
- c. springs and streams.

Ans: (b, c) source of basic needs/springs and streams.

5.List the activities that Vandana undertook after her involvement with the 'Chipko'movement'.

Ans: She spent every vacation doing padayatras, documenting the deforestation, and the work of the forest activists.

She spread the message of the Chipko movement and created awareness in the people about the value of forests.

She put emphasis on organic farming.

She set up 100 community seed banks.

6.The conservation of biodiversity in agriculture leads to

- a. increase in the quantity of food production.

- b. a developing variety of food grains.
 - c. more quality food and higher nutrition.
- Ans: (c) more quality food and higher nutrition.

7. Why is it important to change the fossil-fuel and chemical-based monoculture?

Ans: It is important to change the fossil-fuel and chemical-based monoculture because it impoverishes nature and culture.

8. What prompted the UN to initiate a discussion on the rights of Mother Earth?

OR

Name one of the factors that prompted the U.N. to initiate a discussion on the rights of Mother Earth.

Ans: The Constitution of Ecuador in which were recorded the rights of nature and the Universal Declaration of the Rights of Mother Earth initiated by Bolivia prompted the UN General Assembly to organize a conference so as to initiate a discussion on the rights of Mother Earth.

9. The conference organized by the UN General Assembly aimed at transforming the domination of

- a. people over nature.
- b. men over women.
- c. rich over the poor.
- d. all of the above.

Ans: (d) All of the above.

10. What, according to the author, is eco-apartheid? Why is it necessary to end this?

Ans: According to the author, eco-apartheid means holding the illusion in our minds and lives that humans are separate from nature. It is necessary to remove such an illusion from our minds and lives because it leads to disharmony with nature and finally to violence against nature and people. In short, human beings start exploiting nature and perpetuate violence against themselves.

11. Which event in human history marked the beginning of the separation of humans from nature?

Ans: The industrial revolution which was facilitated by the belief that Earth was dead matter marked the beginning of the separation of humans from nature.

12. How do Carolyn Merchant and Francis Bacon differ in their views?

Ans: Francis Bacon the father of modern science believed that science and the

inventions that result do not “merely exert a gentle guidance over nature’s course, they have the power to conquer and subdue her, to shake her to her foundation. But. Carolyn Merchant points out that due to this over greed, nature has been destroyed by man to suit his capitalism. But then, he realised the importance of nature, and instead of destroying he slowly started to think about nature and nurturing Earth by removing his blind superstitious cultural beliefs. At last, she says “One does not readily slay a mother, dig into her entrails for gold, or mutilate her body”.

13.What ideas of Tagore inspired Vandana Shiva to start Earth University?

Ans: The author states that the Earth University located at Navdanya farm was inspired by Rabindranath Tagore’s ideas expressed in his essay ‘Tapovan’ (Forest of Purity). Tagore says that India’s best ideas have come from the forests where the man was in communion with trees and rivers and lakes, away from the crowds. The peace of the forest has helped the intellectual evolution of man and the culture of the forest has fueled the culture of Indian society.

The culture that has arisen from the forest has been influenced by the diverse processes of renewal of life, which are always at play in the forest, varying from species to species, from season to season, in sight and sound and smell. The unifying principle of life in diversity, of democratic pluralism, thus became the principle of Indian civilization.

14.How are unity and diversity related to each other?

Ans: Unity and diversity are related to each other. This unity in diversity that is the basis of both ecological sustainability and democracy. Diversity without unity becomes the source of conflict and contest. Unity without diversity becomes the ground for external control. The forest is a unity in its diversity and we are united with nature through our relationship with the forest.

Everything I Need to Know I Learned in the Forest Comprehension II :

1.How did the women led by Bachni Devi put up resistance to the felling of trees? Do you think it was effective?

Ans: In 1977, in the Himalayan village of Adwani, a village woman named Bachni Devi led the resistance against her own husband, who had obtained a contract to cut trees. When officials arrived at the forest, the women held up lighted lanterns in broad daylight. When the forester asked them to explain their action, the women told him that they had come there to teach them forestry.

When the forester retorted, calling them foolish women and asked them whether they knew the real value of the forests and asked them whether they knew what the forests bore, the women retorted and sang in chorus saying that the forests bore soil, water, and pure air which sustain the Earth and all she bears.

Their demonstration was very effective because, the menfolk including the forester believed that the village women were naive and ignorant, but on the contrary, they proved that they were quite knowledgeable about the benefits of forestry.

2. Why is it important to promote biodiversity-intensive farming? How did the author achieve it?

Ans: Bio-diversity promotes democratic pluralism where every species gets opportunities to sustain itself in co-operation with others and no species in a forest appropriates the share of another species. Since failure to understand biodiversity and its many functions leads to an impoverishment of nature and culture, it becomes imperative to practice bio-diversity-intensive farming.

The author started Navdanya Farm in 1994 in the Doon Valley where she practiced biodiversity-intensive farming. Initially, she started saving seeds from farmers' fields and today they are able to conserve and grow 630 varieties of rice, 150 varieties of wheat, and hundreds of other species. She opines that bio-diversity-intensive farming produces more food and nutrition per acre and hence bio-diversity is the answer to the food and nutrition crisis.

3. 'Rights of Nature' means

- a. the right of people to use nature.
- b. the duty of human beings to conserve nature.
- c. preserving nature for self-protection.

Ans: (b) and (c) the duty of human beings to conserve nature/ preserving nature for self-protection.

4. What does the concept of the Earth University convey? How is this different from that of the other universities?

OR

Write a note on Earth University mentioned in Vandana Shiva's essay.

Ans: The Earth University located at Navdanya, a biodiversity farm in the Doon Valley of the Himalaya, teaches Earth Democracy. It means freedom for all species to evolve within the web of life, and the freedom and responsibility of humans, as members of the Earth family, to recognize, protect, and respect the rights of other species. Earth

University is different from other universities because it is eco-centric, while the other universities are anthropocentric.

Eco-centrism refers to the system of thought where the focus is on conserving the existing eco-systems that are needed to protect and sustain the web of life on the Earth. On the contrary, the other universities are anthropocentric. They focus on protecting and sustaining the life of human beings only.

Everything I Need to Know I Learned in the Forest Comprehension III :

1. “Tagore saw unity with nature as the highest stage of human evolution.” Do you think consumerism and accumulation of wealth come in the way of realizing Tagore’s vision of human evolution?

Ans: Yes. Undoubtedly consumerism and accumulation of wealth come in the way of realizing Tagore’s vision of human evolution. Tagore firmly believed that Indian civilization found its source of regeneration – both material and intellectual – in the forest. Tagore was convinced that India’s best ideas have come from the place where the man was in communion with trees and rivers and lakes, away from the crowds. The peace of the forest has helped the intellectual evolution of man. The culture that has arisen from the forest has been influenced by the diverse processes of renewal of life, which are always at play in the forest, varying from species to species, from season to season, in sight, sound and smell. Thus, the unifying principle of life in diversity, of democratic pluralism, became the principle of Indian civilization. It is this unity in diversity that supports ecological sustainability and democracy.

On the contrary, consumerism and accumulation work against the idea of unity in diversity and ecological sustainability, because both consumerism and accumulation of wealth are external manifestations of our vices like gluttony, greed, avarice, self-indulgence, self-centeredness, domination and exploitation. These vices ultimately lead to ruthless and barbaric exploitation of nature and cause impoverishment of nature and culture.

2. “The conservation of biodiversity is the answer to the food and nutrition crisis.” Do you agree?

OR

“Biodiversity-based intensive farming is the answer to the food and nutrition crisis”. Discuss.

Ans: Yes. The conservation of biodiversity is the right step to help the people overcome the nutrition crisis because bio-diversity works on the paradigm of Earth Democracy and democratic pluralism wherein there is freedom for all species to evolve within the web of

life. As members of the Earth family, it is the freedom and responsibility of humans to recognize, protect and respect the rights of other species. This way we bring into play the principle of equity. No species in such an ecosystem appropriates the share of another species and every species sustains itself in co-operation with others.

Secondly, bio-diversity sustains democratic pluralism because there are diverse processes of renewal of life always at play in natural eco-systems and they vary from species to species and from season to season in sight, sound and smell. All the species live in perfect harmony. Thus bio-diversity paves the way for enrichment of the web of life leading to abundance.

3. “Conservation of biodiversity is crucial for the sustenance of both nature and human society.” Discuss.

OR

Conservation of biodiversity sustains both nature and culture. Discuss in the light of Vandana Shiva’s essay.

OR

Write a note on biodiversity.

Ans: The Earth houses millions of eco-systems and nurtures bio-diversity. Bio-diversity ensures abundance, freedom, co-operation and mutual giving. Tagore argues that the forests have served as sources of material and intellectual regeneration since time immemorial and the culture of the forest has fueled the culture of Indian society. The culture that has arisen from the forest is nurtured by the unifying principle of life in diversity and of democratic pluralism. It is this unity in diversity that is the basis of both ecological sustainability and democracy. This is true of both nature and culture. We are united with nature through our relationship with the forest. The forest teaches us union, compassion and enoughness.

No species in a forest appropriates the share of another species and every species sustains itself in co-operation with others. This unity in diversity seen in the forest should serve as a model for human society, otherwise, it will lead to conflict, greed, exploitation and finally to the impoverishment of our culture. Therefore, the conservation of diversity is crucial for the sustenance of both nature and human society.

4. In light of this essay, how does one synthesize the wisdom of the past with the modern knowledge systems?

Ans: The essay ‘Everything I need to know I Learned in the Forest’, by Vandana Shiva, highlights the importance of sustaining biodiversity in nature. However, the author does not dismiss scientific inventions and discoveries as useless. Scientific inventions and discoveries have proved successful in controlling infant mortality, increasing longevity.

But some of the discoveries and inventions have resulted in damaging our eco-systems and are now threatening to wipe out life on this earth. Secondly, some scientific practices might create a crisis in the food chain itself.

Under such circumstances, we need to synthesize the wisdom of the past with modern knowledge systems. This has several advantages. For example, traditional knowledge is vital for the sustenance of natural resources including forests, water and agro eco-systems across landscape continuum, spanning from households through farms, village and wilderness.

An expert by name Caval Canti (2002) notes that a limitation of economic development is that it is pursued without any considerations in practice as to its implications on ecosystems. The prevailing economic theories treat the economic process from a purely mechanistic standpoint. Different ways exist, however, to deal with the choices that humans have to make with respect to the allocation of resources, the distribution of the returns and the fulfilment of purposes of material progress.

To understand how local people solve their economic problems in a sustainable fashion is a serious challenge. A better grasp of this issue could possibly be accomplished with the use of ethno economics or ethno ecological economics. Application of scientific research and local knowledge contributes both to the equity, opportunity, security, and empowerment of local communities, as well as to the sustainability of the natural resources. Local knowledge helps in scenario analysis, data collection, management planning, designing of the adaptive strategies to learn, and get feedback and institutional support to put policies into practice.

Science, on the other hand, provides new technologies or helps in the improvement of the existing ones. It also provides tools for networking, storing, visualizing, and analyzing information. Thus, by developing sustainability science and ethno economics, we can synthesise the wisdom of the past with modern knowledge systems.

A Sunny Morning - Serafin and Joaquin Alvarez Quintero

About the playwright :

Serafin (1871 – 1938) and Joaquin (1873 – 1944) Alvarez Quintero were Spanish brothers, known as the 'Golden Boys of Madrid Theatre'. They were celebrated playwrights of the early twentieth century. Together they wrote about 200 plays which depict the life, manners and speech of the people of their native Andalusia in Southern Spain. Their popular comedies, many of which have been translated into other languages, contributed to the revival of Spanish theatre. 'The Flowers,' 'The Merry Heart,' 'One Hundred Years Ago,' 'The Galley Slave' and 'Apple of His Eye' are some of their popular plays.

Characters:

Dona Laura

Petra – her maid

Don Gonzalo

Juanito – his servant

Story in brief:

'A Sunny Morning' revolves around Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura who, in their youth, were passionately attached to each other. A cruel blow of fate separates the two forever. They do not recognize each other when they meet in a park in Madrid on a sunny morning, after several years. But as they begin to talk in earnest, they realize that they are the protagonists of the original love story. But the usual reunion of the long-lost lovers does not take place here as both of them are unwilling to disclose their real identity since they are both sadly changed.

A Sunny Morning Summary :

'A Sunny Morning' is a short, one-act play by Serafin and Joaquin Alvarez Quintero, two renowned Spanish dramatists. It is a romantic comedy which presents the story of Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura who, loved each other in their youth but were forced to separate in life.

On a sunny autumn morning in a quiet corner of a park in Madrid, Dona Laura, a handsome, white-haired lady of about seventy, refined in appearance, is feeding pigeons in the park. Don Gonzalo, a gentleman of seventy, gouty and impatient, enters. Their servants Petra, Dona Laura's maid, and Juanito come and go nearby.

The conversation between the two seventy-year-olds begins sarcastically, with each accusing the other of encroaching on their private space. Don Gonzalo complains the priests have taken his bench and says Dona Laura is a "Senile old lady! She ought to be at home knitting and counting her beads." She finds him "an ill-natured old man!" He resigns himself to "sit on the bench with the old lady."

A pinch of snuff helps to clear their heads, and they find something in common with alternating sneezes of three times each. Dona Laura confides to the audience, "the snuff has made peace between us."

They begin to banter back and forth in a more friendly manner. Then Don Gonzalo reads out loud from a book of poems. As they converse, Gonzalo says that he is from Valencia and to his surprise, Laura reveals that she is from Maricela where she lived in a villa. Gonzalo is startled by the revelation and he says that he knows a woman named Laura Llorente who lived in a villa there, who was perhaps the most beautiful he had ever seen. Both Laura and Gonzalo realise each other to be former lovers. But they pretend not to reveal their identities.

In her youthful days, Dona Laura was known in her locality as 'The Silver Maiden'. She was fair as the lily, with jet black hair and black eyes. She was like a dream. She was in love with Gonzalo, the gallant lover. He used to pass by on horseback every morning through the rose garden and toss up a bouquet of flowers to her balcony which she caught. On his way back in the afternoon she would toss the flowers back to him. But Laura's parents wanted to marry her off to a merchant whom she disliked. One day there was a quarrel between Gonzalo and the merchant, the suitor. After the duel the young man fled from his hometown to Seville and then to Madrid, being scared of the consequences of a duel with a person highly regarded in that locality. Even though he tried to communicate with Laura through letters, all attempts failed.

Now Laura and Gonzalo devise stories of their own deaths. The old Gonzalo says that he is the cousin of the young man. According to him, the young Gonzalo had to leave his place as he was involved in a fight with a merchant, the suitor of Laura. Then he joined the army and went to Africa where he met with a glorious death. The old Laura says that she knows the woman named Laura, known as 'The Silver Maiden' and that

she was her friend during her young age. She also lies that she knows the tragic story of her love affair with a gallant young man named Gonzalo. The old woman reveals that not finding her lover, the young and beautiful Laura committed suicide.

But, in reality, after three months Gonzalo ran off to Paris with a ballet dancer and Laura, on the other hand, got married after two years. Both realise that they are lying but pretend to be unaware. When the play ends, they agree to meet at the park again, still not acknowledging what they both know to be true.

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A Sunny Morning Comprehension I :

1.Do you think Laura was a regular visitor to the park? What makes you think so?

Ans: Yes. Laura was a regular visitor to the park. This is clear from her questions to her maid Petra. She wonders whether somebody would have occupied her seat and whether the pigeons know when to expect her and eagerly come over to feed on the bread crumbs, which means that she comes daily to the park.

2.Why are Don Gonzalo and Laura annoyed with each other?

Ans: Don Gonzalo was annoyed with Laura as she questioned why he had used his handkerchief to brush his shoes and numerically asked whether he would use a shoe brush as a kerchief. Moreover, when he wished her she did not wish him back. Laura was annoyed with Gonzalo because he had scared the pigeons fly away.

3.Dona Laura reads without her glasses as

- a. she has keen eyesight.
- b. she wants to impress Gonzalo.
- c. she knows every word by heart.

Ans: (c) she knows every word by heart.

4.Gonzalo and Laura keep up a humorous conversation because they;

- a. have nothing else to do.
- b. enjoy being with each other.
- c. have the same temperament.

Ans: (c) have the same temperament.

5.Laura and Gonzalo's friendly conversation begins with

- a. Gonzalo reading the poems.
- b. Laura's witty remarks.
- c. a pinch of snuff.

Ans: (c) a pinch of snuff.

6.Do you think Laura is an effective narrator?

Ans: Yes. I think Dona Laura is an effective narrator because when Don Gonzalo asks her what she wishes to tell him Dona Laura tells him clearly that he had scared away the birds which were feeding on her crumbs.

7.Gonzalo does not reveal his identity because:

- a. he no longer loves her.
- b. his appearance has changed.

c. he looks grotesque and old.

Ans: (c) he looks grotesque and old.

A Sunny Morning Comprehension II :

1. Describe the situations wherein Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura recognize each other as 'the silver maiden' and 'the gallant young man'.

Ans: Both Dona Laura and Don Gonzalo become friends soon after enjoying a pinch of snuff offered by Don Gonzalo. While Don Gonzalo is reading aloud, he comes across a famous quotation. Incidentally, he tells Dona that it is from Campoamor. Then Dona Laura expresses her sympathy for him for reading with all those glasses. This prompts Don to boast about his talent to compose verses. Then, he tells her about Espronceda, Zorrilla, and Becquer. Dona makes fun of him saying that he must have gone with Columbus on one of his explorations.

At this moment, Don Gonzalo tells her that he was also a great friend of Campoamor and he had met him in Valencia. Then he adds that he was a native of Valencia. Dona Laura tells him that she had spent several seasons in a villa called Maricela, which was not far from Valencia. The name Maricela startles Don Gonzalo and he goes on to tell her that he had seen the most beautiful woman there and her name was Laura Llorente. Laura is startled to hear her name mentioned and they look at each other intently. It is precisely at this moment that they begin to recognize each other.

2. What were the circumstances that led Gonzalo to flee Valencia?

OR

What circumstances, according to Gonzalo, made his cousin flee Valencia?

Ans: The young Laura Llorente and young Gonzalo loved each other very dearly. Every day while passing by on horseback down the rose path under the window of Laura, Gonzalo used to toss up to her balcony a bouquet of flowers. Later in the afternoon, while the gallant young man was returning by the same path, he would catch the bouquet of flowers she would toss him. As days rolled by, Laura's parents thought of marrying her to a well-known merchant in their locality. One night, while Gonzalo was waiting under her window to hear her sing, the merchant came there unexpectedly and insulted him.

This led to a quarrel and later a duel. The duel went on the whole night and at sunrise the next morning the merchant got badly wounded in the duel. The merchant was a well-known gentleman in Valencia. Since he had been badly wounded in the duel,

Gonzalo became apprehensive of fearful consequences and so fled Valencia and went to Seville and then to Madrid.

3. Did Laura and Gonzalo pine for each other after they were separated by circumstances? Who is more passionate? How do they react to each other now?

OR

How do Laura and Gonzalo claim to have pined for each other after their separation?

Ans: Soon after they were separated by circumstances the young lovers Laura and Gonzalo pined for each other. After listening to Gonzalo's account of how he had fled Aravaca, then joined the army in Africa and had met a glorious death in the war, Laura mutters to herself that it is an atrocious lie. Then Dona Laura pretends to sympathise with him saying he must have been distressed by the calamity. Taking it as a strong point, Gonzalo pretends to say that it was indeed a calamity, but also tries to express his resentment complaining that on the contrary Laura had soon forgotten Gonzalo and was chasing butterflies in the garden without any regret. Dona Laura protests saying 'no' loudly and Gonzalo comments that it is a woman's way. Dona Laura, so as not to be found fault with that way, offers her version of the story.

She tells him that the silver maiden awaited the news of Gonzalo for a year. As she did not receive any letters from him, went to the sea after sunset, wrote his name on the sand, sat on a rock and was finally swept out to the sea by the rising tide. Don Gonzalo mutters to himself that she was a worse liar than he was. Both of them openly express their sympathies for each other. Dona mutters to herself that she will not tell him that she got married two years later. Don Gonzalo mutters to himself that he ran off with a ballet dancer to Paris in three months. From their conversation and from their reactions to each other's partially concocted story, we can conclude that Laura is more passionate.

4. What makes Dona Laura assume that Don Gonzalo is an ill-natured man?

OR

How do Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura accuse each other at the beginning of the play?

Ans: Soon after entering the park, Don Gonzalo looks for a vacant bench. When he finds that the bench on which he used to sit is occupied by three priests, Don Gonzalo gets irritated and he expresses his annoyance remarking that the priests were idling their time away instead of saying Mass in the church. Then Juanito suggests that he could sit on the bench on which Dona Laura was sitting. But Don Gonzalo tells him that he wants a bench to himself. Then after expressing his anger against the three priests, he walks towards the birds near Dona Laura's bench, when she angrily asks him to a

lookout. On hearing her warning cry, Don Gonzalo asks her whether she intended to speak to him.

Next, when Dona tells him that he had scared the birds away, he retorts telling her that he does not care about the birds. Then she tells him that she cared about the birds very much and hence she was complaining about his behaviour. Don Gonzalo tries to snub her saying that it was a public park. Intending to argue with him, Dona asks him why then he was complaining about the priests taking his bench. Instead of giving her a suitable, polite reply, he dismisses her rudely telling her that they had not met before and he can't imagine why she was taking the liberty of addressing him. Naturally, Dona who had listened to his comments about the priests and his replies to her queries assumes that he was an ill-natured man.

5.Laura and Gonzalo build stories about themselves so that they can:

- a. fool each other.
- b. forget the past
- c. conceal their emotions.

Ans: (a) fool each other.

A Sunny Morning Comprehension III :

1.Trace how the irony is built in the play. Did you guess the character's past even before they did so?

Ans: (a) The term 'irony' means 'hiding' or dissembling what actually is the case, not in order to deceive but to achieve special rhetorical or artistic effects.

In the one-act play, 'A Sunny Morning' irony is cleverly built into the play. After settling in her bench, Dona Laura sends away Petra, her maidservant, to chat with the guard.

Soon after that, she glances towards the trees at right and says "Here they come; they know just when to expect me". Though the old lady is referring to the arrival of the birds, it also hints at the entry of Don Gonzalo and Juanito, who are needed for the action to move forward. Dona Laura throws three handfuls of crumbs for the pigeons to eat and soon after that we see Don Gonzalo and Juanito entering the scene.

(b) We come across the next instance of irony when Don Gonzalo starts reading aloud statements supposedly from Campoamor's work.

Don Gonzalo reads aloud the following:

"All love is sad but sad as it is, it is the best thing that we know".

"Twenty years pass. He returns. And each, beholding the other, exclaims can it be that this is he? Heavens, is it she?"

These lines can be taken as examples of 'Dramatic irony'.

(c) There are two more instances of irony in the play. They are:

1. When Dona Laura tells Don Gonzalo that Laura Llorente was called 'The Silver Maiden' in » that locality, he tells her "I seem to see her as if she were before me now, at that window with the red roses".

2. He starts giving a description of her beauty, "She was ideal, fair as a lily, jet black hair and black eyes..." and finally says "what forms of sovereign beauty God models in human clay! She was a dream".

On hearing Don Gonzalo say so, Dona Laura mutters to herself "if you but knew that dream was now by your side, you would realize what dreams come to".

3. "Here are you and I, complete strangers, met by chance, discussing the romance of old friends of long ago! We have been conversing as if we were old friends", Dona Laura tells Don Gonzalo after both of them have told their made-up stories.

A careful reading of the play reveals that there is a relationship between the old lady and the old gentleman. When I read the play a second time paying attention to the story and the instances of irony highlighted here, I was able to guess the characters' past.

**2. Why do Dona Laura and Don Gonzalo spin fictitious stories about themselves?
OR**

Dona Laura and Don Gonzalo spin fictitious stories about themselves to cover their tracks. Discuss with reference to 'A Sunny Morning'.

Ans: Once Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura realize that they are the same old, young lovers of Maricela who were separated in life by fate, they decide not to reveal their identity because they learn from each other in what high esteem they held each other before they departed, they also come to know that both of them had given up the other as lost forever. While Dona Laura tells herself that she had married someone else after waiting for him for one year, Don Gonzalo tells himself that after fleeing from Valencia, then Seville and Madrid, he had run off to Paris with a ballet dancer in about three months.

Therefore, they concoct fictitious stories so as to conceal their identities completely and to make the other believe that he or she was dead. Later, when they realize that they are alive, they do not want to shatter their mutual images in the eyes of the other. Therefore, Don Gonzalo tells himself that he will not reveal himself because he is grotesque. He wishes that she had better recall the gallant horseman who passed daily beneath her window tossing flowers. Similarly, Dona Laura tells herself that "I am too sadly changed. It is better he should remember me as the black-eyed girl tossing flowers as he passed among the roses in the garden."

3. Bring out the feelings of Laura and Gonzalo as they leave the park. Is it different from what they felt about each other at the beginning of the play?

Ans: When the scene opens, we find Dona Laura entering the park, leaning upon the arm of her maid Petra. Soon, the old lady settles in her usual seat in the park. Then the old lady sends away Petra to meet her boyfriend, the guard. Later, when the pigeons arrive, Dona Laura throws three handfuls of bread crumbs. Next, we see Don Gonzalo coming in dragging his feet and leaning upon Juanito's arm. Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura have not seen each other before and hence we cannot know about each other's feelings until they meet.

However, their feelings towards each other become evident only when Don Gonzalo walks towards Dona Laura's bench, despite her warning call 'Lookout'. Therefore, when she finds her pigeons being scared away, she is upset and tells him in a complaining tone that he has scared away the birds who were feeding on her crumbs. In reply, Don gives an arrogant reply which provokes her to make a personal comment, 'Why do you complain that the priests have taken your bench?' Once again, Don Gonzalo's rude snubbing reply provokes Dona Laura to say that he is an ill-natured old man and comments that when people reach a certain age they should not become so fussy and cross. Later, Don comes and sits at the extreme end of Dona Laura's bench and looks at her indignantly. After a few heated exchanges between them, Don Gonzalo mutters to himself 'Senile old lady! She ought to be at home knitting and counting her beads'.

But, by the end of the play, we find a total change in their attitude towards each other. In the course of their conversation, they discover that they were 'lovers' once in their youthful days. But neither of them is ready to disclose their identity. However, the animosity that we witness at the beginning of the play is no longer there when they are ready to depart. Before taking leave of each other, they formally thank each other for having met. Both of them ensure that they are coming to the park the next day. Laura sees Don picking up the lilies dropped by her. Both of them wave farewell. They leave the place as friends.

4.What do you think would have happened if they had revealed their identity? Do you think they know who they are towards the end of the play?

Ans: Once Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura realize that they are the same old young lovers of Maricela who were separated in life by fate, they make up fictitious stories and conceal their identity.

If they had revealed their identity, both of them would have been utterly shocked and would have accused each other of deceiving the other. They know that both of them had held the other in high esteem and both of them had fallen deeply in love.

That is why, when they realize that they are the same old lovers of Maricela, they are shocked to realize how much both of them had changed. Dona Laura after listening to Don Gonzalo's praise of her beauty as 'The Silver Maiden' now feels ashamed to confess that she is the old silver maiden of Maricela because she too is sadly changed. Similarly, Don Gonzalo knows that he is grotesque and so wishes her to keep his image as a gallant horseman who tossed flowers to her every day.

5.How is the title of the play 'A Sunny Morning' justifiable? Discuss.

OR

Bring out the instances from the play A Sunny Morning' to justify it as a blend of romance and comedy.

Ans: 'A Sunny Morning' is a refreshingly new romantic comedy. It tells the story of Don Gonzalo and Dona Laura who were ardent lovers in their youth but were torn apart in life by fate. However, the two lovers meet again when they are in their 70s, not as lovers but as total strangers unexpectedly, in a park in Madrid. After a few initial heated exchanges and repartees, they settle down, occupy the same bench in the park, spend a good time together and depart as friends. By the time they are ready to leave for the day, they recognize each other's identity. They do not disclose it but tell atrocious lies to conceal it. There are quite a few lively moments of humor, sarcasm, and irony which entertain the readers and audience. The title 'A Sunny Morning' is quite appropriate and aptly captures the spirit of the play. The play can be justifiably called a romantic comedy because there are elements of both romance and comedy in the play.

In its most general sense the word 'romance' suggests elements of gallant love, chivalry, and adventure. The phrase 'romantic comedy' denotes a form of drama in which love is the main theme and love leads to a happy ending. A love affair is one of the major themes of a comedy. Keeping in view these points, 'A Sunny Morning' is a romantic comedy in all respects. It tells the story of two young lovers Laura Llorente and Don Gonzalo of Maricela in Valencia.

Laura Llorente was known in her locality as 'The Silver Maiden'. She was in love with Gonzalo, a gallant lover. He used to pass by her house on horseback every morning through the rose garden and toss up a bouquet of flowers to her balcony which she caught. On his way back in the afternoon she would toss the flowers back to him. But Laura's parents wanted to marry her off to a merchant whom she disliked.

One day there ensued a quarrel, leading to a duel between Gonzalo and the merchant, her suitor. The merchant was seriously injured. Fearing serious consequences, Gonzalo fled from his house in the town to Seville and then to Madrid. Even though he tried to communicate with Laura through letters, his attempts failed and he gave her up as lost forever and ran off to Paris with a ballet dancer. Meanwhile, Laura waited for the news of Gonzalo, for one year and finally got married.

These two lovers meet unexpectedly, in a park. They are now in their 70s. Both of them have changed a lot physically but they still cherish the memories of their youth.

However, when they meet in the park, they appear to be cynical, fussy, and ill-natured. The way they repartee and express their resentment towards each other creates opportunities for humour in the play. Finally, they become friends after sharing a pinch

of snuff. They gradually come to realize that they are the very same lovers of yesteryears.

The title 'A Sunny Morning' suggests a warm and bright sunny day. Similarly, the play is also fresh in spirit, devoid of all cliches and stereotypes of earlier, traditional courtly comedies because both the characters and the situations are drawn from contemporary society.

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When You Are Old - W.B. Yeats

A Note On The Poet :

William Butler Yeats (1865 – 1939) is an Irish poet and one of the foremost figures of 20th-century literature. His early poetry is part of the Celtic twilight or the Irish Literary Revival and it uses the history, myths, and heroic figures of Ireland. Yeats wrote plays, was one of the founders of the Abbey Theatre in Dublin, and was witness to the revolutionary politics of Ireland. He was awarded the Nobel Prize for literature in 1923. Later, under the influence of Ezra Pound, he began to write modernist poetry. He is one of the great love poets of the world.

In this love poem, the speaker (who is the lover) imagines his beloved in the future when she is old and reading the book of poems he is now writing. Reading the book she will remember the past, her youthful beauty, and the many who admired her. While the others loved her physical beauty and grace, only he loved her soul and her soul's search for something meaningful. However, she will also feel sad that that love also vanished.

Note how love is personified in the last lines.

Background :

Most critics opine that this poem is a real description of the poet's love. In 1889 Yeats met his great love Maud Gonne, an actress, and Irish revolutionary. However, she married Major John Macbride in 1903, and this episode inspired Yeats to write down this heart-stirring poem. Many critics believe that the poem presents the resentment he feels towards her for not reciprocating his love. The ambiguity of the last stanza of the poem illustrates that the poem is not only about the regret the woman feels when she becomes aware of what she has lost, it also strengthens the argument that this work is actually about the resentment he wants the woman to perceive.

When You Are Old Summary :

'When You Are Old' was written to express the writer's true and unforgettable love. The theme is a painful one of unrequited love, which the poet manipulates in an interesting manner. Instead of focusing upon the present or the past, the poet looks to the future, a

future in which the two people in the poem are destined to be forever apart. The poet imagines an unreal condition that the woman he loved became old and felt regret for refusing his true love.

That is why the poem begins with the presumption that an old and grey lady was sitting beside the fire nodding her head. She is imagined to be reminiscing her memories when she recalls the soft look that her eyes had once, and how many suitors tried to court her, being charmed by her elegance and beauty.

While admitting that many suitors were attracted by her youthful beauty, the speaker tries to tell her that he was the only lover who loved the pilgrim soul in her. He wants her to know that he was attracted by the beauty of her inner self and his love would remain constant even after she grows old. He assures her that he loves even the sorrows of her changing face. He means to say that over a period of time her beauty will have faded away and she will have grown old with her face having shrunk and skin having been wrinkled indicating that she has passed through many difficulties and sorrows.

He concludes visualizing that she is now bending down beside the dying fire, and tells herself in a whisper in a regretful tone that her true love has fled and is hiding his face amid a crowd of stars.

Analysis of the Poem :

‘When You Are Old’ is a short, exquisite, love lyric of twelve lines. It is a sad and introspective poem and is written in a melancholic tone.

The poem is in the form of a direct address by a lover to his lady love. In the poem, there are three stanzas of four lines each with a constant rhyme. The rhyme scheme hints that the speaker/ lover tries to tell her that his love will remain constant even when she grows old.

The most important aspect of this poem is the point of view taken by the narrator. The narrator is asking a woman, who is still young, to imagine a time when she is past her prime youth.

**When you are old and gray and full of sleep,
And nodding by the fire, take down this book,
And slowly read, and dream of the soft look
Your eyes had once, and of their shadows deep;**

The poet tries to put her mind in the future when she is an 'old and gray' woman, 'full of sleep', to 'slowly read' a book of memories from her youth. As the woman is 'nodding by the fire' she leafs through the book (her memories) and recollects her days of 'soft looks' and 'sorrows' as she changed.

**How many loved your moments of glad grace,
And loved your beauty with love false or true,
But one man loved the pilgrim soul in you.
And loved the sorrows of your changing face;**

She remembers her faded beauty that was admired by many but then recalls the only man, the narrator, who loved her for her unique soul. He loved her even as she grew less beautiful and as her personality changed in the fullness of time. The alliteration 'glad grace' expresses that when she is young, beautiful and in her best moments of life many will be interested in her, but their love for her will be just false or superficial love. However, the narrator (speaker) will love her anyway no matter what happens to her beauty.

The line "and loved the sorrows of your changing face" suggests that when she gets old her face gets shrunk. So her face looks different but he will just love her with the same love he always had. There is also a contrast between 'glad grace' and 'sorrows of your changing face', which suggests that while the others love her in her happy times, he will love her every time, including the worst ones.

The phrase 'pilgrim soul' in the line, "but one man loved the pilgrim soul in you," refers to the long walk that her soul has had, searching for real happiness, but really being alone. So, many lovers can love her for how she looks but only he can love her for who she really is. 'Pilgrim Soul' has reference to the Biblical belief that every soul is a pilgrim, on the way to salvation and redemption. The speaker, by referring to this aspect of the beloved rather than to her beauty and fame, evokes oneness with the inner and not the external self.

**And bending down beside the glowing bars,
Murmur, a little sadly, how Love fled
And paced upon the mountains overhead
And hid his face amid a crowd of stars.**

In this stanza, the speaker exhorts the loved one to remember him in later years as she sits beside the fire and bends over the embers of the fire. The onomatopoeic 'murmur' suggests a whisper that shows that she has no passion or zest left. This adds to the

imagery of age and weariness. 'A little sadly' suggests that in later years, as she remembers the speaker, she should feel regretful. The poet uses the word 'love' in all the lines in the second stanza and in the third stanza, second line, he capitalizes the word 'Love', giving it much intensity. He personifies 'Love' in the second line. In the lines,

**And paced upon the mountains overhead
And hid his face amid a crowd of stars**

'pacing' suggests that she was given a chance as 'Love' waited for her; it also suggests the gradual diminishing of the love which may then loiter over mountains for a while and then disappear. Being on the 'mountains overhead' suggests that 'Love' waited on a higher plain than that which she inhabited. Capitalized 'L' for love suggests that it is not just a person that she has lost but the ultimate, true, and everlasting possibility of love.

The phrase 'how love fled' refers to the possibility that the speaker's love would just fly far away because she is not receptive to his love.

When You are Old Comprehension I :

1.The speaker is addressing

- a. a young woman he has loved
- b. an old woman that he has met now
- c. the woman that he has admired in his life.

Ans: (a) a young woman he has loved.

2.Inline two, the word 'book' refers to

- a. memories
- b. book of poems
- c. an album
- d. diary.

Ans: (a) memories.

3.The words 'glad grace' suggest

- a. her physical beauty
- b. her inner beauty
- c. her goodness.

Ans: (a) her physical beauty.

4.'Pilgrim soul' means the soul

- a. which is immortal
- b. that has gone on a pilgrimage
- c. which is questing for true love.

Ans: (c) which is questing for true love.

5.What does the phrase 'your changing face' suggest?

Ans: It suggests that her youth and beauty will fade away. When she grows old her face will get shrunk and will look different.

6.'Love fled' connotes

- a. the death of the man who loved her
- b. the fleeing of her lover to the mountains
- c. the loss endured by her.

Ans: (b) the fleeing of her lover to the mountains.

When You Are Old Comprehension II :

1.How is the 'one-man' different from the many others who loved the lady?

OR

How does the speaker distinguish/contrast his love from/with that of the others?

Ans: The narrator/speaker asks his lady love to presume that she has grown old and grey and is sitting by the fire nodding. Then he asks her to read from her book of memories and reminisce her past when she was in her prime youth. While she is thus engaged in recalling her past, the poet reminds her that though she undoubtedly had a great many suitors who admired her beauty and elegance and professed 'love' which may be true or false, he alone loved her unconditionally.

He says that he loved her inner beauty and even the fading away of her youth and beauty. The phrase 'how many' in the first line (second stanza) stands in contrast to 'But one man', in the third line (second stanza). While many suitors loved her beauty and elegance, he alone loved her pilgrim soul as well as the sorrows of her changing face.

2.How does the poem bring out the transient nature of beauty as against the permanence of love?

Ans: Yes. The poem, while making an attempt to persuade the young lady not to ignore him or his love, also incidentally highlights the transient nature of beauty as against the permanence of love. In fact, the speaker's argument is that, whereas all her suitors are merely attracted by her youthful beauty and elegance, he is attracted by her pilgrim soul. Furthermore, he claims that the love exhibited by her many suitors may not last long and might change as she grows old.

On the contrary, his love will remain constant and unconditional. He would love her 'pilgrim soul' as well as the changes in her face which appear as one grows old. Thus, the poet, using the phrase 'your moments of glad grace' in the first line of the second stanza in contrast with the phrase 'sorrows of your changing face' in the fourth line suggests that 'beauty' is transient in nature whereas 'love' is permanent.

When You Are Old Comprehension III :

1.Comment on the usage of the time frame by the poet in 'When You Are Old'.

OR

'The speaker addresses a young lady in her old age'. Comment on the time sequence used by the poet.

OR

The speaker in 'When You Are Old' is not addressing an old lady. Explain.

Ans: 'When You Are Old' is a short love poem in which the poet uses a time frame in

which the speaker addresses his lady love in the present, takes her to an unreal condition in the future, and asks her to recall her past memories. He does so, in order to persuade her or warn her not to ignore him and make a wrong decision.

The poet's point of view is the most compelling point of the poem. The narrator is calling upon a woman that is not yet through with youth to, once past her prime, recall the days he was in her life and very much in love with her. Obviously, he wants her to remember him for his unique and unconditional love for her, and how she is choosing to ignore it in the present. By writing this poem in this fashion, the woman, when the poet hopes that she grows old, will remember the days when she was young with happiness but will grow regretful that she did not take advantage of his love.

Alternatively, the woman, in the present will see what an opportunity she is missing by ignoring his love for her and leaving him to fade into the past. The speaker fears that his lady love will not act upon his love for her and that she will only remember him in the book of memories. He hopes that if, once old, she puts down the book of memories, she will grow chilly and sorrowful that she did not foresee how steadfast his love was but how foolish she was for taking no notice of it. He is already fearful that she will grow old without him, and this can be seen as he requests that she remember him a 'little sadly' and as a missed chance to have a happy future.

It is the time frame that the poet has used in this poem that facilitates the poet to write this sad and reminiscent poem which is not designed primarily to make an old woman regretful, but to keep a young woman from ignoring the narrator and making the wrong decision.

2. 'When You Are Old' is a poem of contrasts. What purpose do they serve?

Ans: 'When You Are Old' was written to show the true and unforgettable love from the writer. The theme is a painful one of unrequited love, which the poet manipulates in an interesting manner. Instead of focusing upon the present or the past, Yeats looks to the future, a future in which the two people in the poem are destined to be forever apart. The poet visualizes an unreal condition that the woman he loved became old and felt regret for refusing his true love.

To depict such a theme, the poet deploys elegant and quiet words and builds pictures of contrasts:

In the first stanza, there is a contrast between her elegant youth and her depressing old age. In the second stanza, there is a contrast between her many suitors who professed superficial love and the speaker or the lover who promises true love for her. In the third

stanza, there is a contrast between the fleeting or transient love represented by her many suitors and the personified love of the poet.

There is a contrast between 'the sorrows of your changing face' in the second stanza and 'murmur a little sadly' of the third stanza. 'The sorrows' indicate passion or strong emotion is seen in young people and 'little sadly' reflects the listlessness of old people. There is a contrast between the 'beauty and elegance' sans her soul sought after by the suitors and the 'pilgrim soul' in the same lady cherished by the speaker. The many suitors who wanted to court her were attracted by her superficial beauty whereas this lover/speaker was attracted by her pilgrim soul, which symbolizes her inner self. These contrasts serve to build a strong argument to persuade the young lady not to ignore him now and regret later.

The Gardener - P. Lankesh

A Note On The Writer :

P. Lankesh [1935-2000] is an Indian writer and journalist who wrote in Kannada. After graduating with an honours degree in English from Central College at Bangalore, he completed his Master of Arts degree in English from Maharaja College, Mysore. P.

Lankesh's first work was 'Kereya Neeranu Kerege Chelli', a collection of short stories published in 1963. This was followed by several collections of short stories and poetry, three novels, critical essays, translations (including Charles Baudelaire's 'Les Fleurs du Mai', 'Oedipus Rex', and Sophocles' 'Antigone'), as well as several plays and films. His 1976 film 'Pallavi' – a cinematic narration, told from the female protagonist's point of view and based on his novel 'Biruku' – won India's national award for best direction.

The Gardener Summary :

[This short story is the translated English version of 'Thotadavanu', taken from 'When Stone Melts and Other Stories', a collection of short stories published by Sahitya Academi. It is translated into English by H.S. Raghavendra Rao.]

It is said that in these short stories Lankesh shows his preoccupation with human meanness and attempts to explore the evolution of a post-Emergency political and cultural scenario. The title 'When Stone Melts' refers to the mystery at the heart of every transformation, the invisible and inescapable play of history and location that engender the process of change.

The narrator addresses the reader directly in the first person asking for an apology for being brief. He says that the story was conceived in a flash and hence if he elaborates it, the story will lose its vitality. There are only four characters, besides the narrator: Tammanna, Basavaiah or Sangoji, and the owner of the coconut grove and his wife.

There are two stories in this story. The first story is narrated by the author in the first person and the second story is narrated by Tammanna who is also the protagonist in the first story. In the second story, the narrator/protagonist tells his own story to the lady distancing himself from the main story.

The narrator says that this story originated in his chance encounter with an old man who was standing in a coconut grove near Chennarayapatna. The old man (who had been employed in the coconut grove), was a labourer, overseer and philosopher, all rolled into one.

One day the old man came to the coconut garden after walking hundreds of miles. Since the owner of that plantation needed a person of his qualifications, he hired him immediately after talking to him for a few minutes. Thus the old man became an employee in the coconut grove and stayed on. The old man did useful work. He was so well-versed in agriculture that he easily understood the problems of workers. The petty thefts in the garden came to an end, and naturally, the income from the garden improved dramatically. Consequently, the increase in income brought a perceptible change in the lifestyle of the owner. The plantation expanded, but the owner became lazy and shied away from hard work.

The owner's wife found the owner's behaviour strange and puzzling. She found it hard to decide whether the old man's arrival was for the better or for the worse. Her husband's wealth and social prestige had risen higher, and he had acquired a great number of friends in his own village and in the next town as well. Even though he did not do any useful work, his life became crowded with colourful events. On account of his newly acquired clout, he cultivated umpteen other vices including adultery. Though their farm was initially merely ten acres, it had grown beyond their imagination.

Therefore, the owner's wife realized that financially they had been doing well but her only source of worry was that along with financial improvement, their life was also gradually getting out of hand. Thus, one day when she was in a fix like this, the old man met her. He smiled at her, brought down an offering of coconuts from a nearby tree, and sat on the embankment of the well. She had no alternative and so she sat next to him. The old man now begins his narrative and takes the action or plot to its climax.

The old man says that, in a far off place, once there lived a man called Tammanna. He had everything: ten acres of land, a comfortable house, and people too ready to carry out his orders or instructions. Besides these possessions, he also had a rival and his name was Sangoji. However, soon after uttering the name Sangoji, the old man started fumbling for words as if he had committed a mistake. The coconut grove owner's wife, who was listening, felt that it was none of her concern and felt like going away immediately. But, not wishing to hurt the old man, she continued to sit there quietly.

The old man continued his story. He corrected himself once, saying his name was not Sangoji but Basavaiah. [At this moment in the story, the narrator gives a hint to the

reader that the old man is telling a true account of his own experience disguising it in the form of a story].

Both Tammanna and Basavaiah were rivals. If Tammanna bought four more acres adjacent to his land, Basavaiah would also do the same. If one of them had ten friends, the other would acquire ' fifteen admirers. Though initially, all this looked like healthy competition, it took a nasty turn later.

Their rivalry rose to such a pitch that there was no land left in the village for them to buy. All land belonged to either Tammanna or Basavaiah. Tammanna had one thousand acres and Basavaiah eight hundred. Basavaiah could not tolerate this. His men asked Tammanna to sell two hundred acres but Tammanna refused to do so. On the other hand, Tammanna offered to buy all the land that belonged to Basavaiah. Basavaiah became furious. He went along with his people and acquired two hundred acres of Tammanna's land forcibly, and got it fenced up all around. Tammanna could not put up with this invasion.

Tammanna's advisers told him that there were three ways by which Tammanna could get back his land. He could go to the court of law or he could also take recourse to the police. If he did not like to do, either way, he could also use muscle power to get his land back. There was any number of persons ready to attack Basavaiah and wrest his land from him. But Tammanna was in search of a method that could destroy Basavaiah completely. Tammanna got all his experiences composed in the form of ballads and sang them in public. Their rivalry moved away from the visible to the invisible.

Basavaiah could not do the same way. He tried to show his rivalry in doing agricultural tasks more diligently, but that was also in vain. Meanwhile, Tammanna's reputation started spreading all around. His songs started making mention of Basavaiah's cruelty and his meanness. Scholars and critics went after his songs and earned their share of fame. Basavaiah became desperate and angry and retaliated by encroaching on more and more of Tammanna's land. But Tammanna was ignorant of all this and blissfully enjoyed his singing. Art had become the *raison d'être* of his life. He was even felicitated as the best poet of his times.

Basavaiah felt humiliated, which he tried to hide by acquiring all kinds of luxuries. He got a palatial mansion built for himself; appointed a number of people to praise him and bedecked himself with gold, diamonds, and other precious stones. But his house looked dull and empty because Tammanna's books were not there. He attempted to fill the lacuna by inviting scholars, poets, and musicians to his place. This way, he tried to invest his home with meaning.

One day, Basavaiah came to know that Tammanna was ill. The news made him happy. At that point, Basavaiah found the means of surpassing Tammanna. Health is wealth. Tammanna's disease was Basavaiah's health. But Tammanna thought differently. He had thought of yet another method of punishing Basavaiah. Tammanna contemplated 'death'. As long as he continued his rivalry at the level of the body, Basavaiah would go on offering stiff competition. But, if he died, Basavaiah could do nothing to defeat him. The old man ends his storytelling the coconut garden owner's wife that wishing to destroy Basavaiah completely, Tammanna gave up everything and ran off from his village.

As long as Tammanna was there, Basavaiah had a reason to be alive, but once Tammanna left the place Basavaiah passed away. The old man tells the lady that Basavaiah died because he had no reason to live. Then he confesses to her that he is Tammanna himself. After Basavaiah's death, Tammanna tells the lady that he forgot all his songs and ballads, lost his fame, and became a non-entity. He concludes telling her that, that way he avenged himself.

Tammanna tells the woman that the experiences of his life had made him realize that human nature is very strange. He sums up his experiences in one sentence. He tells her that though man works to fulfill his many needs like wealth, education, art, and many more things, yet those things do not give him the right, compelling reasons to live. All through his life man lives for some kind of unbearable vengefulness. It is in this vengefulness that he finds a reason for his existence.

Finally, using his autobiographical account as an example, the old man. tries to covertly give her a message. He tells her that her husband was flourishing as a rich man and was not amenable to any advice. Man is so complicated that till the day of his death, he goes on living for some revenge or the other, confronting one challenge or the other. He wants her to understand that she had better try to understand why her husband is living like that.

Finally, he asks her to take the whole story as a dream and not to take his words seriously. We can infer here that he is saddened by the coconut grove owner's lifestyle and wants to put an end to it by cautioning the lady about her husband and do something to find out why her husband was doing so. As soon as the old man finishes his story, the first narrator reappears and tells the reader that he had seen all this in a dream and hence he is unable to elaborate.

The Gardener Comprehension I :

1.What qualities of the old man impressed the narrator?

Ans: The old man impressed the narrator by his eyes suffused with strange memories and native intelligence. He had strong muscular arms, grey hairs and a beak-like nose. He had a newspaper tucked under his arm and a spade in his hands. The narrator felt the old man was a labourer, overseer and philosopher all rolled into one – a multi-dimensional personality.

2.Is it a significant factor that the old man came to the garden after walking hundreds of miles?

Ans: Yes. The narrator learns from the old man that he had come to that garden after he had walked hundreds of miles. This fact becomes significant because, when he left his place, his intention was to die but once he came there the coconut grove and the place probably convinced him that he could live there comfortably. Moreover, before reaching this place he may have received the news of Basavaiah's death and must have realized that life or death had no meaning for him. This transformation in his mindset may have prompted him to settle there.

3.The owner of the garden became lethargic because

- a. the income of the garden improved dramatically.
- b. he had become dependent upon the gardener.
- c. there was nothing much left for the owner to do.

Ans: (c) there was nothing much left for the owner to do.

4.Why did the owner's wife start worrying about the strange ways of her husband?

Ans: The owner of the coconut plantation was quite normal. He was working hard to bring about improvement in his earnings. Probably he had little expertise in managing agricultural workers. Therefore, he was looking for someone who would help him. That is why, the moment he spoke to the old man (Tamanna) he felt that he had got the kind of man he wanted. His expectations proved right and the old man helped him in every way and solved all his problems, which eventually resulted in increase in his income.

Once his worries disappeared and he had hardly any work to engage himself in, his personal attention went towards acquiring property and social prestige. It is quite natural that with social prestige also follow certain vices among which adultery was one. Adultery affects any woman. All along, her husband had been faithful to her and once his wife came to know that he was spending his money and time with other women, she

got seriously worried. She found it hard to decide whether the arrival of the old man had done good or bad to her husband.

5. When did the old man decide to narrate his story?

Ans: The old man, who had settled there in the coconut plantation for good, had watched the activities of the owner. Initially, the owner used to show interest in improving his plantation. Once the old man had solved all the problems, the owner had plenty of leisure and he became lazy. Secondly, he had more money which led him to expand his plantation. Then he had turned his gaze towards acquiring property and social prestige. Then he cultivated certain vices among which adultery was one.

One day, he saw the owner's wife in the plantation. He saw her looking worried. He guessed that her husband's activities had given her the worries. Therefore, when he saw her in the plantation he thought he should narrate his own story and try to caution her about her husband. He had understood the way we face ups and downs in our life. By doing so, he probably believed that she might be able to convince her husband about his mistakes and set his life right.

6. Tammanna considers his rival, Sangoji/Basavaiah, an important possession because

- a. competition helps in the development of an individual.
- b. Sangoji/Basavaiah leads a more colourful life.
- c. rivalry offers new possibilities of life for him.

Ans: (c) rivalry offers new possibilities of life for him.

7. "No, his name was not Sangoji, but Basavaiah," said the old man because

- a. he had really forgotten the name.
- b. he wanted to keep the identity of his rival a secret
- c. he was fictionalizing his past.

Ans: (c) he was fictionalizing his past.

8. What unique strategy did Tammanna conceive to annihilate Basavaiah?

Ans: When Tammanna came to know that Basavaiah had forcibly acquired two hundred acres of his land, he could not tolerate this invasion. Though his supporters explained to him all the means available to him, he was not satisfied with them because he knew that sooner or later Basavaiah would again try to outdo him by hook or by crook. Tammanna did not want Basavaiah to trouble him again. So, he hit on a unique plan. He took recourse to singing ballads and telling the people through them about the cruelty and the meanness of Basavaiah. This way he thought he could annihilate him completely.

9. Why does Basavaiah start inviting scholars and musicians to his place?

OR

How did Basavaiah try to overcome his humiliation?

Ans: Once Tammanna started making mention of Basavaiah's cruelty and meanness in his songs, Tammanna became very popular among scholars of folklore and critics. Basavaiah watched all this in humiliation. Basavaiah tried to redress his humiliation by acquiring material wealth. He bedecked himself with gold, diamonds and other precious stones, and started living in a palatial mansion. But the visitors to his house told him that his house looked dull and empty because Tammanna's books were not there. Basavaiah thought of investing his home with meaning by inviting scholars, poets and musicians to his place.

10. What was Basavaiah's ray of hope in his attempts to outwit Tammanna?

Ans: When Basavaiah failed in all his attempts to outwit Tammanna, he came to know that Tammanna had fallen ill. This news cheered up Basavaiah's spirits. This gave him a ray of hope that by keeping himself healthy he could outwit Tammanna who was ill. Tammanna's disease became Basavaiah's health.

11. Tammanna decides to give up everything and leave the place because of

- a. he sees no purpose in living there.
- b. he wants to create an impression that he is dead.
- c. he wants to put an end to the rivalry.

Ans: (b) he wants to create an impression that he is dead.

12. Tammanna forgets his songs and ballads because

- a. he finds them futile.
- b. he doesn't need them anymore.
- c. he avenges himself.

Ans: (b) he doesn't need them anymore.

The Gardener Comprehension II :

1. How did the owner's lifestyle change after the arrival of the old man?

OR

"The old man's stay on the farm led to many changes in the owner's lifestyle."

Illustrate with details from the short story to support this statement.

Ans: The owner had been working hard to improve his plantation, but there were many problems which he had not been able to solve. However, when the old man met him, he came to know that the old man was well-versed in agriculture and had native

intelligence. Therefore he appointed him immediately. His expectations proved right. The old man proved his worth in solving all the problems. Consequently, the income from the garden improved dramatically. This caused a perceptible change in the lifestyle of the owner. He expanded his plantation.

However, he became lethargic and shied away from hard work. His wealth and social prestige also increased. He acquired a number of friends in the next town as well as in his own village. Even though he had precious little to do, his life became crowded with colourful events. He cultivated umpteen vices including adultery.

2.What advice did the supporters of Tammanna give for getting back his land?

Ans: When Basavaiah acquired Tammanna's two hundred acres forcibly, Tammanna could not tolerate this invasion. Tammanna's supporters advised him about the various methods available for getting back his land. They told him that he could go to the court of law. He could also take recourse to the police. If he did not want to do either, there were any number of persons ready to attack Basavaiah and using force and violence to wrest his land from him.

3.How did Tammanna react to Basavaiah's encroachment of his land?

Ans: When Tammanna came to know that Basavaiah had forcibly taken away two hundred acres of his land, he could not tolerate this invasion. When his supporters advised him to either go to the court or seek the help of the police or ask some persons to attack Basavaiah and take back his land forcibly, Tammanna hit on a unique idea, of annihilating Basavaiah. He thought of getting all his experiences composed in the form of ballads and telling the people through them about the cruelty and the meanness of Basavaiah.

4.How did Basavaiah try to overcome his humiliation?

Ans: When Tammanna started singing ballads through which he told the people about Basavaiah's cruelty and his meanness, he became very popular. Many scholars of folklore and literary critics translated his songs and earned their share of the fame. All this made Basavaiah shrink in humiliation. However, he tried to redress his humiliation by acquiring more material wealth and luxuries. He got a palatial mansion built for himself. He appointed a number of persons just to praise him. He bedecked himself with gold, diamonds, and other precious stones. He even started inviting scholars, poets and musicians to his place with the intention of investing his home with meaning.

The Gardener Comprehension III :

1.The rivalry between Tammanna and Basavaiah keeps moving from the visible domain to the invisible. Comment.

Ans: In the beginning, there appeared to be a healthy competition between Tammanna and Basavaiah. Tammanna did not take Basavaiah as his rival at all. Therefore, when Basavaiah acquired fifteen admirers to outdo Tammanna's ten friends, it did not come to Tammanna's notice at all. Tammanna did whatever he wanted without bothering about Basavaiah. But Basavaiah did not keep quiet. When he came to know that Tammanna possessed one thousand acres of land, and he had only eight hundred, he could not tolerate this. He sent word to Tammanna asking him to sell two hundred acres to him. Tammanna did not agree.

On the contrary, he offered to buy all the land that belonged to Basavaiah. Therefore, Basavaiah went along with his people and acquired two hundred acres of Tammanna's land forcibly and got a fence built around it. Tammanna could not tolerate this invasion. Later, when his supporters suggested to him that he could go to the court of law or the police or use his own people to attack him and forcibly wrest his land from him, Tammanna did not accept their suggestion. Tammanna probably thought that competing with Basavaiah by physical means has no end to it because it depends on who is able to muster more muscle power. Muscle power has its own limitations. Secondly, muscle power needs the involvement of many more people apart from Tammanna.

Moreover, as long as both of them were fighting by visible means people will not know who was trying to compete with whom. Until then, Basavaiah was the first one to show to the people he had more land, more friends, more wealth, etc. Tammanna never did anything to spite Basavaiah. Whatever Tammanna did, was on his natural inclination and not to spite Basavaiah. Therefore, Tammanna realized the limitations of competing with Basavaiah by physical means. That is why he thought of putting an end to the unhealthy rivalry of Basavaiah by taking recourse to something invisible. He took recourse to singing ballads and telling the people through them about the cruelty and the meanness of Basavaiah.

2.How does Tammanna adopt a counter-strategy to challenge the material wealth of Basavaiah?

Ans: When Tammanna came to know that the rivalry between him and Basavaiah had reached a peak and that two hundred acres of his land had been forcibly taken away from him and had been even fenced up, Tammanna hit on a plan of annihilating Basavaiah completely. He got all his bitter experiences with Basavaiah composed in the form of ballads and started singing them before the people, announcing to everyone Basavaiah's cruelty and his meanness. This way his reputation as an artist started

spreading fast and critics and scholars of folklore thronged him and translated his songs.

3.Tammanna turns reflective in the course of his life. What does this tell us about human nature?

Ans: 'The Gardener' is the story of Tammanna, an old man, now employed in a coconut plantation. Though the story is initially narrated by the author, Tammanna himself becomes the narrator later. Tammanna is the protagonist in the story and he tells the story of the rivalry between two farmers Tammanna and Basavaiah. Though Tammanna is one of the characters in the story, the narrator does not disclose his identity till the end. The second narrator tells us that Tammanna was a farmer, had ten acres of land, a comfortable house and people too ready to carry out his orders. Then he tells us about his rival Basavaiah.

We learn from the narrator that Tammanna did not perceive Basavaiah as his rival initially. Tammanna led a normal life and became prosperous gradually and came to possess 1000 acres of land. Until some point whatever Basavaiah did to keep himself on par with Tammanna was seen as healthy competition.

But, one day, Basavaiah asks Tammanna to sell him his two hundred acres of land and Tammanna refuses. Basavaiah takes the land forcibly. Though there were various options available for getting his land back, Tammanna searches for a method that could annihilate Basavaiah completely. Instead of proving might is right or seeking justice from the court of law, Tammanna uses a different strategy. He composes and sings ballads about Basavaiah's meanness and cruelty. Very soon Tammanna becomes very popular and Basavaiah has no answer to his brainy ideas.

Secondly, Tammanna having found meaningful engagement in 'art' forgets Basavaiah's bad deeds. Just when Basavaiah is contemplating what to do next to spite Tammanna, he comes to know that Tammanna is ill. Basavaiah is pleased with the news. But their rivalry does not end there. Tammanna decides to outbeat him by manipulating the situation itself. He gives up everything and goes away to Chennarayapatna so as to spread the news that Tammanna is dead. Later Basavaiah dies a natural death. When Tammanna comes to know about his death, he becomes reflective. Though there is no cause-effect relationship between the rumour of Tammanna's death and Basavaiah's real death, Tammanna is shaken out of his senses.

Until then both Basavaiah and Tammanna indulged in rivalry to satisfy their ego. With the death of Basavaiah, Tammanna loses his identity and he becomes a non-entity.

This makes Tammanna reflect over human nature and comes to the conclusion that man needs some issue to fight for or cling on to. In this game, when the loser dies it is natural for the winner to feel guilty. He suffers from a sense of guilt that he was responsible for Basavaiah's death. Naturally, when Tammanna is accused by his own conscience, he becomes reflective. When one becomes reflective, one tends to review one's own actions objectively. We do not normally attach emotions to our thinking and then we discover what went wrong and where. Here, both Tammanna and Basavaiah have not done anything 'bad' intentionally. They only fought imaginary battles and lived in a dream world of their own.

Man is mortal and all the glory that man believes to enjoy is created by our mind. Man is a dreamer and lives in a dream world of his own. Since man's life has its own limitations, man's dream and reality rarely go in unison. When reality overtakes man, the man comes to realize that he is only a puppet in the scheme of things and man is in reality 'nothing', but builds up his own image to boost his confidence so that life becomes meaningful as long as he is alive.

4.How does the reference to Russia and America provide another dimension to the story?

Ans: 'The Gardener' presents the story of two farmers who get actively involved in rivalry and each one tries to overtake the other in earnings, wealth and social prestige. But, at one point, Basavaiah takes recourse to force and forcibly occupies a part of Tammanna's landholdings. Until now both of them had tried to upstage the other using tangible means. But now Tammanna realizes the limitations of muscle power and so uses his 'intellect' to unleash a strategy by which he wishes to annihilate Basavaiah completely. He gets all his bitter experiences with Basavaiah composed in the form of ballads and songs and sings them in public.

Thus, Tammanna tries to give a fitting reply to Basavaiah's use of physical force and so their fight takes a psychological dimension. Basavaiah fails to match up to the manipulatory tactics of Tammanna and shrinks in humiliation. However, he tries to console his wounded pride by indulging in luxurious living. No matter what he does, he does not succeed in upstaging Tammanna. It is at this stage higher forces play their own role. Tammanna falls ill and Basavaiah enjoys psychologically telling himself that Tammanna's disease is Basavaiah's health. This way, Basavaiah gets the satisfaction of finding a reason to keep himself happy. So, here the story has now passed from the physical dimension to the psychological dimension.

At this stage, Tammanna comes out with another plan. He plans to use something beyond man's life. Tammanna thinks that as long as Basavaiah knows that he is alive,

Basavaiah will continue to take him as his rival. So Tammanna hits on an idea which works at a level higher than the physical and psychological level. His plan is to beat Basavaiah on another plane, which is beyond man's limits. He knows for sure that if Basavaiah comes to think that Tammanna is dead, Basavaiah will stop treating him as his rival. Tammanna goes away to Chennarayapatna and spreads the news that Tammanna is dead. It is sheer coincidence that Basavaiah dies a natural death. But Tammanna comes to feel guilty that he was the cause of his death. This incident brings him back to his senses and he reflects over his life.

Now, after the death of Basavaiah, Tammanna has become a non-entity. When he reflects over their mutual game plans, Tammanna realizes that man invents several reasons to make his life meaningful. He also realizes that man can go on indulging in whims and fancies until a certain age only. Later, when the man comes to confront reality, he comes to see the truth. Then he becomes spiritual. That is when a man realizes his limitations. Thus we see the plot taking several dimensions from physical to psychological and then to spiritual.

But, this story also takes another dimension. Earlier, stories that used to focus on man's vices like cruelty, meanness, greed, jealousy, rivalry, etc., used to be portrayed on a smaller canvas and the stories used to be confined to people living in towns, cities and kingdoms. We are now in the post-modern society and the common man is now being influenced by global forces. In traditional societies, solutions to man's mundane, existential problems used to be found locally. A king or a Lord or a chieftain or a zamindar used to dispense justice. But this story is situated in a post-modern society.

When Basavaiah acquires Tammanna's land forcibly, Tammanna's followers offer three solutions – seek the help of the police; seek a legal solution; or take recourse to use muscle power. The three strategies suggested by Tammanna's followers saturate this story in the post-modern scenario. Their thinking exhibits a modern world where police, law court and mafia exist. Even at the national and international levels, big countries like Russia and America follow such strategies.

The fact that Tammanna makes a reference to Russia and America, is only a hint by the author that the problems of 'man' in the modern society cannot be confined to the war between 'virtues and vices' of the yesteryears but man's problems are complex and are reflected at the global level also.

Similarly, when Tammanna makes a reference to Russia's declaration to America that America is not their enemy and she will not wage a war against America, it is only a strategy by the writer to suggest that Tammanna and Basavaiah belong to post-modern

society. One can also infer that a literary artist in the modern world cannot be blind to man's problems in general and try to suggest solutions at the local level. Man's problems are deep-rooted and have implications at different levels. Man's problems go beyond a nation and though problems of human society are the same, they assume different dimensions as human society becomes more and more complex every day.

5.Observe how the story employs multiple narratives. How does this technique unveil the mystery of human relationships?

Ans: In the short story 'The Gardener' by P. Lankesh, there is a story within a story and there are two narrators.

In the first story, the author in the persona of the first-person narrator introduces the protagonist Tammanna and the story of the owner of the coconut plantation. Then, the first narrator makes way for the second narrator to take over. Interestingly, in the story, the narrator is the protagonist and tells his own story to the second owner's wife. However, the narrator employs the third-person narrative style and distances himself from the story. Thus 'The Gardener' is an example of the use of multiple narratives.

Multiple narratives describe a type of story that follows several protagonists rather than focusing on one main character. In some cases, writers choose this structure to show the individual perspectives of characters in a larger 'macro story' and how they relate to each other. 'The Gardener' is an example of the second type. Tammanna is the protagonist in both stories.

In the first story, we learn how Tammanna uses his own biography to indirectly give a message to the owner's wife. He gives to the lady his own perspective of human life and experience. The author has used this technique of multiple narratives to reveal the mystery of human relationships.

In his own life, Tammanna has learnt lessons of being proactive in a rivalry with Basavaiah. He plays his game with Basavaiah, only until he dies. Basavaiah's death comes as a revelation to him about human nature. Only then does he theorise saying 'man does not live with the intention of acquiring wealth, or education or art but for some kind of unbearable vengefulness'. Until then, both Basavaiah and Tammanna showed a keen interest in fighting and a zest for life. But once Basavaiah dies, Tammanna loses all enthusiasm for life. He says he is a non-entity now.

Now he has become philosophical. Therefore, when he finds the owner of the coconut plantation cultivating all kinds of vices and the lady getting desperate about her husband, the 'guilt' about Basavaiah's death that was pricking his conscience gets

transformed into a virtue or a positive force and that motivates him to tell his own story objectively to the owner's wife.

Had not the author used multiple narrative structures, Tammanna's story could not have come out as a story to educate the owner's wife. Thus, multiple narrative structures is able to unveil the mystery of human relationships.

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To the Foot from its Child - Pablo Neruda

A Note On The Poet :

Pablo Neruda (1904-1973) is the pen name and, later legal name of the Chilean poet, diplomat, and politician Ricardo Eliecer Neftali Reyes Basoalto. In 1971 Neruda won the Nobel Prize for Literature.

Neruda became known as a poet while still a teenager. He wrote in a variety of styles including surrealist poems, historical epics, overtly political manifestos, a prose autobiography, and erotically- charged love poems such as the ones in his 1924 collection 'Twenty Love Poems and a Song of Despair'.

Neruda's poetry is renowned for its fantastic imagery and surreal use of language. The surrealists attempted to express in art and literature the workings of the unconscious mind and to synthesize. these workings with the conscious mind.

Neruda believes that our most intense experience of impermanence is not death, but our own isolation among the living. It is probably this idea that gets reflected in the poem 'To the Foot from its Child'. According to Neruda, "it was through metaphor, not rational analysis and argument, that the mysteries of the world could be revealed".

Background:

'To the Foot from its Child' is the translated English version of the original poem 'Al Pie Desde Su Nino' written by Pablo Neruda and translated into English by Alastair Reid. [The poem appears in the collection of poems titled 'Estravagaris' published in 1958. 'Extravagaris' (Book of Vagaries) is the English title given by Reid].

To the Foot from its Child Summary :

'To the Foot from its Child' by Pablo Neruda is a narrative-descriptive poem which narrates the journey of a child's foot until it becomes an adult foot and beyond until it dies. Besides narrating the experiences of the adult foot until its death, the poem also describes the changes that the child's foot undergoes until it becomes an adult foot. The journey of the child's foot is similar to the 'journey of life'. The poet uses the 'foot' as a metaphor and conveys his view of life. This metaphor helps the poet to convey the

idea of how the child's spirit gets crushed through the challenges and restrictions that life places upon him. Thus, by personifying the foot, the poet expects the reader to compare the experience of the foot to the whole person's hopes and dreams as well as to the realities of everyday life. By and large one can infer that the poem is basically a criticism of how people force children to grow in society and forget all their dreams and aspirations. The child wants to be a butterfly or an apple, but society is harsh and forces the kid to become a responsible adult doing responsible adult things.

The transition of the child's foot into an adult foot and then until its death can be studied under four stages conveniently. The four stages are

Childhood

Experiencing Reality

Maturity and

Death and Rebirth.

A brief description of each stage is given below:

1. Childhood (Lines 1 – 2):

The first stanza describes the characteristic features of the child's foot. It is an infant's foot and it does not know that it is a 'foot' at all. It lacks awareness and hence it dreams of unlimited possibilities. It would like to be a 'butterfly' or an 'apple'. The foot has an optimistic view of life.

2. Experiencing Reality (Lines 3 – 16):

Here the poet highlights the impact of time on the child. As the infant's foot starts growing in the outside world, it begins to experience the harshness and pain of life while walking. When it steps over, "stones and bits of glass, / streets, ladders / and the paths in the rough earth, it learns that its role is that of a foot the same way people become aware of their role in life. It realizes that it can neither fly like a butterfly nor become a bulged apple on the branch of a tree. The child's foot has now discovered that it is only a 'foot', its spirit loses its battle against the world, is taken prisoner, and is condemned to live in a shoe. It also means that the child's spirit becomes aware of its limitations as a human being and understands its role as a social being in human society.

Now, having been imprisoned in a shoe, it gradually tries to understand the world, in its own way. It is alone and cannot communicate with its counterpart, and gropes blindly in the dark like a blind man. The 'foot' is not in the open and whatever ideas it forms about life, are formed in the confined space of the shoe. Here, it means, it is not in touch with

reality directly. The society decides what it should understand about 'life' or the world outside. Gradually, the foot adapts itself to its world and learns to cope with the harsh realities of life.

3. Maturity (Lines 17 – 46):

In this part of the poem the poet gives a graphic description of the changes seen in the child's foot during its transition from a child's foot to 'adult foot'. The 'soft nails of quartz' in the child's foot gradually grow hard and change themselves into an 'opaque' substance 'hard as horn'. The 'tiny petaled toes' of the child's foot 'grow bunched and out of trim'. The toes in the adult foot appear like 'eyeless reptiles'. Later they grow harder and become callused.

In this stanza, the poet attempts to let the reader know that as the child grows into an adult it becomes less open to reality. It also means that people grow harder both physically and emotionally. The phrase 'faint volcanoes of death' suggests that the foot comes to appreciate 'mortality'. Thus, we find that the child's foot has now been transformed from a beautiful form into a warped and ugly one.

The poet then describes the journey of an adult foot until its death. It is now like an eyeless reptile. Hence he calls it a 'blind thing'. The adult foot is now in the harsh world outside, suggesting that the adult gets trapped in the routines of everyday life or the humdrum commonality of existence. It is now less capable of enjoyment and finds life difficult in every walk of life. It slogs and slogs either as a man's foot or as a woman's foot working in the field or market or mines or ministries. It toils in the shoe, day and night, scarcely finding time to enjoy the pleasures of life or sleep. It works without respite and finally meets with death.

4. Death and Rebirth (Lines 47 – 53):

Soon after the death, the adult foot gets buried. It goes down into the underground. It finds everything dark there. It also does not know that it is dead and has ceased to be a foot. When the foot dies and is buried, its consciousness is childlike again. Therefore, the foot revisits the possibilities of flying like a butterfly or becoming an apple. Here it means that people consider the possibility of an after-life.

To sum up, the freedom of childhood is lost when a person becomes an adult and is exposed to a life of constant work and struggle. Outside, uncontrollable forces have the power to direct one's life and thus 'life' in society takes away people's free spirits until

they are freed again by death. The human promise is not fulfilled by those whom society enslaves and mistreats.

The poet imagines that the naked foot of a boy, innocent still of the habituations of social society does not know that it is a foot, or a butterfly or an apple.

Only through a long process of denial of our embodied natures, beginning with the simple act of wearing shoes and thus denying contact with the earth does the boy become a man. However, upon being buried, he still does not know if he will fly or become an apple.

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To the Foot from its Child Comprehension I :

1.What would the foot like to be?

OR

Mention one of the things that the child's foot likes to be.

Ans: The foot would like to be a butterfly or an apple.

2.'The child's foot is not yet aware it's a foot' (line 1 of the poem) conveys

- a. the immense possibilities of life
- b. the unrestricted nature of a child's imagination
- c. the child's ignorance of harsh realities.

Ans: (b) and (c) the unrestricted nature of a child's imagination/the child's ignorance of harsh realities.

3.What does time teach the child?

Ans: Time teaches the foot that it cannot fly and also cannot be a fruit on the branch of a tree.

4.The line 'stones and bits of glass, streets, ladders and the paths in the rough earth'

- a. indicates hardships one has to face in life.
- b. provides a mere description of a road.
- c. suggests the good and bad experiences of growing up.

Ans: (a) indicates hardships one has to face in life.

5.Why does the child's foot feel defeated?

Ans: The child's foot feels defeated because it has to live like a prisoner, condemned to live in a shoe, and it can never be free to escape from the difficulties of life.

6.Mention the words that convey the real experiences of the foot.

Ans: The words 'stones and bits of glass, streets, ladders, and the paths in the rough earth' convey the real experiences of the child's foot.

7.Identify the lines in the poem that suggest the transformation of the foot.

Ans: Lines 17 – 28 suggest the transformation of the foot.

"These soft nails

of quartz

.....

.....
a coarsening hard to accept.”

8.“..... condemned to live in a shoe” suggests that the foot is

- (a) a prisoner
- (b) a criminal
- (c) forced to give up its dreams.

Ans: (a) and (c) a criminal/forced to give up its dreams.

9.What does the line ‘until the whole man chooses to stop’ mean?

OR

When does the foot stop to walk in Neruda’s poem?

Ans: The line, ‘until the whole man chooses to stop’ means until the person dies.

OR

The foot stops to walk when the person dies.

To the Foot from its Child Comprehension II :

1.We think of a foot as a part of the human body, but Neruda says ‘To the Foot From its Child’. Why?

Ans: We think of a foot physically as belonging to a person but Neruda sees in a philosophical way and says “To The Foot From Its Child”. Though it belongs to a person physically, philosophically like the child who is the symbol of innocence, the foot also does know about its future. But in adulthood, it faces many challenges of life and gets an overall experience and leads a meaningful life until the end. Finally, it is attacked by diseases and surrendered to death.

2.Pick out the expressions that suggest the child’s imagination is fertile.

Ans: The expressions, ‘to be a butterfly’, or ‘an apple’, ‘can not fly’, ‘cannot be a fruit bulging on the branch’ suggest that the child’s imagination is fertile.

3.What contrasting descriptions of the foot does the poem offer? Why?

Ans: The poet Pablo Neruda presents a contrasting description of a child’s foot and an adult’s foot so as to delineate the changes that are seen in a person’s life as he or she changes from an infant into an adult, until his death. Initially, the child or the infant’s foot has soft nails of quartz and its toes are tiny, soft, and rounded at the tips like the petals of some flowers.

As the child learns to walk and starts walking on stones, bits of glass, streets, ladders and the rough surface of the earth, the child's foot becomes aware of its role. It learns that it is a foot and cannot become a butterfly or a bulging fruit on a tree. Once it realizes that it is a foot, it is defeated in realizing its aspirations and gets imprisoned in a shoe. Inside the shoe, it tries to understand the world in its own way, alone, like a blind man groping in the dark. During this period its soft nails of quartz become opaque, are bunched together, and look like eyeless reptiles with triangular heads, grow callused, and are covered with faint volcanoes of death.

These changes happen because, once the child's foot becomes an adult's foot, it walks as the foot of a man or woman and keeps walking in the fields as a farmer, or as a grocer in the markets, or as a miner in the mines or as a church minister or a government worker, until its death. Thus, the foot experiences the hardships of life and loses its 'soft' and flowery petal-like form.

4. The poem begins with the idea that a child's foot is not yet aware that it is a foot; at the end, the foot is unaware that it had ceased to be a foot. What is the poet trying to convey through these statements?

OR

Explain the similarity between the foot's early life and its end as depicted in 'To the Foot From its Child'.

Ans: In this poem, 'foot' is a metaphor for 'life'. The poet Neruda using the foot as a metaphor to explore 'life' through its various stages from infancy through childhood until death.

When the poem begins, the 'foot' is the infant's foot which suggests man's 'childhood'. The child's foot does not know that it is a foot. This state refers to the innocence of childhood where 'Man' has many dreams and aspirations. The child's wish to become a butterfly or an apple stands for man's aspirations and dreams. Once the child's foot enters the real world, it starts walking over stones, bits of glass, streets, ladders, and the rough surface of the earth.

Thus, as the child grows over a period of time, the child's foot realizes that it is only a 'foot' and cannot become fruit or a butterfly. Then, since it has to serve its role as a foot, it is imprisoned in a shoe. Inside the shoe, it tries to understand the world alone, in isolation. The child's foot, as it grows old, serves as the foot of a man or a woman working in the fields, or market or mines or ministries and toils hard day and night until it dies. When it dies, the foot loses its human awareness and that is why when it is buried the foot again gets its child-like innocence. It again dreams of becoming an apple or a

butterfly. It is this journey from childhood through adulthood and the final death that the poem focuses on.

Pablo Neruda is saying that life and death are part of a continuous cycle. Secondly, the poet wishes to say that the freedom of childhood is lost when a person becomes an adult and faces a life of constant work and struggle. Thus, life takes away people's free spirits until they are freed again by death.

5.How does Neruda describe the busy life of the individual as represented by the foot?

Ans: The 'foot' is used as a metaphor for life and the foot refers to the foot of an individual. Once the child develops into an adult, the adult keeps on walking without respite either as a man or as a woman. The individual spends his life working either as a farmer in a field, or as a miner in mines, or as a salesperson in the market or as a government servant or as a church minister. This way the individual toils hard in society until his death.

6.What does the last stanza of the poem mean? Can you think of parallels in nature?

Ans: In this poem, 'foot' is used as a metaphor for 'life'. Life refers to the life of a human being as seen from his infancy until his death. Pablo Neruda gives his view of 'life' and 'death' in this poem. The poem does not begin with the beginning of life in the womb of its mother but from the time after it has taken birth on the earth. The poem covers the period of its infancy to death and beyond. The 'foot' as portrayed in the poem refers to the child's foot. Since a child is not aware of its limitations and lives in a dream world of imagination, the child's foot wishes to fly like a butterfly or become a bulging apple on the branch of a tree. Over a period of time, it realizes that it is only a foot and its role is only to serve as a foot.

The poet then refers to the 'adult food' after death or an individual after death. Once a human being dies, he or she is normally buried. It is this burial of the dead body of the individual that is expressed in the line "it descended underground unaware, for there, everything was dark". Once the 'foot' or the individual dies, it loses its human awareness and goes back to its child-like innocence. This is expressed in the sentence 'It never knew it had ceased to be a foot'. That is why, like a child's foot which is not aware that it is only a 'foot', it aspires to become a butterfly and fly or become an apple.

One can find several parallels in nature. All living beings born on the earth pass through the cycle of birth and death. A seed germinates to give a seedling. The seedling grows into an adult plant, may become a tree or a shrub, and die. Its seeds bring a similar

plant to life again. Similarly, the eggs of animals hatch and bring forth their young ones which grow, mature, lay eggs and later die. Their eggs bring back similar animals to life again.

To the Foot from its Child Comprehension III :

1.Examine how Neruda's poem works out the contrast between colourful dreams and the humdrum reality of life.

OR

The poem 'To the Foot From its Child' represents the conflict between illusion and reality. Elaborate.

Ans: The poem, 'To the Foot from its Child', presents a contrast between colourful dreams and the humdrum reality of life. The poet conveys his view of life through his description of a foot. The foot is a metaphor for expressing the crushing of a child's spirit through the challenges and restrictions that life places upon him. One can undoubtedly infer that the poem is basically a criticism of how people force children to grow in society and forget all their dreams and imaginations.

With a view to delineating the forces that capture the child's freedom and aspirations, the poet begins the poem making a statement directly that the child's foot, which is not aware that it is a foot, would like to be a butterfly or an apple. From this one can infer that man's spirit dreams of enjoying unlimited freedom in this world but it comes to know that it cannot enjoy unlimited freedom and has to pass through several obstacles before it matures into an adult.

But, in time, stones and bits of glass, streets, ladders, paths in the rough earth go on teaching the foot that it cannot fly. As the infant is growing and developing into a mature adult, he is exposed to the harsh realities of life which are metaphorically expressed as stones, bits of glass, ladder, street, etc. These are the problems and obstacles an individual has to face. Thus, once the child becomes a boy, an adolescent, and an adult, the problems of life teach the individual that he is a 'mortal' and his powers are limited and can only serve the society as a member like other human beings. This sense is expressed in the line 'that it cannot fly, cannot become a fruit and is defeated, falls in the battle, is a prisoner condemned to live in a shoe'. Here, the 'shoe' can be taken to mean the human society that regulates his mind and activities.

Wearing the shoe refers to the infant becoming a mature adult. Soon after entering adulthood, the individual explores 'life' within the shoe. He loses touch with the reality of the outside world but experiences the world through the eyes of society. This again

means that a lot of restrictions are imposed on the individual. Now that he is an adult he keeps on walking without respite through the fields, mines, markets, and ministries. The line 'this foot toils in its shoe, scarcely taking time to bare itself in love or sleep' expresses the fact that once he realizes that he is a man destined to live in a society, he learns to face the humdrum realities of life. He has no time to let his human spirit indulge in 'love' and 'sleep'. He is a prisoner and keeps on working until he dies. Once he dies his spirit loses its human awareness and is once again as free as the children.

2.Neruda's poem is a salute to the ordinary human being, who continues with life braving all odds. Do you agree? Give reasons.

Ans: Yes. In this poem, Neruda tries to delineate the journey of human 'life' from its infancy to death and beyond. With a view to expressing the changes that the 'life spirit' undergoes through its journey from an infant to an adult and beyond death, Neruda uses 'foot' as a metaphor. That is why he calls 'life' during infancy as the infant foot and the life spirit of an adult as the adult foot.

The whole poem can be summed up as the 'surrender' of life force to societal pressures. During infancy, the child's spirit dreams of infinite possibilities and hence dreams of becoming a fruit or a butterfly. Once it starts growing in society the harsh realities of life expressed as 'stones, bits of glass, ladder, and rough surface of the earth', teach the infant spirit that it is a 'foot' which means 'you have a role' to play in the society and 'you are an individual subservient to the whims and fancies of the society'. Once the infant spirit gradually accepts its defeat and tries to live in conformity with the norms of the society, it becomes an adult. This is expressed metaphorically as the 'foot being imprisoned in a shoe'.

Once you become a member of the society you learn to live like others, giving up your pleasures and gradually you get to know the realities of life. You go on slogging throughout your life without indulging in 'love and sleep' which symbolically represent your rights on this earth. You forego your rights and live like an adult and serve the society until you die and you get your freedom after your death. As long as your life spirit is in your body you have human awareness and you are aware of your limitations. Once you die you lose human awareness and your spirit is free to enjoy its freedom. In the poem, Neruda does not speak of the possibilities of the human spirit 'rebellious'. Nor does he say that human spirit is being crushed by oppressive forces; the human spirit does not commit suicide. On the contrary, he describes the journey of the human spirit as an infant's foot until it becomes an adult foot and after its death how it becomes free again. From this, it can be argued that Neruda's poem is a salute to the human spirit for braving all odds and completing one's cycle of life and death peacefully, and not rebelliously.

3. Is Neruda criticizing how society crushes childhood dreams and forces people into rigid moulds?

OR

**“Society crushes dreams of individuals and condemns them to live in captivity.”
Explain with reference to ‘To the Foot from its Child’.**

Ans: Yes, to some extent. In this narrative-descriptive poem, Neruda has attempted to delineate the predicament of man as a prisoner enslaved by society. Using ‘foot’ as a metaphor for ‘life’, he narrates the journey of life from that of an ‘infant foot’ to an ‘adult foot’ until its death and after. In the first two lines itself, the poet declares the wish of childhood. The infant’s foot is not aware that it is a ‘foot’ and hence would like to be a butterfly or an apple. These two objects – ‘butterfly’ and ‘apple’ – together suggest that the infant’s foot thinks of complete freedom to become whatever it wants. Being born a human being it cannot aspire to become a butterfly or an apple.

From this, we can infer that there is some restriction imposed on us by birth itself. This is expressed in the line ‘it is not aware that it is a foot’. The infant foot, once it starts growing, is exposed to the ways and means of the world. We live in human society and nature, the words ‘stones, bits of glass, streets, ladders, and the paths in the rough earth’ refer to man’s ways of living. This exposure to man’s style of living brings awareness in the child that it is a foot. The poet suggests that the infant’s foot is engaged in a battle with the society and ‘adults’ crush the child’s playful spirit and imprison it in a shoe. This stage refers to the way the child gets acclimatized to living in human society.

Once it wears the ‘shoe’, which means, it accepts its identity as ‘man’, a member of the human society, he starts exploring the human world alone, groping in the dark like a blind man. There is a difference in the way an adult explores the world. As a child, it thinks of infinite possibilities; but, as an adult, it is aware of its limitations. This means the society has been successful in crushing childhood dreams and forcing the life spirit into the rigid moulds of society.

Since the whole poem only describes various changes undergone by the human spirit, we cannot say that Neruda is criticizing society for its stranglehold on the human spirit. Secondly, Neruda also says that the child’s foot does not know that it is a foot. This means, even Neruda knows that the child is born a human being and is going to live in human society. Thirdly, nowhere in the poem does Neruda say anything against societal forces. However, Neruda sympathises with ‘Man’ at one point. He says, ‘this foot toils in its shoe scarcely taking time to bare itself in love or sleep’. These lines indicate that Neruda only sympathises with man’s predicament and does not criticize society.

4. 'Foot' is a keyword in the poem. Comment on Neruda's skillful use of the word and its associations in terms of imagery to convey his ideas.

OR

Highlight the imagery used to bring out life's hardships that deform the child's foot.

Ans: In this poem, as the title 'To the Foot from its Child' suggests, 'foot' is the keyword in the poem. The poet uses 'foot' as a metaphor for his view of 'life'. The poet personifies the 'foot' and focuses his attention on the 'life' of man, using the 'foot' as the protagonist. 'Life' begins in infancy and so even in the poem, 'life' begins as an infant's foot.

It is natural that children, who are naive and innocent, do not know that their foot is meant for walking and it has a function to discharge. Through the use of the 'foot' as a metaphor, the poet cleverly brings out the battle between harsh realities of life symbolically expressed as stones, streets, ladder, bits of glass, etc. The child dreams of becoming a butterfly or an apple. So naturally, the metaphor of foot helps the poet to convey his meaning through an imaginary battle fought between the child's foot and the surfaces on which the child is likely to walk.

The child's foot is sure to be hurt when it walks on a street laden with stones and bits of glass and paths in the rough earth and when it climbs the ladder pressing his soft foot on the pointed edges of the rungs of the ladder. Then it realizes that it is a 'foot'. Here, the poet wants the reader to know that the adult world fights against the spirit of the child and makes him become aware of his role as an individual in human society. At this stage, the foot is imprisoned in a shoe, which means, the child's consciousness reaches maturity and adulthood.

Adulthood is now represented as 'adult foot' enclosed in a shoe. The adult foot gropes in the dark and learns about the harsh realities of life like a blind man. Here, it means, unlike the child's foot which had more freedom than the adult's, the adult foot has to work in a rigid mould given by the society. The 'shoe' represents this framework given by society. Here again, the 'foot' as a metaphor comes to his help. Therefore, the poet chooses 'shoe' as representing societal norms and traditions.

The blind adult foot now walks and works without respite until he dies. The different professions of men are mentioned. The adult foot may be a man's foot or a woman's foot and keeps walking through fields, markets, mines, and ministries, and finally toils hard scarcely finding time to enjoy 'love' and 'sleep'. Here also the metaphor of the 'foot' facilitates the expression in the line 'scarcely taking time to bare itself in love or sleep'.

Finally, it ceases to be a 'foot' when a man chooses to stop working. Thus, the 'foot' as a metaphor has been skillfully used by the poet to evoke the right imagery to suit his meaning.

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Believe that Books will Never Disappear - Jorge Luis Borges

About the Interview :

Jorge Luis Borges (1899-1986) is an Argentine short-story writer, essayist, poet and translator born in Buenos Aires. His work embraces the “character of unreality in all literature”. His most famous books, ‘Ficciones’ (1944) and ‘The Aleph’ (El Aleph, 1949) are compilations of short stories interconnected by common themes, including dreams, labyrinths, libraries, mirrors, infinity, fictional writers, philosophy, religion and God. Believe that Books will Never Disappear Interview with Jorge Luis Borges About the

Interviewer :

Roberto Alifano, Argentine poet, storyteller, essayist and journalist, was born in the city of General Pinto, province of Buenos Aires, in 1943. His books have been translated into several languages. From 1974 to 1985 he worked with Jorge Luis Borges.

Believe that Books will Never Disappear Summary :

This lesson presents excerpts from a face-to-face interview between Jorge Luis Borges and Roberto Alifano. Jorge Luis Borges was an Argentine short-story writer, essayist, poet and translator, who became partially blind at the age of 55.

In this interview, Borges shares his views on the importance of ‘books’ in the era of globalised electronic communication. Incidentally, Borges shares his views/observations about a few other topics like poetry, metaphors and literature as well, besides expressing his feelings about his ‘mother’ and his ‘blindness’. Alifano, the interviewer, asks questions about each of the topics mentioned above and Borges expresses his views in response to them.

The interview begins with the first question, ‘What was your first literary reading?’ In reply, Borges tells him that the first literary work that he read was ‘Grimm’s Fairy Tales’ in the English version. Then Borges tells his interviewer that he learned more from his father’s library than by high school or the university.

Alifano then asks Borges to speak about his mother Dona Leonor. Borges tells him that his mother was an extraordinary person who showed him a great deal of kindness in his life. Then he continues, telling the interviewer in a confessional tone that he feels guilty for not having been a happy man in order to have given his mother the happiness she deserved. He also feels that he should have shown a better understanding of his mother.

Then, he generalizes the issue stating that it is true of all children that when their mothers die, children feel that they had taken them for granted (while she was alive) like they do with the moon or the sun or the seasons and feel that they have abused their mothers. However, this truth does not dawn on such children before the death of their mother. Then Borges adds that his mother was an intelligent and gracious woman who had no enemies.

Then, Alifano asks Borges apologetically what blindness meant to him. Borges, in reply, tells him that blindness is a way of life not entirely unhappy. He adds that as a writer he generally believes that all persons must think that whatever happens to him or to her is a resource. He believes that all things have been given us for a purpose and an artist must feel that more intensely. Borges is of the opinion that all that happens to us, including humiliations, misfortunes, and embarrassments are given to us as raw material as clay so that we may shape our art.

Alifano endorses Borges' idea quoting from Homer's 'The Odyssey'. The lines quoted by Alifano are taken from this poem, in which the poet tells the reader that it is the Gods who make man's life tragic so as to weave a song for future generations to sing. This idea is based on the belief that men write songs in order to soothe the mind when they recall their woes.

After listening to Alifano's quote from 'The Odyssey', Borges adds a little more to highlight the same idea of man's life being troubled by many undesirable events. Borges tells Alifano that in one of his poems he has said that 'humiliation', 'misfortune', and 'discord' were given to us that we may change them and using our miserable circumstances create works which last forever. Then he quotes from Goethe, "All that is near becomes far". Here again, Borges is referring to the loss of his eyesight.

In the line quoted here, Goethe is referring to the evening twilight when the things closest to us seem to move away from our eyes. Borges is quoting this line to tell Alifano that the visible world has moved away from his eyes forever. Borges then adds that his eyesight has been replaced by many other things. Then he tells Alifano that it is his duty to accept blindness and still enjoy it as far as possible. Therefore, he tells

Alifano that he still continues to pretend that he is not blind and buys books, to fill his house with.

Alifano, hearing him mention 'Books', asks Borges to speak about the theme of books. In reply, Borges tells Alifano that he had a very strange dream in which he had seen the library of Alexandria burning, its countless volumes attacked by flames. Then he asks Alifano whether he believes that his dream has any meaning. Alifano replies that it may have some meaning, but then continues his interview asking Borges whether he has ever thought of writing a book on the history of the 'book'.

Borges tells him that he won't be able to write such a book though it is an excellent idea. He wonders whether an eighty-three-year-old man can set such a project for himself. Incidentally, Borges tells him that he will keep it in his mind. Then Borges tells Alifano that Spengler has already made an effort in this regard in his 'Decline of the West'. In this book, Spengler has made a remarkable comment on books. Then Alifano refers to Borges' comments (in one of his essays) about the words of Bernard Shaw, in which he has declared "Every book worth being re-read has been written by the spirit".

Borges agrees with him and tells him that a book goes beyond its author's intention, which may not be right. Borges declares that in every book there is a need for something more, which is not easy to understand. Then he gives the example of an ancient book. He tells Alifano that when one reads an ancient book one feels as though he or she was reading about all the time that has passed from the day it was written to his present day.

Borges concludes saying that a book always retains something sacred, something mortal, something magical which brings happiness. Then, Alifano asks Borges to define poetry. In reply, Borges says that poetry is something so intimate, and so essential that it cannot be defined without being oversimplified. If one attempts to define poetry it would be like attempting to define the colour yellow, love, and the fall of the leaves in autumn. Borges then states that poetry is not the poem but it is the aesthetic act, the poetic act that takes place when the poet writes it when the reader reads it and it always happens in a different manner. Then he adds and says that when the poetic act takes place, we become aware of it. He then concludes declaring that poetry is a magical, mysterious, and unexplainable, although not an incomprehensible, event.

He feels that the poet should be deemed to have failed if one does not feel the poetic event upon reading it. Alifano then adds telling Borges that the important thing in the art of poetry is finding the precise words. Borges agrees with him. He then states that

precise words elicit the emotion. He quotes the line “This quiet dust was gentlemen and ladies” from Emily Dickinson’s poem to illustrate his statement.

Alifano then asks Borges to explain the concept of metaphors. Borges tells him in reply that true metaphors have been there in existence since the beginning of time. Then he tells him that he has occasionally thought of reducing all metaphors to five or six essential metaphors.

Borges is of the opinion that these essential metaphors are found in all literature, apart from many others which are whimsical. Borges then tells him that the poet has to discover metaphors, even though they may already exist.

Finally, Alifano asks Borges to comment on the statement “modern developments in communications will replace books with something more dynamic that will require less time than reading”.

Borges tells him that books will never disappear. Then, he declares that among the many inventions of man, the book is undoubtedly the most astounding, and all the others are only extensions of our bodies. He opines that the telephone is the extension of our voice; the telescope and the microscope are extensions of our sight, and the sword and the plough are extensions of our arms. He asserts that only the book is an extension of our imagination and memory.

Then Alifano asks Borges his reactions to his own statement, ‘Literature is a dream’. Borges assertively tells him that it is true. He restates his statement ‘Literature is a dream’, and says that it is a ‘controlled dream’. Then he says that it is his belief that we owe literature almost everything we are; what we have been, and also what we will be and ends saying “Our past is nothing but a sequence of dreams.” He concludes remarking that there can be no difference between dreaming and remembering the past. Then he declares, “Books are the great memory of all centuries and their function is irreplaceable. If books disappear, history will disappear and surely the man would disappear”.

I Believe that Books will Never Disappear Comprehension I :

1. 'I was educated more by my father's library' says Borges. He means _____

- a. school or the university did not educate him.
- b. he was educated in his father's library too.
- c. he learnt through private tuitions held in his father's library.

Ans: (b) he was educated in his father's library too.

2. Why did Borges feel guilty about his mother?

Ans: His mother's dedication to nurturing him was immense. He had misused her love as he had taken her for granted and never gave her his love and affection in return.

3. According to Borges, blindness is _____

- a. just a physical handicap
- b. not a misfortune
- c. actually a resource.

Ans: (c) actually a resource.

4. Why does Borges prefer to believe that he is not blind?

Ans: He believes in optimism than pessimism. If he were to believe that he was blind, it would affect his future but if he takes it positively and uses it as raw material, it helps his future. Hence he believes in optimism.

5. Borges feels that when we read a book what matters is not the author's intention, but what sense we get out of it. (True/False.)

Ans: True.

6. How, according to Borges, does the book go beyond the author's intention?

Ans: According to Borges, in every book, there is a need for something more, which is always mysterious. A book can be full of errors; we can reject its author's opinions; disagree with him or her, but the book always retains something sacred, something mortal, and something magical which brings happiness. Thus, the book goes beyond the author's intention.

7. When does the poetic act happen, according to Borges?

Ans: According to Borges, the poetic act happens when the poet writes it and the reader reads it.

8.What cannot be defined without oversimplifying it?

Ans: Poetry is something so intimate and essential that it cannot be defined without oversimplifying it.

9.Which is the most astounding invention of man?

Ans: 'Book' is undoubtedly the most astounding invention of man.

I Believe that Books will Never Disappear Comprehension II :

1.Why does Borges feel remorseful after his mother's death regarding his relationship with her? Can this experience be generalized?

OR

How does Borges describe his mother and his feelings for her in his interview?

Ans: During the course of his interview with Alifano, Borges tells him that his mother was an extraordinary person who showed him a great deal of kindness in his life. Then he confesses in a remorseful tone that he could not make his mother happy because he himself was not a happy man. He also confesses that he should have shown a better understanding of his mother.

This experience can be generalized because what Borges says is true of all children. It is not surprising to know, when their mothers die, most children express that they had taken their mother for granted while they were alive like they do with the moon or the sun or the seasons and are guilty that they had abused their mothers.

2.How does Borges elaborate on Goethe's words, 'ail that is near becomes far'?

Ans: While giving his observations about 'blindness', Borges recalls an idea he had expressed in one of his poems. He had said that humiliation, misfortune, and discord were given to us so that we may transmute them, and make from the miserable circumstance of our life 'eternal works'. At this juncture, Borges recalls to mind a statement made by Goethe. It says, "All that is near becomes far". In this statement, Goethe refers not only to the sunset but also to life. Borges says that in his case, the visible world has moved away from his eyes forever. He feels that it is his duty to accept his misfortune and as far as possible enjoy those things.

3.What, according to Borges, should one think of humiliations and misfortunes?

Ans: Borges says that all persons must think that whatever happens to him or her is a resource. He adds that all things have been given to us for a purpose, and therefore we should think of our humiliations, misfortunes and embarrassments as raw material like clay so that we may shape our art. He says that humiliation, misfortune and discord

were given to us so that we may transmute them, so that we may make from the miserable circumstance of our life eternal works or works that aspire to be so.

4.What are Borges'views on poetry and poem?

Ans: Borges believes that poetry is something so intimate and so essential that it cannot be defined without oversimplifying it. Then he says that poetry is not the poem and opines that a poem may be nothing more than a series of symbols. Borges opines that poetry is the aesthetic act that takes place when the poet writes it and when the reader reads it. He believes that poetry is a magical, mysterious and unexplainable – although not an incomprehensible – event. He believes that one should feel the poetic event upon reading it otherwise the poet should be deemed to have failed.

5.Why is it important for poetry to use language precisely? With what example does Borges demonstrate this aspect of poetic language?

OR

Finding precise words is important in the art of poetry. How does Borges justify this in his interview? ‘

OR

To what extent is finding the precise words important in the art of poetry, according to Borges?

Ans: Borges feels that poetry needs to use language precisely. He opines that only precise words elicit the emotion. In order to prove his point, he quotes a line from Emily Dickinson, ‘This quiet dust was gentlemen and ladies’. He argues that though the idea is banal the poet is referring to a place which had been visited by men and women in ‘summer’. These people are now dead and the dust she refers to is the dust of death. Instead of saying ‘This quiet dust was gentlemen and ladies’ if the poet had used ‘men and women’, the poem would have failed as poetry. It would have sounded trivial.

6.In spite of modern modes of communication, Borges believes that books will not disappear. Illustrate.

OR

Why does Borges say that books will never disappear?

OR

‘The modern developments in communications will not replace books.’ Explain with reference to Jorge Luis Borges’ thoughts on this.

Ans: According to Borges, among the many inventions of man, the book is undoubtedly the most astounding of all. All others are extensions of our bodies. The telephone is the extension of our voice, the telescope and the microscope are extensions of our sight and the sword and the plough are extensions of our arms. Only the book is an extension

of our imagination and memory. Modern modes in communications have not developed anything to work as a substitute for our imagination and memory.

I Believe that Books will Never Disappear Comprehension III :

1. 'Poetry is magical, mysterious, and unexplainable'. How does Borges explain the strange aspect of poetry?

OR

What are Borges's views on poetry?

Ans: According to Borges, poetry is an aesthetic act; and poetry is not the poem. The poetic act takes place when the poet writes it and the reader reads it and it always happens in a slightly different manner. When the poetic act takes place, Borges believes that we become aware of it. That is why he calls poetry as a magical, mysterious, and unexplainable event. If one does not feel the poetic event upon reading it, Borges opines that we need to conclude that the poet has failed.

2. How does Borges value literature? Why is it important for the future of mankind?

Ans: According to Borges, a book is only an extension of our imagination and memory. We get access to literature through books. Literature is a dream, a controlled dream. Borges believes that we owe literature almost everything we are, what we have been, and what we will be. Our past is nothing but a sequence of dreams. He believes that there is no difference between dreaming and remembering the past. It is books that serve as the repositories of great memories of all centuries and nothing else can replace books. Therefore, if books disappear, surely history would disappear and along with history man would also disappear. Therefore, literature is very important for preserving the future of mankind.

Heaven, If you are not here on Earth -

Kuvempu

A Note On The Poet :

K.V. Puttappa (1904-1994) is widely known by the pen name Kuvempu. He is acknowledged as the greatest poet of the 20th century Kannada literature. He is the first among eight recipients of the Jnanpith Award for Kannada.

He is the second – after M. Govinda Pai – among Kannada poets to be revered as Rashtrakavi, a national poet. His work 'Sri Ramayana Darshanam', the rewriting of the great ancient Indian epic 'Ramayana' in modern Kannada, is regarded as a revival of the era of Mahakavya (Epic poetry) in a contemporary form and charm. He is immortalized by some of his phrases, and in particular for his contribution to Universal Humanism or in his own words 'Vishwa Manavatha Vaada'. He was conferred the Padma Vibhushan by the Government of India. He has penned the Karnataka State anthem 'Jaya Bharata Jananiya Tanujate'. The poem has been translated into English by Dr. C. Naganna, a well-known poet, critic, and translator.

In this poem, Kuvempu urges us to take note of nature as a dynamic entity. For him, heaven is not something beyond the boundaries of this world, since the earth itself possesses all that the so-called heaven promises. The poet's decisive inference that heaven is here on earth and nowhere else is seen from the beginning to the end. According to him, the stream, the waves, the splendour of harvest, the sunshine, the celestial eye, the moonlight – are all nothing but the reflection of that unseen paradise called heaven.

Heaven, If you are not here on Earth Summary :

This poem is the English version of 'Swargave, Bhoomiyoliradire Neenu', a poem in Kannada, written by Kuvempu, one of the most revered poets of Karnataka. The poem makes an attempt to give the reader a glimpse into the rationalistic outlook of the poet. The poet has tried to argue that concepts like 'Heaven', 'God', 'Nymphs' etc., are man's creations. Entities like 'Heaven' and 'God' exist only on the Earth and you cannot find them anywhere else. The poet suggests that one should perceive divinity and enjoy the heavenly bliss in the company of Nature itself. The poet strongly believes that 'Heavenliness and worldliness' are not distinct or two separate entities and argues

that there is no difference between worshipping or adoring Nature and worshipping or adoring God.

In the first two lines the poet addresses 'Heaven' and declares emphatically that if Heaven does not exist on the Earth where else can it be. It only means that the reader needs not look for 'Heaven' in the skies; if at all there is an entity called 'Heaven' one must find it on the earth only and nowhere else.

The poet refers to our beliefs about 'Gods' and 'heavenly nymphs'. The poet expresses his conviction that there is no distinct or substantial entity called 'God' and it is Man himself who is God. Similarly, there exist no entities called 'heavenly nymphs'. He firmly believes that we ourselves are the nymphs, and the nymphs are to be found nowhere else but on this earth only.

The poet wants to dispel the popular notion that gods and nymphs live in heaven. The poet, who wants to dismiss such beliefs, tells the reader that we ourselves should become gods and nymphs. The poet wants us to give up our belief that we go to heaven after death where we find gods and nymphs.

The poet tries to introduce us to the different forms or parts of heaven that exist on the earth. He presents a mesmerizing picture of 'Nature' in its pristine form. The poet states that the 'bliss' that we experience when we look at the streams that are leaping down, roaring, from the top of the hills, the waves that come rolling across the seas carrying surf at their edges, the tender rays of sunlight falling on the vast expanse of green forests and the gentle sun warming up the earth make this Earth, 'Heaven'.

The poet refers to the beauty of the harvest season and the moonlit night. He declares that one enjoys heavenly bliss when one watches the splendour of harvest and the moonlit night. The poet ends the poem saying that the poet who imbibes this heavenly bliss, spreads the nectar of Heaven through his poetry on this earth.

A poet is endowed with a higher degree of imagination and sensibility. With these qualities, the poet appreciates nature's beauty and in turn, the poet enables others to behold heaven on earth.

To sum up, the poet argues that we do not need to seek heaven after death, but can enjoy heavenly bliss even when we are alive, if only we have the 'eyes' to see 'Heaven' on this earth. 'Heaven' exists only on the earth and nowhere else. One is sure to enjoy the pleasures of heaven when one looks at the splendour of Nature. The poet urges the

reader to perceive the tremendous energy that lies underneath the physical beauty of Nature. This idea can be taken as the message of the poem.

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Heaven, If you are not here on Earth Comprehension I :

1. According to the poet, 'heaven' is

- (a) on earth
- (b) within us
- (c) elsewhere.

Ans: (a) on earth.

2. The poet finds god in

- (a) nature
- (b) earth
- (c) temple.

Ans: (a) nature.

3. What does the line 'Heaven lies all over' suggest?

Ans: Heaven is not elsewhere but within us and is all over the world. If we are good, then that is heaven and if we are bad that is hell. Nature is also a heaven as we can find heaven in objects like trees, moon, sands of grains etc.

4. Who creates 'heaven on earth'?

OR

Where does the poet create heaven?

Ans: The poet creates heaven on earth.

Heaven, If you are not here on Earth Comprehension II :

1. Describe the beauty in nature that makes the earth a heavenly place.

OR

How has the poet glorified heaven on earth?

Ans: The poet Kuvempu argues that we do not need to seek heaven after death. We can enjoy the heavenly bliss in looking at Nature on this earth itself. The poet presents a beautiful description of nature's beauty. The poet emphatically states that the bliss that one experiences while looking at the streams that are leaping down, roaring from the top of the hills, the waves that come rolling across the seas carrying surf at their edges, the tender rays of sunlight falling on the sprawling green forests and the gentle sun warming up the earth make this earth a heavenly place.

2. Why does the poet feel that earth is more beautiful than heaven?

Ans: According to Kuvempu, there is no heaven in reality. Entities like 'God', 'Heaven',

and the nymphs are merely figments of man's imagination. All the different forms of nature like the green forests, the streams that leap down the hills, the waves that roll across the seas, the moonlit night, and the splendour of harvest appear more beautiful than the imaginary descriptions of the man.

Heaven, If you are not here on Earth Comprehension III :

1.How does the poet explain the illusion of heaven in the poem?

OR

How does the poem 'Heaven, if you are not here on Earth' visualise heaven?

Ans: Kuvempu considers concepts like 'God', 'nymphs' and 'heaven' as myths created by man. He opines that if at all 'heaven' exists it exists only on this earth and nowhere else. In order to break the illusion of heaven in man's mind, he presents before us charming sights of nature and argues that nothing can be more heavenly than these forms of nature.

He makes a direct address to nature and declares that if heaven does not exist on the earth where else can it be. He justifies his statement referring to the streams, the waves, and the sunlight. He says that the streams that leap down roaring from the top of the hills, the rolling surf at the edge of the waves, the tender rays of sunlight falling on the green forests, the gentle sun warming the earth all these make the earth heaven.

2.How does the poem celebrate the power of the poet?

Ans: Having argued categorically that if at all there exists an entity called heaven, it exists only on this earth, the poet Kuvempu presents before the readers' beautiful sights of nature. In the last stanza, the poet states that one sees chunks of heaven lying all over in the splendour of harvest and of moonlight. He concludes the poem celebrating poetic talent. He says that the poet enjoys looking at Nature, imbibes the beauty of nature and spills the nectar of heaven, on the earth, through his poetry.

Japan and Brazil through a Traveller's Eye - George Mikes

A Note On The Writer :

George Mikes (1912 – 1987) was a Hungarian-born British artist, author, publisher, illustrator, and journalist. He studied Law and received his doctorate at Budapest University. He is best known for his humorous commentaries on various countries. His early books included 'We Were There To Escape' and 'How to be an Alien'. Subsequent books dealt with (among others) Japan ('The Land of the Rising Yen'), Israel ('Milk and Honey, The Prophet Motive'), the U.S. ('How to Scrape Skies'), and the United Nations ('How to Unite Nations'), Australia ('Boomerang'), the British again ('How to be Inimitable, How to be Decadent'), and South America ('How to Tango'). Other subjects include God ('How to be God'), his cat ('Tsi-Tsa'), wealth ('How to be Poor'), or philosophy ('How to be a Guru'). His autobiography was called 'How to be Seventy'.

In this lesson, there are two excerpts titled 'Japanese Manners' and 'Traffic in Brazil', chosen from George Mikes' book titled 'The Land of the Rising Yen' and 'How to Tango', respectively. They are two specimens of 'Travel writing'. The writer is a travel journalist, who presents his observations about the people of Japan and Brazil in these two articles.

In the first excerpt titled 'Japanese Manners,' the writer gives his comments about the Japanese habit of 'bowing' and how they manage to respect each others' privacy even though they are living in an overcrowded island. The author shares his experience of travelling in Japan and tries to draw the readers' attention to what is most striking about the Japanese people as seen by a touring journalist.

Japan and Brazil through a Traveller's Eye Summary :

Japanese Manners :

Within fifteen minutes after you have landed in Japan, you will learn that the people of Japan are an exquisitely well-mannered people, who live on a hopelessly overcrowded island. Consequently, their living space is very limited and so they do not have any

privacy, yet the people respect people's privacy in a different way. Their 'courtesy' serves a double function. They exhibit such polite behaviour that their 'courtesy' itself serves as a substitute for privacy. The writer supports his opinion-with as an example. For example, he says, one finds red telephones in the streets, shops, halls of hotels, etc., and the instrument is placed on a table or a counter. They do not have space to spare for telephone booths. But, any person can conduct his most confidential business transactions, even intimate love quarrels in public and in perfect privacy, without being apprehensive about any passerby overhearing you. The author emphatically says that the person's telephone receiver is his castle.

The writer then gives his observations about the Japanese obsession with 'Bowing'. He calls it a 'mania' because everybody keeps bowing to everybody else. He remarks that the people bow to each other with the solemnity of a courtier with a great deal of natural and inimitable grace. He comments that though 'bowing' is like shaking hands or kissing the cheek, it is quainter, more formal, and more oriental but also infectious. Then he states that bowing is so commonly seen everywhere that even the onlookers start bowing though not the right way as the Japanese do. We bow too deeply or not deeply enough or we bow to the wrong man at the wrong time. Secondly, we do not clasp our hands in front of us, which is considered a bad way, or we may clasp the hands in a bad way which is considered even worse.

Next, the writer tells us that the Japanese have a complicated hierarchy in bowing: who bows to whom, how deeply, and for how long. Then the author cites an incident that happened in America. He tells us that in one of the American states, there was a traffic law which laid down that if two cars met at an intersection, neither was to move before the other had gone. The author uses this incident to tell us that, similarly in Japan, if two Japanese bows, neither are to straighten up before the other stands erect in front of him. Though it sounds a little complicated to us, the Japanese manage it without difficulty and even the smallest difference in rank, standing, age, social position will be subtly reflected in that split second; one man's bow will be shorter than the others'. In many cases, there are clear-cut differences in position and no difficulties.

According to the Japanese culture, the wife bows to her husband, the child bows to his father, younger brother to elder brothers, the sister bows to all brothers of whatever age. The author then recollects a sight he had seen in Japan, that of Japanese mothers carrying their babies on their backs in little saddles and whenever their mother bowed, the babies bowed too. Then there are the bowing girls in Japanese stores standing at the top of escalators, bowing deeply and deferentially to everyone. Next, the writer narrates his experience on a fast train (Tokaido Line), between Tokyo and Osaka. He

tells us that two conductors enter the carriage in a theatrical style, march to the middle of the coach, bow ceremoniously in both directions, and then start checking the tickets. Later, he narrates how even an animal like the deer do 'bowing'. He tells the reader that in one of the parts of 'Nara' (Nara Park is a vast wildlife park located in the city of Nara, Japan, at the foot of Mount Wakakusa, where wild deer roam about freely), he bought a pack of food for deer. The deer came up to him, looked into his eyes, and bowed deeply. The author states that it was not a chance gesture but it was a proper and courteous bow.

The author conjectures that the deer are more imitative, and having seen the people bowing all the time, probably they also get into the habit. Then he says it may be something genetic and is in the blood of Japanese deer. Finally, he ends the incident, saying that the deer, after bowing to him, jumped at him and snatched the little food-bag from his hand.

In a humorous tone, he tells the reader that the Japanese people who bow with such ceremonious serenity even at bus-stops, exhibit flippant behaviour almost immediately. He tells the reader that as soon as a bus arrives, the bowing gentlemen become savage-like, push each other aside, tread on each other's toes and shove their elbows into each other's stomachs to get into the bus.

He ends his travelogue on Japan with his humorous observations about 'soup eating' in Japan. According to the Japanese, when eating soup you must make a fearful noise; only then will one be appreciated. If the soup eater does not make a noise, his hostess will think that the guest is an ill-mannered lout. On the other hand, if the guest makes some noise while eating soup, she will think that he is not a reasonably well brought up European because no reasonably well brought up European makes such disgusting noises when eating up the soup. The author tells jokingly that the hostess will conclude that he must be an ill-mannered lout.

Traffic in Brazil :

This excerpt is taken from 'How to Tango', a humorous commentary on South America, by George Mikes. The author tells us in a humorous vein how the people of Brazil drive their motor vehicles. He also records his appreciation of the people's talent for decorating their grey pavements.

The author narrates his experiences while walking as a tourist through the streets of Copacabana. The very first sentence is a comment about their time consciousness. He

says very casually, “Nobody hurries in Brazil”; then he sarcastically adds, “it does not really matter whether you reach your destination an hour soon, a day late, or not at all”.

Then he turns his attention towards the grey pavements in Copacabana. He states that the grey pavements in the streets are often decorated with beautiful black mosaics which he calls ‘a unique type of decoration’. Then he gives the people of Brazil his compliments for their talent for doing such decorations. He remarks, “Only a people alive to beauty in their surroundings and who have plenty of time for contemplation during their meditative, ambulatory exercises would take the trouble to decorate the pavements they walk on”. He uses a pompous term ‘ambulatory exercises’ to refer to their walking style.

One should also note that though here he is appreciating the people for their aesthetic sense, he is also satirizing their sluggish walking style or the lethargic attitude of the people. In the very next sentence, he makes fun of their ‘driving style’. He tells the reader that the very same leisurely characters when they get behind a steering wheel, they drive very fast and are reckless. Having made a comment about their time consciousness, now he says, “gaining a tenth of a second is a matter of grave importance for all of them all the time”. The reader cannot but infer that the people of Copacabana are very lethargic only while walking and are reckless while driving vehicles.

The writer remarks that buying a motor car in Brazil is an extremely expensive event because import duty for importing cars from other countries is very high. In this context, he also compares Brazil with other countries in South America and says, “Only a few other, poorer South American states are in a worse position in this respect.” Then he remarks that “complaints are universal; hardly anyone can afford a car.” Having said this he proceeds to say that yet you find an unimaginably large number of motor cars here. Then he makes a satirical comment on the craze of the people for buying cars. He says, “the number of motor vehicles is growing by leaps and bounds as if they were distributed free of charge to all and sundry.” The reader should be careful to note here that the author is also expressing his doubt or surprise at the capacity of the people to pay such huge import duties to buy a car.

Then he explains how reckless the people who drive motor vehicles are. He remarks that “it is, not that drivers do not care about pedestrians”; the trouble is “they are, in fact, on the lookout for them. As soon as a driver notices a pedestrian step off the pavement, the driver considers him as ‘fair game’, he takes aim and accelerates.” The pedestrian has to jump, leap, and run for dear life. In these lines, the author is trying to tell the

reader how reckless the drivers are and how they chase people as hunters do while hunting an animal.

However, in the next line, he compliments the people for their sweet and sensible temperament. He tells the reader that the pedestrian does not resent being targeted by the driver. He says, “driver and pedestrian – hunter and prey smile amicably at each other, and they appear to be saying “I win today you will tomorrow”.

In the next paragraph, the author talks about the rivalry between two drivers. Though the war between two drivers appears to be murderous, yet they are good-tempered. He describes the style of their driving – they cut in, overtake on both sides, force you to brake violently and commit all the most heinous crimes on the road twenty times an hour”. Despite exhibiting such recklessness in their driving, they smile at you and do not show any anger, no hostility, and no mad hooting.

In the next paragraph, he recalls an incident he had probably witnessed in a place called Avenida Presidente Vargas. He says it is the worst place in Brazil known for its crowded and slow-moving’ traffic. His statement is paradoxical. He says, on the one hand, that driver’s drive recklessly; and here he calls the traffic ‘crawling traffic’. He says even the onlookers will be contemplating the truly fascinating problem “how can crawling traffic proceed at such terrifying speed”. One can imagine the number of vehicles moving at such terrific speed and probably it is the number of vehicles moving at a time together which makes the reader call it ‘crawling traffic’. He comments about the helplessness of the pedestrian who wishes to cross the road waiting for hours on end.

Then, he concludes narrating a jovial anecdote. He tells the reader that he might witness a situation in which a man standing beside you on your side of the road, suddenly discovers a friend of his on the other side and starts waving to him. He asks him, “How on earth did you ever get there?” The other fellow yells back, “How? I was born on this side”. The author narrates this anecdote probably to convince the reader how difficult it is to cross a busy road in Avenida Vargas.

Japan and Brazil through a Traveller's Eye Comprehension I :

1. 'Exquisitely well-mannered people' refers to

- a. Indians
- b. Japanese
- c. Americans.

Ans: (b) Japanese.

2. What behaviour substitutes privacy in Japan?

Ans: The respect for one another's privacy and showing courtesy are the substitutes for privacy in Japan.

3. The reference to public telephone suggests:

- a. how overcrowded Japan is
- b. how the Japanese respect privacy
- c. how busy the Japanese are.

Ans: (b) how the Japanese respect privacy.

4. Hierarchy in bowing demands

- a. youngsters bow to their elders.
- b. wife bow to her husband.
- c. sisters bow to their brothers.

Ans: (b) and (c) wife bow to her husband/ sisters bow to their brothers.

5. How does one show appreciation while eating soup in Japan?

OR

What is the sign of appreciation when eating soup in Japan?

OR

Why do the Japanese make a fearful noise while eating soup?

Ans: When a person is eating soup offered by a host or hostess, he must make a fearful noise so as to show his sign of appreciation; otherwise, the host or hostess will think that the guest is ill-mannered.

6. How are the pavements in Brazil decorated? What does it tell us about the people there?

OR

Why do Brazilians decorate the pavements they walk on?

Ans: The grey pavements in Brazil are often decorated with beautiful black mosaics, a unique type of decoration. From this, we can infer that these people are alive to beauty.

in their surroundings. Secondly, they walk very slowly and meditatively and have a lot of time for contemplation.

7.What happens when leisurely people in Brazil get a steering wheel in their hands?

Ans: When leisurely people get a steering wheel in their hands, they drive their vehicles so fast that you would be inclined to believe that gaining a tenth of a second is a matter of grave importance for them all the time.

8.Who do the Brazilian drivers look out for when they are driving? Why?

Ans: The drivers are supposed to look out for pedestrians. But in Brazil, they do not care for people walking on the roads or people trying to cross the roads. They deliberately accelerate and laugh at pedestrians who run to survive. The drivers in Brazil treat pedestrians as fair prey to hunt and mow down.

9.What remarkable attitude is seen in the war between drivers?

Ans: The war between the drivers is murderous but good-tempered. They cut in, overtake on both sides and force the other person to break violently and commit all the most heinous crimes. But they smile at the other person without any anger, hostility, or mad hooting.

Japan and Brazil through a Traveller's Eye Comprehension II :

1.Why is bowing in Japan a complicated process?

Ans: 'Bowing' in Japan is complicated because they follow a complicated hierarchy in bowing which they have to follow as sacrosanct. The Japanese know very clearly who should bow to whom, how deeply, and for how long. For example, they follow certain basic rules inside the family. They are: "the wife bows to her husband, the child bows to his father, younger brothers to elder brothers, and the sister bows to all brothers". The Japanese reflect the smallest difference in rank, standing, age, social position in their bowing style in that split second.

2.Why does bowing, a natural practice in Japanese culture, look so quaint' and puzzling to the author?

Ans: 'Bowing', a natural practice in Japanese culture, looks so 'quaint' and puzzling to the author because when the Japanese bow, they bow neither too deeply nor not deeply enough and bow to the right person at the right time. They know who should bow to whom, how deeply, and for how long. They manage it without difficulty and subtly reflect even the smallest difference in rank, standing, age, and social position.

Secondly, they bow with the ceremonious serenity of a courtier yet with a great deal of natural and inimitable grace.

3. Do you think the author is finding fault with/making fun of the culture of bowing in Japanese and speeding cars in Brazil?

Ans: No. This article is a piece of travel writing. Travel writing is no longer viewed as a product of some innocent curiosity. It is also not an attempt to understand an alien culture objectively. Rather, this narrative should be read as the author's perspective on Japanese culture. The author is certainly not finding fault with the Japanese way of eating soup or their habit of bowing.

The author is only expressing his surprise when he looks at their cultural habits as an outsider. The language might sometimes appear to be used for a humorous effect. But, in a piece of creative writing, such liberties in their style must be accepted as natural. If the writer simply described objectively whatever he saw, the article will lose its human interest.

Similarly, the author is expressing his surprise at the way the drivers of four-wheelers move on the road in Brazil and the size of the fast-moving traffic. The author is also expressing his appreciation for the beautiful black mosaics seen on the pavements. He is also expressing his annoyance for the sluggishness of the leisurely walking pedestrians.

Japan and Brazil through a Traveller's Eye Comprehension III :

1. 'Bowling in Japan is quainter; more formal, more oriental.' Do you agree?

OR

How does George Mikes describe bowing to be a quainter and infectious trait of Japanese people?

Ans: Yes. In this article, the author introduces the reader to one of the most fascinating and conspicuous cultural habits of the Japanese people. He tells the reader that as soon as you land in Japan, you perceive immediately that the Japanese are exquisitely well-mannered. Very soon, you will also discover that the Japanese are very courteous and ensure that they do not violate a speaker's privacy while talking to someone over the phone. Then you come to be a witness to people bowing to each other almost everywhere as if it is an obsession with them.

However, the author records his appreciation for their skill and style of bowing. He says that people bow to each other with the ceremonious solemnity of a courtier and yet with

a great deal of natural and inimitable grace. Then he remarks that bowing is neither less nor more silly than shaking hands or kissing the cheek, but it is quainter, more formal, more oriental, and also infectious.

He says so because, while anyone can learn the art of shaking hands or kissing the cheek perfectly well, it is extremely difficult for a European to learn to do 'bowing' the way Japanese do because, in a split second, the Japanese manage to subtly reflect all the nuances one needs to follow while bowing. They successfully exhibit the smallest difference in rank, standing, age, and social position. On the other hand, if European attempts to bow to someone, he or she will bow too deeply or not deeply enough; they bow to the wrong man at the wrong time or they do not clasp their hands in front of them which is bad or they do in a wrong way which is considered even worse.

2. Describe how traffic in Brazil leads to humorous observations.

OR

Give an account of the crawling traffic in Brazil as mentioned by George Mikes.

OR

Write a note on traffic in Brazil.

Ans: George Mikes makes humorous comments on the 'traffic' in Copacabana and Avenida Presidente Vargas in particular and Brazil in general. He opines that Brazilians are easy-going and leisurely characters. But the very same people, the moment they get a steering wheel in their hands, no speed „ is fast for them. They drive with such speed that one would be inclined to believe that gaining a tenth of a second is a matter of grave importance for all of them, all the time. The writer talks about the increasing number of vehicles in Brazil and says that the increase in the number of vehicles is making the pedestrian's life more hazardous every day. He then narrates an interesting anecdote to give a clear idea of the number of vehicles moving on the road at any given time in Avenida Presidente Vargas.

He asks the reader to imagine that he is standing on one side of the road trying to cross the road. He will spend hours on end contemplating a fascinating problem: How can crawling traffic proceed at such a terrifying speed? He strengthens the same idea by another example. He asks the reader to imagine that a man on his side of the road suddenly catches sight of a friend of his on the other side of the road and starts waving to him. Then he shouts at him asking "How on earth did you get over there?" The other person will yell back at him, "How? I was born on this side!" The author leaves it to the readers to draw their own inferences.

3. What aspects of our social life, do you think, would appear quaint and odd to a foreign tourist?

Ans: India is a multi-ethnic, pluricultural, and multilingual country. People of different cultural practices, customs, and traditions are spread throughout the length and breadth of the country, thus making the population heterogeneous in character.

But, foreign tourists who visit India, most often come from countries where the population is homogeneous in character. Naturally, the foreign tourists find quite a few aspects of our social life, quaint and odd.

One of the commonest habits that might appear quaint to them is the way our womenfolk create patterns on the floor in front of their houses or gates, with chalk piece, coloured powder, or flower petals, called Rangoli.

Similarly, the buntings of mango leaves and plantain tree stem that we decorate our houses with special pooja days, auspicious occasions and festivals, and lighting lamps during Deepavali appear odd to them. Secondly, Indians' love and respect for the holy cow and monkeys as a symbol of god also appear quaint to them.

Another aspect that may appear quaint is the ritual of worshipping vehicles which are commonly seen during Ayudha Pooja. Apart from these, there are several habits which might make us bow our heads in shame. They are urinating in public, spitting chewed betel nut residues on the walls and roads, sneaking loudly over mobile phones in public places, jumping at railway and bus ticket counters and at bus stops, crossing roads where there are no pedestrian crossings, honking unnecessarily, parking vehicles on the footpath, disobeying signal lights, men staring at women walking on the street till she moves out of sight, putting up pandals for private functions on the road and blocking it for pedestrians and motorists, shoving garbage on the road, pedestrians jaywalking on the road, etc. Talking to strangers on trains and buses, enquiring them about their jobs and salaries, etc., are also some of the social aspects of Indians which appear quaint to foreigners.

The Voter - Chinua Achebe

A Note On The Writer :

Chinua Achebe (1930-2013) is a Nigerian novelist, poet, professor, and critic. Achebe's novels focus on the traditions of Igbo society, the effect of Christian influences, and the clash of Western and traditional African values during and after the colonial era. His style relies heavily on the Igbo oral tradition and combines straightforward narration with representations of folk stories, proverbs, and oratory. He also published a number of short stories, children's books, and essay collections. Some of his works are: 'Things Fall Apart', 'Arrow Of God', 'No Longer At Ease', 'Enemy Of The People' and 'Girls At War'.

The Voter Summary :

In this short story, Achebe offers a satirical picture of how politics and elections generally work in modern African countries like Nigeria.

The protagonist of the story is Rufus Okeke – Roof for short. The majority of the Igbo people in the village are illiterate, backward, and poor. Though the administration of the town is in the hands of a democratic government comprising elected representatives of the people, the people have not yet realized the value of their mandate and are also not yet aware of their rights. It is election time now. The ruling party PAP (People's Alliance Party) is seeking re-election. There is hardly any other party to obstruct or prevent the re-election of the existing government. One important aspect of this election is the re-election of Marcus Ibe, who is Minister of Culture in the outgoing government. The only other party, which appears to be a non-entity until now, is the POP – Progressive Organisation Party, and Maduka is its representative. The POP is making a strong attempt to garner some votes in its favour.

The focus of the author seems to be to capture the human drama in which a poor, pathetically innocent and naive people make a brave attempt to derive some monetary benefit during the election from a prospective candidate using the mediatory strategies of a literate young man of their town in when they have reposed a great deal of trust. However, the crux of the plot is how this very same trusted representative of the people manages to strike a rich bargain with the opposition party as well and yet remain loyal to both the parties.

When the story opens, we are introduced to Rufus Okeke. He is a very popular man in the village. His popularity is due to the fact that unlike people of his age, Roof has not abandoned his village seeking work in the towns. Secondly, he is also not a village lout. People like him because they believe that he has given up a bright future and come back to their village on his own after spending two years as a bicycle repairer's apprentice in Port Harcourt with the intention of guiding the people of the village.

In the next stage, the author tells us about the voters and the government. We learn that the whole village had voted en masse in favour of the People's Alliance Party and elected Honourable Marcus Ibe of their village, who had become Minister of Culture in the outgoing government. The author tells us in a satirical tone that Marcus Ibe was sure to be re-elected because there was hardly any other opposition party worth considering. From this situation, the reader can infer the predicament of the innocent people pitted against greedy and power-thirsty politicians. In a tone veiled in mild satire, the author says that Roof, the trusted representative of the people of Umuofia, was working as the election campaign manager for the Honourable Minister Marcus Ibe, who was seeking re-election from Umuofia.

The roof was more intelligent and cleverer than the common people of Umuofia. He had become a real expert in election campaigning at all levels – village, local government or national, that is why he was able to gauge the mood and temper of the electorate at any given time. This time, he has been intelligent enough to warn Marcus Ibe that a radical change has come into the thinking of the people in Umuofia since the last election. Thus he kindles the interest of the reader.

The villagers had come to realize that in five years, politics had brought wealth, chieftaincy titles, doctorate degrees and other honours readily to the man whom they had given their votes free of charge five years ago. It is also a paradox that the people who had empowered a person to enjoy such benefits themselves remained poor and ignorant. They did not even know that a doctorate degree holder is not a medical doctor. Anyhow, the people were now ready to try the value of their votes in a different way.

The author then narrates the expectations of the people in Umuofia. The people had now witnessed the 'good' things done by politics to their own elected representative Marcus Ibe. Before getting elected, he was only a fairly successful mission school teacher and was on the verge of getting dismissed on the basis of a female teacher's complaint. Just at that moment, politics had come to their village and at that opportune moment Marcus Ibe had wisely joined up. By doing so he had escaped dismissal.

Secondly, he got elected and became 'Chief the Honourable' in the government. Consequently, he got two long cars and had built himself the biggest house in that village. But, he remained a devoted leader of his people. In a satirical tone, the author says that whenever he could, he left the good things of the capital and returned to his village which had neither running water nor electricity, but he had lately installed a private plant to supply electricity to his new house in the village. The writer comments that Marcus knew the source of his good fortune hinting that it is the people of Umuofia who are responsible for his prosperity.

Marcus Ibe had christened his new house 'Umuofia Mansions' in honour of his village and on the day the house was opened, he had hosted a grand lunch to his people slaughtering five bulls and countless goats. Moreover, the house was opened by the Archbishop. Thus the writer gives a rosy picture of the eminence and prosperity of Marcus which politics had bestowed on him.

The author describes the reactions of the people of Umuofia after they had enjoyed Marcus's hospitality. There is subtle irony in the description. The people are full of praise for Marcus' hospitality. But, they also know that Marcus owes his riches to his getting elected and joining the government. We can perceive a tone of regret when the people conclude after the feasting was over that they had underrated the power of the ballot paper earlier and that they should not do it again. This is the radical change in people's attitude towards casting their ballot paper in an election free of charge without expecting any benefits.

Since Roof had already warned Marcus Ibe about it, Marcus had also taken suitable measures to meet the expectations of the people. "He had drawn five months' salary in advance and changed a few hundred pounds into shining shillings and had armed his campaign boys with eloquent little jute bags". Having sensed that the people of Umuofia will not cast their ballot paper in his favour, free of cost, Marcus had sent money to bribe and persuade the voters to vote for him. The contesting candidate would make his speeches in the morning and at night his expert election managers would conduct their whispering campaign.

Here 'whispering campaign' refers to the way election managers visit voters' houses in the evening after sunset and tell the voters about the prospect of their candidate becoming minister. Thereby they appeal to people's self-esteem and the honour that is going to be bestowed on their town and finally bribe them into casting their vote in favour of their political party.

We see how the radical change in people brings about a change in the nature of the election process and affects the sanctity of the people's mandate.

We witness a whispering campaign conducted by Roof in the house of Ogbuefi Ezenwa, a man of the high traditional title. Roof addresses a group of elders and tells them that his party PAP has made a man of their village a minister in the outgoing government. Roof tries to argue that it is a great honour for one of their sons to be singled out for this honour. Then he tells them that PAP leaders look upon Umuofia with a favourable attitude and whether they cast their vote in his favour or not, PAP will form the government. He also tries to hint at the promise made by PAP to the people of Umuofia that they will give pipe-borne water to their village.

After Roof had finished talking, Ogbuefi Ezenwa spoke to Roof. He tells him that they believe as true every word he has said and every one of them would cast his vote for Marcus. He also promises to get their wives' votes too in his favour. But, he then tells him straightaway that it is shameful to accept two shillings for their vote. He then says that if Marcus were a poor man they would give their vote free as they had done it before. Then the old leader argues that Marcus is a great man and does his things like a great man. Then he tells Roof that they did not demand money before and they will not ask him in future.

The writer also uses the same language to mock at Roof. He says that Roof had also lately been taking down a 'lot of firewood' from Marcus. The previous day, he had taken a rich robe from Marcus. Moreover, Marcus himself had rebuked his wife when she objected to Roof taking his fifth bottle of beer from the refrigerator. Furthermore, Roof had been chauffeur-driven to the disputed site, about a land case which he won. Having enjoyed all such benefits from Marcus, Roof understood the demands of the elders. Therefore, he finally drops two more shillings in front of each one of them and tells them in a tone of finality that he is through with it, and pretends to be defiant. Then he ends his campaign with the sentence, "Cast your paper for the enemy if you like!" The elders quickly calm him down with a placatory speech agreeing to vote for Marcus, and pick up the coins on the floor, with a feeling that they have not lost their decorum and dignity in the bargain.

The author has until now introduced the reader to the existing situation. Now he is going to talk about the opposition party. The author here satirises how opposition parties come into being and how sincere they are in their objectives and in their fighting strategies.

In his 'whispering campaign', Roof had asked the elders, in the end, to give their vote to the enemy. The enemy of PAP was a new party called the Progressive Organisation Party (POP). It had been formed by the tribes down the coast. The founders of the party claimed that they had founded the party to save themselves from "totally political, cultural, social and religious annihilation". The party organizers (of POP) knew that they had no chance of winning against the PAP, yet they had taken the plunge for a straight fight with PAP. They had provided cars and loudspeakers to a few rascals and thugs to go around and make a lot of noise. The author hints that they had also spent a lot of money in Umuofia. The writer comments that such money will only make the local campaigners very rich.

The action now reaches the climax. The writer tells the reader that as the election day was approaching nearer, for Roof "everything was moving as planned".

One evening the leader of the POP campaign team comes to visit Roof. Although they were well known to each other, his visit is cold and businesslike. He places five pounds on the floor before Roof and tells him that they want his vote. Roof immediately gets up from his chair, closes the outside door carefully and comes back to his chair. Within that short time Roof has weighed the proposition. Roof tries to give a reason to the other person for not accepting his proposition. Roof tells him that he was working for Marcus and it would be very bad to accept it. But the other person had come prepared for such an answer. So he tells him that Marcus would not be there when Roof puts his ballot paper in the box. Then, in a dismissive tone, he tells Roof that they have plenty of work to do that night, and asks him whether he is going to accept it or not.

Roof asks him whether anyone would talk about it outside. The other man tells him categorically that they wanted votes and not gossip. Roof accepts the money. Then they get Roof to swear that he would vote for Maduka in front of a little object called 'iyi', which had been brought from Mbanta. However, Roof does not hesitate but says aloud that he would cast his vote for Maduka, failing which the 'iyi' will take note. The other man is satisfied and leaves. Before he leaves Roof tells him that Maduka has no chance of winning against Marcus. But the other person tells him that it would be enough if he gets a few votes that time, and he "would get more in the following election. All that they wanted was to make the people know that Maduka will give pounds and not shillings".

The narrator describes the town and the mood of the people. We learn that Chief the Honourable Marcus Ibe was doing things in grand style. He hires a highlife band from Umuru and stations it at a distance considered lawful. Many villagers dance to the music before proceeding to the booths. Some people shake hands with the great man 'Marcus' and congratulate him in advance. Roof and his campaign boys give last-minute

advice to the people and try to win Marcus' appreciation. The writer then tells us that Marcus was a stickler for details. He wants to ensure that not a single vote goes to the other party. Therefore, as soon as the first rush of voters is over, he promptly asks his campaign boys to go one at a time and put in their ballot papers. He asks Roof to go first.

Roof dashes off towards the booths without any hesitation. After the electoral officer has explained to him about the two boxes, he goes in and sees the two boxes one of which has the picture of the car and the other, the head. Roof brings out his ballot paper and looks at it. He does not like to betray Marcus even in secret. For a few seconds, he feels like going back to the other man and returning his five pounds. Then he realizes that it is impossible because he has sworn on that 'iyi'. Then he recalls the red five-pound notes. Roof's mind works quick as lightning. He folds the paper, tears it in two along the crease and puts one half in each box. He puts the first half into Maduka's box and says to himself aloud, "I vote for Maduka", and comes out. The election officials mark his thumb with indelible purple ink and he walks out of the booth as jauntily as he has gone in.

The Voter Comprehension I :

1.The roof was a popular young man because of he-

- a. had not abandoned his village.2nd PUC English Textbook Answers Springs Chapter 12 The Voter
- b. wanted to guide his people.
- c. was forced to return to his village.

Ans: (a) had not abandoned his village.

2.Why was Marcus considered rich and powerful?

Ans: Marcus had two long cars and had just built himself the biggest house anyone had seen in these parts. He had entertained his people slaughtering five bulls and countless goats to feed the people. Though the village had no electricity, he had installed a private plant to supply electricity to his new home. Secondly, his house was opened by the Archbishop. Thirdly, he had been made a minister after he won the election. That is why he was considered rich and powerful.

3.Marcus Ibe had earlier been

- a. doctor
- b. schoolteacher
- c. politician.

Ans: (b) school teacher.

4.The fact that Marcus Ibe left the good things of the capital and returned to his village whenever he could, shows

- a. his devotion to his people and love for the place
 - b. he enjoyed all the comforts of the city in his village.
 - c. he wanted to improve the amenities in his village.
- Ans: (b) he enjoyed all the comforts of the city in his village.

5.After the feasting, the villagers

- a. praised Marcus's faithfulness and generosity.
- b. intended to demand more for their votes
- c. realized Marcus's wealth.

Ans: (c) realized Marcus's wealth.

6.The 'whispering campaign' is

- a. secret campaigning at night
- b. bargaining for votes.

c. clandestine distribution of money.

Ans: (c) clandestine distribution of money.

7.The village elder Ezenwa tilted the lamp a little because

a. he could not see properly.

b. the place was too dark.

c. he wanted to confirm the amount paid to each.

Ans: (c) he wanted to confirm the amount paid to each.

8.‘Firewood’ refers to

a. Roof taking advantage of the situation.

b. the advantages of being a voter.

c. the benefits the elders received.

Ans: (c) the benefits the elders received.

9.Roof and the leader of the POP campaign team were

a. friends.

b. strangers.

c. acquaintances.

Ans: (a, c) friends/acquaintances.

10.The roof was mesmerized by

a. the red notes on the floor.

b. the picture of the cocoa farmer.

c. the POP campaign leader.

Ans: (a) the red notes on the floor.

11.Roof’s act of inserting the torn ballot papers in two boxes signifies

a. keeping his promise.

b. appeasing Iyi

c. absolving himself of his guilt

Ans: (c) absolving himself of his guilt.

The Voter Comprehension II :

1.Trace the change in the attitude of the villagers before the second election. Give reasons.

OR

Why did the people decide not to cast their vote for free in the forthcoming

election?

OR

Explain the change that had come into the thinking of Umuofia in 'The Voter'.

OR

Trace the reasons behind the 'radical change' that had come into the thinking of Umuofia in 'The Voter'.

Ans: In this short story, Chinua Achebe makes an attempt to present before the reader how 'elections' lose their sanctity and are misused by greedy politicians for self-aggrandizement instead of bringing about improvement in the life of the people.

The people of Umuofia vote en masse in favor of the People's Alliance Party and elect Marcus Ibe, a local teacher, as their leader. Once getting elected, people see a great many changes in Marcus' life. Their elected representative becomes wealthy, is awarded chieftaincy titles and doctorate degrees, besides many other honours. He also builds a huge mansion in his native village and names it 'Umuofia Mansions'. He spends most of his time in the capital and comes back to stay in his village mansion sometimes.

The villagers do not have running water and electricity, but he gets a private plant installed in his village to supply electricity to his new house. To top it all, his new house is opened by the Archbishop. On the day the new house is opened, he hosts a grand dinner to all the people of his village, slaughtering five bulls and countless goats. The common people realize that winning an election can change an ordinary mission school teacher into a wealthy and powerful man.

They also know that it is their ballot which has given him all those benefits. They recall that they had given their votes free of charge five years ago. They realize that they had underrated the power of the ballot paper and should not do so again. That is why, in the second election, they demand money for their votes.

2.What was the justification for the formation of the POP?

OR

What reasons are given for the formation of the POP?

Ans: POP stands for Progressive Organisation Party. This party is formed by the tribes down the coast to save themselves from 'totally political, cultural, social and religious annihilation'. The POP was a complete non-entity in the first election. Once the organizers come to know that there is no opposition party, some rich members of the tribes down the coast, form this party. They want the people to know that they will be paid pounds and not shillings if they listen to them and vote for them. In the story, we do not get any hint about the objectives of the PAP, but the organizers of the POP claim

that they want to save the people from political, religious, cultural annihilation, though they appear to be no better.

From the situation described in the story, we can infer that the writer intends to tell the reader that no political party is seriously interested in improving the welfare of the people. They seem to know for sure that by winning an election, they can take the government in their hands and become rich. They seem to be unaware of their duties and responsibilities.

**3.The roof is an intelligent manipulator. Justify with reference to the story,
OR**

What is the role played by Roof in ‘The Voter’?

Ans: Roof Okeke is an energetic young man and has come back to his own village Umuofia, after working as a bicycle repairer’s apprentice for two years in Port Harcourt. It is true that he would have enjoyed a rich life if he had stayed on in his job. But he comes back to the village and tells the people that he wants to guide them in difficult times. Later he becomes an ‘election campaign manager’ for Marcus Ibe and over a period of five years becomes an expert in election campaigning at all levels.

In the story, we get to know more about Roof when he is on the job, engaged in one of his whispering campaigns. He tells the elders that Marcus Ibe, being a ‘son’ from their village, has been made a minister and it should be considered a great honour. Then he tries to use his rationalistic thinking with the people. He asks them, “Do you ever stop to ask yourselves why we should be singled out for this honour?” He himself answers his question. He tells them that they are favoured by the PAP leaders. Here we see Roof as a manipulator at work. He knows for sure that Marcus was perhaps the only man with some education.

Secondly, there was no opposition party. Basically, the village folk were innocent and naive and hardly realized the meaning of an election and the value of their mandate. Roof exploits this situation to his advantage.

Moreover, when he comes to learn that people had understood the benefits of entering politics and winning an election as seen in the case of Marcus Ibe and are now planning not to give their vote free of charge, he immediately informs Marcus and keeps him prepared to pay some money to the people in exchange for their votes.

Finally, we get a clear picture of Roof as a manipulator when he accepts five pounds from the election manager of POR. He makes sure that they will not disclose the news of his accepting the money. He also tries to keep his conscience clear by telling them that

he works for Marcus; while putting his ballot paper into the box, he cleverly manages to cast his vote for both Marcus and Maduka, without attracting the wrath of 'Iyi'.

The Voter Comprehension III :

1.The POP campaign leader's meeting with Roof shows the misuse of transparency in a democratic setup. Discuss.

Ans: In this story, Achebe satirizes 'politicians' and makes an attempt to show how even in a democratic setup election can become farcical.

Unlike in dictatorship or monarchy, in a democratic setup, people have the freedom to elect a 'person' to work as their representative in the government and work for their upliftment. One of the hallmarks of democracy is its insistence on transparency. Every person is subject to scrutiny by the public in the election process. A person is free to vote for a person of his choice from among the contestants. 'Transparency' in this refers to Roof's informing the POP campaign leader that he is working for Marcus.

Secondly, whether Roof informs him or not, it is well known to everyone that Roof is Marcus' election campaign manager. The candidates are permitted by law to make known to the people all such appointments and maintain transparency in their dealings.

However, no candidate can strike a deal with the people and buy their votes. But this is done clandestinely. The POP campaign leader knows that Roof is working for Marcus. Therefore, they want to buy Roof's vote first so that they will let him know that the POP leaders will pay in pounds and not in shillings. This is the message they want to put across to the people through Roof. Probably, next time, Roof who has made a name as an efficient election campaign manager for Marcus, will be bold enough to demand 'pounds' instead of shillings from Marcus and if he refuses to pay in pounds, he might go and work for the POP leader. That way he will be able to motivate his people to vote for POP instead of the circus. Thus, the POP campaign managers' meeting with Roof is daring misuse of transparency in a democratic setup.

2.To every human comes a time of reckoning. How does Roof's dilemma on the day of the election reflect this?

OR

Why did Roof face a dilemma while he was inside the voting booth? How did he resolve it?

OR

"There comes a time in every man's life to decide". Explain with reference to 'The

Voter’.

Ans: In ‘The Voter’, Roof is an energetic young man who has the reputation of sacrificing a bright future for the sake of the people of his village. The roof has worked in a city for two years and has experience in dealing with both literates and illiterates. Based on this knowledge of general human behaviour, Roof builds for himself a career as an election campaign manager for Marcus Ibe.

When the story opens, we learn that Marcus Ibe is Chief the Honourable Minister of Culture in the outgoing government and is seeking people’s mandate for a second term. We also learn that Marcus considers Roof a real expert in election campaigning at all levels. Roof knows how politicians make money. He also knows that the people of Umuofia have now decided to vote for Marcus for a price. Roof conveys this news to Marcus and prepares him beforehand.

Like an efficient manager, he tries to highlight the strong points of PAP and finally strike a bargain with the voters paying them four shillings per vote. Everything is now going according to his plan and is happy.

But, one evening, the leader of the POP campaign team comes to his house to meet him. He tempts Roof to vote for Maduka paying him five pounds. Roof’s greed tempts him to accept the offer. But, he also gets trapped. The leader asks him to swear on the ‘Iyi’, that he would vote for Maduka.

The roof cannot go back on his promise. So he swears to vote for Maduka. Finally, on the day of the voting, Marcus wants to make sure that every one of his people casts his vote without fail. Therefore, Roof being his election manager, Marcus sends him to the booth first to vote. Now, Roof is caught in a moral dilemma. All along he has worked for Marcus and his conscience does not permit him to cheat Marcus. Now, when Marcus asks him to cast his vote he is in two minds. He feels that he cannot betray Marcus. For a moment, his mind tells him that he should vote for Marcus and go back and return the money he had received from the POP election manager.

Secondly, he remembers that he had sworn on that ‘Iyi’. In a few seconds, his mind hits on a new idea. He folds the ballot paper in the middle and tears it into two halves at the crease. He drops the first half into the box meant for Maduka and confirms his vote saying that he votes for Maduka. Since he has not taken an oath to vote for Marcus, there is no fear of ‘Iyi’ in him but only his guilt. Since he has worked as his manager for money and rewards, he drops the other half into the box meant for Marcus. Thus, he ensures that he does not cheat either. By tearing the ballot paper and casting his vote for both of them he overcomes his moral dilemma.

3.What comment does the story offer on the electoral system? Is it relevant?

Ans: In 'The Voter', Achebe tries to present a true picture of the drama that is witnessed during an election held in a small town in Nigeria. There are two main characters and two political parties in the story and the voters are the villagers of Umuofia.

The roof is an energetic young man, who is now working as the election campaign manager for Marcus Ibe, who was once a local mission school teacher and was on the verge of dismissal from service on the basis of a female teacher's complaint.

Marcus Ibe joins the People's Alliance Party, contests the election, and gets elected. He becomes a minister and his government completes a five-year term and he is now seeking re-election. During his term as a minister, he amasses a lot of wealth, comes to own two big cars, builds a huge mansion in his native village, and wins several chieftaincy titles and doctorate degrees.

But his people remain the same – poor, illiterate, ignorant, and naive. The situation in his village also does not show any improvement. The same old problems of lack of running water and electricity continue to plague the people and prevent them from improving economically and politically. When the story opens, we learn that Marcus Ibe is seeking a second term and everyone is sure that he is going to get a landslide victory because there is no opposition party worth taking into consideration.

But there is a change in the perception of the people. After feasting in Marcus' new house and noticing his wealth and power, the poor people of Umuofia realize that 'elections' do have a meaning and their votes which they had underrated before, are of high value. Therefore, they demand some value for their votes and Roof manages to convince them that they should vote for Marcus again by giving four shillings each.

Some tribes down the coast had set up a new political party called POP with the objective of saving the people from 'totally political, cultural, social and religious annihilation'. Their campaign leader comes to Roof's house and offers to buy his vote for five pounds. Roof initially is enamoured of the five-pound notes and agrees to vote.

But the POP leader cleverly gets him to swear on the 'iyi' that he will vote for Maduka. Finally, on election day, his conscience pricks him to a little extent and Roof feels like voting loyally for Marcus and returning the money to the POP election manager. But the oath he has taken before 'iyi' does not allow him to do so and there is a moral dilemma. However, Roof cuts his ballot paper in two, drops one half into the box meant for

Maduka and drops the other half into the box meant for Marcus, and saves his conscience and his life too. This is the story in a nutshell.

There are lessons to learn from this story. We must note that merely naming our government as 'democracy' and setting up all the things needed for holding elections do not guarantee that people will be able to exercise their true mandate and will elect competent members to the government which will strive for the upliftment of the people socially, educationally, economically and culturally. We cannot guarantee democratic governance by merely holding elections regularly. First, we must educate the people about their rights, duties, and responsibilities in any election.

Secondly, we must ensure that people have the right to recall their representatives if they do not strive to improve a lot of people. Thirdly, elected representatives must be forced to account for their earnings after joining the government. Finally, there should be an authority which should oversee that sanctity of election procedures is not tampered with.

Also, those who get elected are self-centered and exploit the people and the situation to their benefit. On the whole, one can argue that by merely holding elections regularly we cannot ensure that a democratic government will come into place.

Secondly, the electoral system that is now in place in the story is not foolproof. As regards the relevance of the story to our own situation, one can argue that it is highly relevant even today. Even after nearly seven decades of independence, we have not been able to ensure free and fair elections, the main reason being the lack of education and moral values. We are witness to every type of corrupt practice in elections.

4. 'Democracy is more than holding elections regularly.' Do you think the story supports this statement?

Ans: In 'The Voter', Achebe tries to present a true picture of the drama that is witnessed during an election held in a small town in Nigeria. There are two main characters and two political parties in the story and the voters are the villagers of Umuofia.

The roof is an energetic young man, who is now working as the election campaign manager for Marcus Ibe, who was once a local mission school teacher and was on the verge of dismissal from service on the basis of a female teacher's complaint.

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own two big cars, builds a huge mansion in his native village, and wins several chieftaincy titles and doctorate degrees.

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But the POP leader cleverly gets him to swear on the 'iyi' that he will vote for Maduka. Finally, on election day, his conscience pricks him to a little extent and Roof feels like voting loyally for Marcus and returning the money to the POP election manager. But the oath he has taken before 'iyi' does not allow him to do so and there is a moral dilemma. However, Roof cuts his ballot paper in two, drops one half into the box meant for Maduka and drops the other half into the box meant for Marcus, and saves his conscience and his life too. This is the story in a nutshell.

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Secondly, we must ensure that people have the right to recall their representatives if they do not strive to improve a lot of people. Thirdly, elected representatives must be forced to account for their earnings after joining the government. Finally, there should

be an authority which should oversee that sanctity of election procedures is not tampered with.

Also, those who get elected are self-centred and exploit the people and the situation to their benefit. On the whole, one can argue that by merely holding elections regularly we cannot ensure that a democratic government will come into place. Secondly, the electoral system that is now in place in the story is not foolproof.

As regards the relevance of the story to our own situation, one can argue that it is highly relevant even today. Even after nearly seven decades of independence, we have not been able to ensure free and fair elections, the main reason being the lack of education and moral values. We are witness to every type of corrupt practice in elections.

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Where there is a Wheel - P. Sainath

A Note On The Writer :

Palagummi Sainath (born 1957) is an Indian journalist and photojournalist focusing on social problems, rural affairs, poverty and aftermath of globalization in India. He is the Rural Affairs Editor of The Hindu. A regular contributor to The Telegraph in Kolkata, he also writes for the fortnightly Frontline and the daily Business Line in Chennai.

Sainath has received close to forty national and international journalism awards and fellowships in thirty years as a journalist, including the Ramon Magsaysay journalism award in 2007, the European Commission's Natali Prize in 1994, the Boerma journalism Prize from the UN FAO in 2001, the Amnesty International global award for human rights journalism in 2000, and the B.D. Goenka Award for excellence in journalism in 2000. In June 2011, Sainath was conferred an Honorary Doctor of Letters degree (DLitt) by the University of Alberta, the university's highest honour.

Where there is a Wheel Summary :

This lesson is an article taken from a book titled 'Everybody Loves a Good Drought', by P. Sainath, a popular photo-journalist. Besides giving a brief history of 'cycling' as a social movement in Pudukkottai, he also reports how a group of women initiated the remaining women in the village to learn 'cycling' so as to use it as a symbol of independence, freedom and mobility. Finally, he also comments on the general impact of this on women's lives in the Pudukkottai district of Tamil Nadu.

The author begins the article commenting that when people hear the caption, "Cycling as a social movement", it may sound far-fetched to them, but it is true. Then the author remarks that "people find curious ways of hitting out at their backwardness, of expressing defiance, a hammering at the fetters that hold them".

The author then quotes statistics to prove his point. He reports that over the past eighteen months, 100000 rural women have taken to bicycling as a symbol of independence, freedom and mobility, and their number constitutes over one-fourth of all rural Women in Pudukkottai. Among them over 70000 of them have taken part in public exhibition-cum-contests to proudly display their skills, yet the desire to learn 'cycling' and the 'training camps' continue.

The author then tells us how two of the participants Jameela Bibi, and Fatima, a secondary school teacher, feel about their achievement in cycling. The author quotes Jameela Bibi, who says, "It's my right, we can go anywhere. Now I don't have to wait for a bus". Similarly, he quotes Fatima also. Fatima says, "There is freedom in cycling. We are not dependent on anyone now. I can never give this up!" Jameela, Fatima and their friend Avakanni, all in their early twenties, have trained scores of other young women in the art of cycling.

The author remarks that "Cycling has swept across this district; women agricultural workers, quarry labourers and village health nurses are among its fans. They are now being followed by balwadi and Anganwadi workers, gem cutters, school teachers, gramasevikas and mid-day meal workers. The vast majority are those who have just become literate". The district's vigorous literacy drive led by Arivoli Iyakkam (Light of Knowledge Movement) has been quick to tap this energy. The author has spoken to every one of these 'neo-literate', 'neo-cyclist' women and asserts that there is a direct link between cycling and the neo-cyclists' personal independence.

Then he reports the opinion of the coordinator who says that the "cycling training has given confidence to women and it has reduced their dependence on men".

The author says that he often sees a woman doing a four-kilometre stretch on her bicycle to collect water, sometimes with her children. He opines that women can cart provisions from other places on their own. Initially, these women had to put up with vicious attacks on their character. Even filthy remarks used to be made by men. He praises the 'Arivoli' organisation for volunteering to give social sanction to cycling.

Next, he mentions the 'Cycle Training Camp' that he had seen in Kilakuruchi village. He says that it was an unusual experience to see all the prospective learners who had turned out in their Sunday best. They appeared to be determined to learn cycling. The Arivoli activists produced songs for the neo-cyclists to encourage bicycling. The author quotes a line which says, "O sisters, come learn cycling, move with the wheel of time".

Then, we learn that those who got trained in cycling came back in large numbers to help new learners. They worked free of charge for Arivoli as 'master trainers'. Then, he comments that there is not only a desire to learn but a widespread perception among them that 'all women ought to learn cycling'.

In the next part of the report, the writer gives a brief historical background to cycling as a social movement. He reports that in 1991 a former district collector by name Sheela

Rani Chunkath hit on the idea of training female literacy activists so as to reach women in interior villages. She also included 'mobility' (for women) as a part of the literacy drive, because lack of mobility among women played a big role in weakening the confidence of women. It is reported that Chunkath paid personal attention to this idea and motivated the banks to give loans to women to buy cycles. Each block was assigned specific duties in promoting the drive. The district collector met with great success in her plan. Due to the initiative taken by her, the literacy activists learned cycling.

This encouraged the neo-literates, and their example was followed by every woman in the village to learn cycling. This led to a shortage of 'ladies' cycles. Then the women started using 'gents' cycles. In fact, some women even preferred 'gents' cycles because it has an additional bar from the seat to the handle. The author then says, even to this day thousands of women here ride 'gents' cycles.

On the International Women's Day in 1992, over 1500 female cyclists with flags on the handlebars, bells ringing, took Pudukkottai by storm. The towns' inhabitants were stunned by this all women's cycle rally.

The writer describes the reactions of the men to this social movement. The author gives the opinion of S. Kanakarajan, owner of Ram Cycles. The cycle dealer says that he had seen a rise of over 350 per cent in the sales of 'ladies' cycles in one year. But the author believes that the percentage of increase mentioned by the cycle agent is incorrect because a lot of women have gone in for 'gents' cycles as they could not wait for 'ladies' cycles. Then the writer remarks that not all males were hostile and some men were even encouraging in their attitude. For instance, Muthu Bhaskaran, a male Arivoli activist, wrote the famous cycling song that has become their anthem.

The writer cites the example of Manormani to illustrate how learning to ride a bicycle can help stone quarry workers also. The twenty-two-year-old Manormani is a stone quarry worker and Arivoli volunteer. She works in Kudimianmalai's stone quarries. According to her, it is vital for her co-workers to learn cycling because their working places are a little cut off from the main road. Those who learn cycling can be mobile (which means they can go home after work and come back the next day, otherwise, they will have to stay there alone in a new place facing a lot of problems or travel by bus every day). The writer says that in 1992, more than 70000 women displayed their cycling skills at the public 'exhibition-cum-contests' run by Arivoli. The UNICEF, who were impressed with the achievement of these activists, sanctioned fifty mopeds for Arivoli women activists.

The writer gives his views about cycling as a social movement. He says that cycling boosts income. Some of the women sell agricultural or other produce within a group of villages. For such people, cycling saves time. Secondly, cycling gives you more time to focus on selling your produce. Thirdly, it helps you to cover a larger area. Lastly, it can increase your leisure time too. Earlier, small producers had to carry their produce only by bus and had to depend on fathers, brothers, husbands, or sons even to reach the bus stop. They could cover only a limited number of villages to sell their produce as they had to do so on foot.

Moreover, these women had to rush back early to tend to the children and perform other chores like fetching water. Those who had bicycles now combined these difficult tasks without any anxiety or tension. Even now one can see along some remote road, a young mother, with a child on the cycle bar and, produce on the carrier. She could also be seen carrying two or even three pots of water hung across the back, and cycling towards work or home.

Finally, the author opines that for these neo-literate/neo-cyclist women, more than the economic aspect, the sense of self-respect it brings is vital. The author admits in a confessing tone that never before had he seen that humble vehicle (cycle) in that light – the bicycle as a metaphor for freedom. Before concluding, the writer quotes Kannammal who opines that for rural women it is a Himalayan achievement like flying an aeroplane.

In the last paragraph, the author adds a postscript. He says that in April 1995, when the author returned to Pudukkottai, the craze for learning cycling was still on (three years later). Then he adds that a large number of women were unable to afford bicycles which then cost around Rs. 1400 each. He concludes saying that Pudukkottai remains unique among Indian districts for the stunning proportion of women who have taken to cycling and the enthusiasm for gaining the skill among the rest.

Where there is a Wheel Comprehension I :

1.What does cycling as a symbol of social mobility mean?

Ans: Cycling through the word evokes minute meaning, it is broader when it comes to society. Social mobility has two meanings literally. It moves society from one place to another, which means the transportation of people, and it also connotes the progress of society. When women want to go for a market they do not want to wait for men they could go on themselves.

2.When Jameela Bibi says, “It is my right. We can go anywhere”, she is

- a. asserting her right to move freely.
- b. suggesting mobility leading to liberation.
- c. expressing her indifference to dirty remarks.
- d. boasting about her cycling skill.

Ans: (a) asserting her right to move freely.

3.What does bicycle represent for the rural women?

OR

Mention any one of the symbols which bicycling represents for the women.

Ans: For the rural women bicycle represents ‘freedom’.

4.What is common between neo-literates and neo-cyclists?

Ans: Cycling as a social movement was first popularized by the neo-literates. These neo-literates are the ones who became neo-cyclists.

5.‘Enforced routine’ and ‘male imposed barrier’ refer to

- a. confining women to the kitchen.
- b. subjecting women to drudgery.
- c. status of women in a patriarchal society.
- d. lack of freedom of movement

Ans: (c) status of women in a patriarchal society.

6.How did the men react to women taking to cycling?

Ans: Initially, women had to put up with vicious attacks on their character. Some of the men made filthy remarks. But later, once it got social sanction from the Arivoli organization, some menfolk became less hostile and some of them even encouraged the women to learn cycling.

7.What do the phrases ‘flags on the handlebar’ and ‘bells ringing’ suggest?

Ans: The phrases ‘flags on the handlebar’ and ‘bells ringing’ refer to the women’s cycle

rally organized on International Women's Day in 1992 in which 1500 female cyclists took Pudukkottai by storm.

8. Why did UNICEF sanction mopeds to Arivoli women activists?

Ans: The UNICEF sanctioned fifty mopeds to Arivoli women activists in appreciation of their work of initiating more than 70000 women to display their cycling skills at the public 'exhibition-cum-contests' in a single week in 1992.

9. Why is the cycle called 'the humble vehicle'?

Ans: The word 'humble' means 'poor', the lowest in rank. The writer calls the cycle a humble vehicle because it is the most common and ubiquitous vehicle seen even in the most remote of places, a common man's vehicle.

Where there is a Wheel Comprehension II :

1. What is the role of Arivoli Iyakkam in liberating women?

Ans: In Pudukkottai district there is an organization called Arivoli Iyakkam (Light of Knowledge Movement) which spearheaded the district's vigorous literacy drive. N. Kannammal is the central coordinator of Arivoli. This literacy organization conducted literacy campaigns among rural women and created a good number of neo-literates. Later, the Arivoli literacy activists, led by N.

Kannammal pioneered the cycling learning movement and thus gave cycling a social sanction. Later, at Kilakuruchi village, the Arivoli activists conducted a cycling training camp for their neo-literates as well as other women enthusiasts. A large number of those who learnt cycling come to train new learners, as master trainers, and this way they helped nearly 70000 rural women to learn cycling. Thus, by teaching them to read and write along with 'cycling', the Arivoli organization liberated a vast majority of the rural women in the Pudukkottai District.

2. In what different ways has the cycle empowered rural women?

OR

Discuss how the cycling movement has empowered the rural women of Pudukkottai.

Ans: 'Cycling' empowers women in many ways. It gives them 'confidence' which results from being self-dependent and free to carry out their duties and responsibilities without depending on the menfolk. For example, womenfolk can fetch water from even the remotest source and cart provisions on their own. In this way, cycling emancipates womenfolk psychologically. Cycling also empowers women economically and politically.

Cycling boosts their income. Some of the women who sell agricultural or other products within a group of villages can save a great deal of time by going to such places on their bicycles.

Secondly, it gives them much more time to focus on selling their produce. Thirdly, it enlarges the area they can hope to cover. Finally, if they choose to enjoy their leisure, cycling gives them a lot of leisure also. These women, besides performing these jobs, can also perform other chores. Finally, to top it all, it gives them self-respect. They can also participate in political work.

3. Why does the author describe the Arivoli 'cycling training camp's unusual experience?

Ans: One of the pioneers in encouraging 'cycling' and giving it a social sanction was the Arivoli activists. These activists conducted a 'cycling training camp' in Kilakuruchi village. The writer, who visited the camp, calls it an unusual experience because, on that Sunday, all the prospective learners had turned out in their Sunday best. The author remarks that one could not help being struck by the sheer passion of the pro-cycling movement. The learners exuded so much enthusiasm and passion for learning cycling.

4. Do you think neo-literate women taking to cycling contributes to the literacy movement?

Ans: Yes. Women taking up cycling is as significant as their taking up literacy because cycling gives them mobility, freedom, and independence which together give the women confidence to stand on their own legs. Initially, Sheela Rani Chunkath, a district collector, in 1991 intended to train female literacy activists so as to enable them to spread literacy among women in the interior. Therefore, she included mobility as a part of the literacy drive.

However, cycling played a much more significant role than literacy in the lives of the womenfolk. It gave them confidence, freedom, and independence to eke out an independent existence. Cycling helped them stay attached to their children and family and yet be financially independent. It also helped the women to share family responsibilities with the menfolk.

5. How does Sheela Rani Chunkath, the district collector, promote the empowerment of women?

OR

Bring out the role of Sheela Rani Chunkath in the empowerment of women in Pudukkottai.

Ans: In 1991, Sheela Rani Chunkath was the district collector of Pudukkottai. As a part of the female literacy drive, she wanted to train female literacy activists so that literacy would reach women in the interior. She had realized that the lack of mobility among women played a big role in undermining their confidence. Therefore, she included 'mobility' as a part of the literacy drive. Naturally, literacy activists learned cycling first. This inspired the neo-literates also to learn cycling. This, in turn, inspired every woman in the village to learn cycling.

The literates, having become neo-cyclists, encouraged every woman in the district to learn cycling, by organizing 'cycle training camps'. Thus, Sheela Rani Chunkath became instrumental in 'cycling' becoming a social movement in the Pudukkottai district. This way Sheela Rani Chunkath should be commended for promoting 'freedom' of women by including 'cycling' in her literacy project.

6.How did the women react to the shortage of ladies' cycle?

Ans: Once 'cycling' as a symbol of women's liberation caught the imagination of the womenfolk in the Pudukkottai district, every woman in the district volunteered to learn cycling. Not surprisingly, this led to a shortage of 'ladies' cycles. These women enthusiasts did not hesitate. They volunteered to buy even 'gents' cycles and learned cycling. Later on, many women started preferring the 'gents' cycle because it has an additional bar from the seat to the handle and that way it enabled them to go out along with a child also. Even to this day thousands of women in Pudukkottai district ride 'gents' cycles. '

Where there is a Wheel Comprehension III :

1.How does P. Sainath show that cycling brings about changes beyond economic gains?

Ans: P. Sainath presents an eye-witness report of 'cycling' becoming a social movement. He tells us how tens of thousands of women in the Pudukkottai district of Tamil Nadu got initiated to learn cycling.

The Arivoli activists led by N. Kannammal pioneered the 'cycling' movement. As a part of their vigorous literacy drive, these activists learned cycling. Later, they organized 'cycling training camps' for other women. Thus, it got social sanction. Once the movement became a big force, every woman in Pudukkottai volunteered to learn cycling. Towards the end of the article, Sainath says, besides giving women freedom, mobility, and independence, it also has definite economic implications.

It boosts their family income. Sainath reports that a section of the women sells agricultural or other products within a group of villages. For them, cycling cuts down on time wasted in waiting for buses. Secondly, it gives them much more time to focus on selling their produce. Thirdly, it enlarges the area they wish to cover. Lastly, it can increase their leisure time.

In conclusion, he says, cycling brings about changes beyond economic gains also. 'Cycling' gives them a sense of self-respect which is vital to their sense of well-being. Thus, Sainath says that this humble vehicle has become a metaphor for freedom for these women.

2. 'O sister come learn cycling, move with the wheel of time...' How does the song suggest that the cycle could be an instrument of social change and progress?

Ans: In the article titled 'Where There is a Wheel', Sainath, the writer, reports an important social movement that took place during 1992-94 that stunned the people of the Pudukkottai district in Tamil Nadu.

There was an organization named 'Arivoli Iyakkam' which led the female literacy movement in Pudukkottai. These Arivoli activists learned 'cycling' so as to enable themselves to spread the message of literacy among rural women in the interior. Once the activists learned cycling, they, in turn, taught their neo-literates cycling. These neo-literates, neo-cyclists trained women in cycling, all over the district. During this period Muthu Bhaskaran, an Arivoli activist, wrote a famous song to encourage rural women to learn cycling. The song is intended to call upon the womenfolk to learn cycling.

The song conveys a simple message and when it is sung in Tamil, the mother tongue of these rural women, its meaning is easily understood. It only calls upon the woman to set in motion her own wheel of life. Until then, the woman could not move out of the house, because her 'mobility' depended on her being able to find money to go by bus. Going by bus also depended on the permission of the menfolk. The woman needed the help of her menfolk even to sell the agricultural produce which grew on her land. This way the woman could not break the male-imposed barriers. Once she learned cycling she got the freedom to move to any place she wanted and the freedom to do any work she wished to.

This song invites the woman to learn cycling and set in motion the wheel of her life. Here, the 'wheel' refers to 'progress'. So, it tells the woman to learn cycling and be responsible for her own progress.

Water - Challapalli Swaroopa Rani

A Note On The Poet :

Challapalli Swaroopa Rani (B 1968) obtained her doctorate at the University of Hyderabad and is currently the Head of the Centre for Buddhist Studies, Nagarjuna University, Guntur. A popular literary critic and writer, she has received several awards for her literary contributions. Several short stories and poems, essays on experiences of Dalit women, child labour and village life have been translated and published in Hindi, English and Malayalam. Her anthology of poems 'Mankenapuwu' has been awarded the Vimala Santhi Sahiti Puraskaram in 2006.

Some of her main books include an edited volume titled 'Padunekkinapata', an anthology of poetry by different Dalit poets published in 1995, 'Mankenapuwu' her first collection of poetry in 2005, 'Neeli Meghalu', 'Chikkanavuthunna Pata', a collection of essays entitled 'Asthithvagaanam' in 2012. She was the founder editor to the refereed Journal of Historical Research 'Charitraka Parishodhana'. She is the chief editor of the monthly journal on Dalit issues called 'Bahujanakeratalu' and a member of the editorial board of the monthly journal 'Samantara Voice'.

Water Summary :

'Water', by Challapalli Swaroopa Rani, is a reflective-narrative poem. The speaker in the persona of a 'Dalit' reminisces and chronicles a few typical but poignant situations which express the anguish and helplessness of a Dalit when he or she goes to a public pond or tank to collect water for their daily needs.

In the first five stanzas, the speaker cites 'water' as the witness to the practice of untouchability. The poet states in a casual, matter-of-fact tone that 'water', which knows where the ground is inclined along which it has to flow, knows that 'untouchability' never disappears, because the quarrel or conflict over allowing the Dalits to collect water from a village tank or pond, between the upper caste people and the Dalits, has been smouldering for several generations. The poet draws parallels between this situation and the dampness on the well's edge which never dries up. The writer uses this analogy to let the reader know that 'water', being the 'elixir of life', every living creature needs water, but it is so cruel of the upper caste people to deny such an essential 'element' of life to the 'Dalits' in the name of untouchability.

The speaker seems to say that this has been happening every day for several generations and it is ironical that only water knows it. The poet is showing an accusing finger at all those people who deny access to the Dalits to water in public places. The poet seems to ask the reader, 'Don't you know this?'

The idea is reiterated citing another instance of untouchability. The poet cites a Biblical incident in which Jesus, the Jew, goes to a Samaria woman (in a town called Sychar) and asks the woman for a drink. The Samaria woman belongs to an inferior race and Jesus, the Jew belongs to a superior race. Here the speaker seems to say that 'water' is essential to all, be it a Samaria woman or Jesus the Jew; similarly, water is essential for both the upper caste people and the untouchables. The same idea is reiterated in the next two lines. Even among the untouchables, there were sub-castes. 'Leather' refers to cobblers and the 'spool' refers to weavers. The speaker means to say that whether one is a cobbler or a weaver both of them need water. This fact is known to 'water', but why are people so cruel to give access to water to one and deny access to the other. Here, the 'other' refers to the untouchables.

A Panchama does not have the right to draw water from a public well because he is untouchable. It is cruel and unfortunate that he is made to wait near the well until a Shudra arrives. Here again, it is ironical that the 'Panchama', who does not belong to varna, has to wait for a Shudra who is supposed to belong to the fourth rank in the social hierarchy. A Shudra, according to the 'varna' scheme, is unskilled labour and he does all the physical tasks as directed by the other upper caste people. Naturally, only when a Shudra comes to a pond to fetch water for an upper caste person can he give some water to the Panchama. It also means that the other upper caste people who normally do not fetch water from a well will not be able to give water to a Panchama. The speaker is once again referring to the cruelty of the 'varna system' and the practices associated with untouchability.

The speaker cites another cruel instance of untouchability. Normally, whenever a person belonging to one of the four varnas happens to give some water to an 'untouchable' (here it is a girl), he/she takes care to see that the giver and the receiver stand apart from each other and pours water from a distance, from a higher level to a lower level. On such occasions, some water is bound to fall on the receiver. Here, the receiver being a girl, waterfalls all over her. The speaker wants the reader to imagine the humiliation of the girl when someone throws water at her or on her. Here, the speaker is highlighting the cruel practice of untouchability.

The speaker recalls a heinous incident that happened in a place called Karamchedu. It is reported that on 16 July 1985, when two Kamma youths were washing dirty buckets (that had been used to feed – their buffaloes) in the drinking water tank in Madigapalle, a Dalit boy objected to it, which angered the youth. Consequently, when the youths were about to beat up the boy, Munnangi Suvartamma, a Dalit woman, tried to protect the boy from the attack. She lifted the vessel that she was carrying, to drive away from the attackers. This act of lifting the vessel in self-defence later resulted in a ghastly attack by the upper caste people on the Dalits.

However, the speaker states that 'water' knows the 'anger' exhibited by Suvartamma by lifting her vessel (water pot) against the Kamma landlords, who asked her not to pollute the pond water. In the last two lines, the speaker asserts that 'water' has been the witness to centuries of social injustice.

The poet speaks in the first person and reminisces her painful experiences. The speaker says that whenever she sees water, she recalls that the people in her part of the village (Wada) would be suffering from severe thirst all day, not being able to get even a glass of water. She recalls sadly how they (the Dalits) would look forward to their weekly bath day, as if it was a wonderful festival day, while the upper caste people in the entire village enjoyed bathing luxuriously twice a day. Here the speaker intends to highlight the fact that while the Dalits were 'deprived' of water and were given water only once a week, the other people had so much water that they bathed luxuriously twice a day.

The speaker recalls her childhood, when they had to walk miles and miles to fetch water from the big canal and carried back heavy pots with the muscles and veins in their necks straining and bursting.

The speaker narrates a fire accident in Malapalle. It was a locality where the Dalits lived in thatched huts. When their thatched roofs caught fire, the huts were completely destroyed in the fire for want of a pot of water to douse the fire.

The speaker expresses her opinion about the role of water in the life of the Dalits. She also expresses her view about how water is acting as an agent of social change at the local as well as at the global level.

The speaker states that for them (Dalits) water is a mighty movement itself and cites the instance of the Mahad struggle at the Chadar tank. (Mahad was a town in Colaba district in the then Mumbai state.) The Mahad municipality had passed a resolution to allow untouchables full/free access to all village waterfronts. But the local upper-caste

population did not allow the Dalits to use the water and the resolution remained only on paper. On 19 March 1927, Dr Baba Saheb Ambedkar led a rally to the water reservoir at Mahad, drank water from that tank, and asserted the rights of the Dalits.

The speaker states that, for the Dalits, a single drop of water stands for tears shed by Dalits over several generations. She regretfully states that the Dalits had fought many battles for water in which they had shed their blood but had never succeeded in winning even a small puddle of water.

The speaker seems to hint that 'water' can act as an agent of social change and avenge the humiliation suffered by the Dalits. That is why she says, water is not a simple thing. It can give life but it can also devour lives. She categorically states that the water which should have been given to the Dalits to quench their parched throats later became the killer tsunami wave and swallowed village after village. In these lines the speaker seems to suggest that 'water' itself has acted as an agent of retribution, punishing the people for denying water to the Dalits. The theme of water as a mighty force and an agent of social change continues.

She recalls the suffering undergone by the poor people who get killed whenever there is a flood. The speaker remarks that poor people become playthings in the vicious hands of water and get killed in large numbers, often turning villages into dry deserts. Having expressed the harm caused by water to the untouchables, the speaker, in stanza thirteen, says that 'water' can become an issue of conflict between the village and the Wada, and between one State and another and be the cause of a bloody battle where people kill or hurt each other making the blood run in streams.

The speaker says that the very same water also can sit innocently in a Bisleri bottle appearing so innocuous. The poet traces the new avatar taken by water in the global market. She says that the very same 'well water' which the Dalits used to draw up from a well and carry in pots balancing them over their heads and hands now slowly and clandestinely dances its way into the Pepsi man's bottle. Subsequently, it gets sold in its new name 'mineral water'. The sale and origin of mineral water are also being vehemently debated. It is well known that Dalits depend on wells for their needs. But, owing to globalisation, many entrepreneurs have set up bottling plants for mineral water and other beverages. This has resulted in the depletion of groundwater which affects the Dalits directly.

The speaker seems to ridicule all those people who prevented the Dalits from polluting the water by their touch. She seems to make fun of them saying, "What happened to your social restrictions now?"

The speaker concludes declaring that 'water' is not an insignificant or trivial issue but is a multinational market commodity and it knows everything (omniscient). It contains the world, meaning, water has no boundaries. In the end, the speaker seems to challenge the oppressors that they can no longer deprive the untouchables of their share of water.

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Water Comprehension I :

1.The expression 'generations-old strife' suggests

- a. the bane of the caste system.
- b. politics of revenge.
- c. differences among humans.

Ans: (a) the bane of the caste system.

2.“It also knows the sub-caste difference between leather and spool.”

'leather and spool' stands for

- a. pure and impure.
- b. higher and lower.
- c. cobbler and weaver.

Ans: (c) cobbler and weaver.

3.How is water a witness to the humiliation caused to the Dalits?

Ans: In earlier times, when the varna system was in practice, the 'panchamas' or the untouchables were not allowed to touch or fill their pots with water. Whenever a Wada girl went to collect water from a pond or a tank, the people of other varnas used to pour water from a higher level at a distance, into the pot of the Wada girl. Naturally, on such occasions, some water would invariably fall on the body of the girl. This would cause a lot of humiliation to the girl.

4.What does the speaker remember when she sees water?

Ans: When the speaker sees water she would remember how people in her Wada would thirst all day for a glass of water.

Secondly, when she sees water she is also reminded of how they would eagerly welcome their weekly bath days as if it was a wondrous festival and also remember how the entire village bathed luxuriously twice a day.

The speaker also would recall her childhood when she would walk miles on end to go to the big canal and carry back heavy pots with the muscles and veins on her neck straining and bursting.

Finally, the sight of water would also make her recall how thatched roofs in Malapalle were burnt to ashes for want of a pot of water to douse the fire.

5.'circus feat' refers to

- a. hardship to fetch water.

- b. balancing the water pots on the head,
- c. 'efforts to secure basic needs.
- d. struggle surrounding water.

Ans: (b) balancing the water pots on the head.

6. 'Water' is a

- a. a liquid called water.
- b. a catalyst for a movement
- c. witness to strife.
- d. life-giver and destroyer,
- e. mean to practice untouchability.
- f. profit-making commodity.

Ans: (c), (d), (e) and (f).

Water Comprehension II :

1. Discuss the travails suffered by the Wada people to get water.

OR

How does the poet bring out the suffering and pain experienced on account of water?

OR

Discuss the problems faced by Wada people while collecting water.

Ans: In the poem 'Water', the speaker recalls the 'role' played by water as an agent of social change. Incidentally, she uses the context of the poem to highlight the travails and tribulations suffered by the people in wadas, with particular reference to the practice of untouchability in Andhra Pradesh in the pre- and post-independence periods.

It is an age-old practice that the Dalits or the untouchables live in separate colonies situated farther away from other communities and are called 'wadas'. Whenever the Dalits needed water they used to wait near the pond or tank until a shudra came there and gave them some water. This caused a great deal of humiliation, pain, suffering and anguish to the Dalits.

The speaker describes how an upper caste person poured water from a distance at a higher level into the pot of a wada girl at a lower level and how some water would fall on her body making her feel humiliated.

The writer also narrates a heinous incident that happened in Madigapalle in Karamchedu. It so happened that a Dalit boy tried to prevent two upper castes (Kamma)

youths from washing their dirty buckets in their drinking water pond. The two upper caste youths tried to attack the boy but a Dalit woman by name Suvartamma came to the boy's defence lifting her vessel to ward off their attack. Enraged by this protest by a Dalit woman, the Kamma landlords attacked the Dalit colony.

The speaker recalls how her wada people would thirst all day for a glass of water and narrates how people in wadas eagerly look forward to their weekly bathing day as if it was a wondrous festival while the people in the entire village bathed luxuriously twice a day. She also recalls painfully, how in her childhood she used to walk miles and miles to collect water from the big canal and carry back home heavy pots balanced on her head, with the muscles and veins on her necks straining and bursting. Finally, the speaker mentions how several thatched huts in Malapalle (a Dalit colony) were reduced to ashes for want of a pot of water to douse the fire.

2. 'For us, water is not simply H₂O', suggests

- a. it's chemical significance.
- b. it is a common resource available for all.
- c. it is a symbol of struggle against discrimination.

Ans: (c) it is a symbol of struggle against discrimination.

3. What does the contrast 'some taking bath once a week and others twice a day' connote?

Ans: 'Some taking bath once a week and others twice a day' connotes that the Dalits were able to take a bath only once in a week because they had no free access to public water and only when they had stored enough water for all of them to take a bath, would they take a bath on that day. On the other hand, the village people had free access to water and so they would take a bath twice a day.

4. Why does water become a matter of dispute?

Ans: The available quality of water differs from area to area so it becomes a matter of dispute. Some people get excess of water and some people do not get water even to drink. Water is a necessity for all the basic needs and for irrigation, for electricity, and for Industries. When the required quantity of water is not available, people will have to get it from elsewhere; When they go to other areas, the people from that area protest and agitate, so wars happen. A similar fight occurred between Karnataka and Tamilnadu. People of both states destroyed each other's property and destroyed and damaged buses just over the question of sharing water. In this way, many quarrels have happened for the sake of water.

5.Look at the expressions ‘many a circus feat’ and ‘dances its way into the Pepsi man’s bottle.’ What contrast do you notice between the two?

Ans: The phrase ‘many a circus feat’ refers to the Wada women walking with heavy pots of water on their heads, miles, and miles, from a big canal. This indicates the strain, the anguish, and the humiliation suffered by Dalits to fetch water for their daily needs. On the contrary, the phrase, ‘dances its way into the Pepsi man’s bottle’ refers to water being sold as a multinational market commodity. Here the phrase ‘dances its way’ shows the ease and the surreptitious ways in which ‘water’ is sold for a price when it is known all over the country that tens of thousands of poor people and Dalits even today, walk miles to fetch drinking water. For the Dalits and the poor, water is a necessity and ‘Pepsi’ is an item of luxury. This reflects how the poor become victims of discrimination.

Water Comprehension III :

1.How does the poem ‘Water’ demonstrate the disparity and discrimination in our society using water as a symbol?

OR

Is water instrumental in social discrimination and disparity? Explain.

OR

Bring out the bitter instances recollected by the speaker in ‘Water’.

OR

The difference between race and agony of the panchama due to water has been effectively brought out in ‘Water’. Discuss.

OR

‘Water is a witness to centuries of social injustice.’ Explain with reference to the poem ‘Water’.

Ans: In the poem ‘Water’, the speaker recalls several instances taken from the life of the Dalits to highlight the disparity between the Dalits and the upper caste people in their lifestyles.

The speaker states that water is witness to the Panchama’s plight when he goes to the pond or tank to collect water. Since he does not have the right to draw a pot of water directly from a well, he waits all day near the well until a shudra arrives there and fills his pot. Next, the speaker mentions the humiliation of the Wada girl, when she receives water poured from a distance. Some waterfalls on her body and she felt humiliated.

Later, the speaker articulates the righteous indignation shown by Karamchedu Suvartamma, when she raised her vessel to ward off an attack by the Kamma youths against the Dalit boy who asked them not to pollute their drinking water. These

instances illustrate how the Dalits were discriminated against using water from a public well.

The speaker recalls how people in the Wada would thirst all day for a glass of water while the villagers had a lot of water to drink and bathe as and when they wanted. On the other hand, the people in the village enjoyed the bath twice a day, because they had plenty of water, and the Dalits were made to forego water on the pretext of untouchability. Next, the speaker narrates how in her childhood they walked miles and miles to collect water from the big canal and walked back carrying heavy pots of water on their heads, with the veins in their neck straining and bursting.

Finally, the speaker recalls how several thatched huts in Malapalle were reduced to ashes for want of a pot of water to douse the fire.

2.How are the poor affected by

- a. lack of water.
- b. denial of water.
- c. the fury of nature?

Ans: In the poem 'Water' the speaker highlights how 'water' becomes a symbol of discrimination against the Dalits.

(a) Since the Dalits do not have free access to water, they cannot take a bath as and when they like. They can take a bath only after they have stored up adequate water for all the members of the family. Normally, this used to happen only once a week in those days.

(b) The Dalits were prohibited from fetching water from a pond or tank in a village. Naturally, when they needed water they had to go to the pond with their pot and wait until a shudra arrived and gave them water. Secondly, when the village people gave them water, they used to pour water from a distance into the pots carried by the Dalits and some water would fall on their bodies. This caused a lot of anguish and humiliation to the Dalits.

(c) The speaker speaks about 'water' as a natural social agent. Water is essential for life. It can give life but also can devour lives. The water that refused to quench parched throats became the killer tsunami wave and swallowed village after village. This way 'water' worked as a symbol of Nature and showed its fury against people who discriminated against the Dalits.

3.Trace the journey of water from ancient times as a symbol of purity to the age of the multinational market where it is a commodity.

OR

Water that ignites struggles and strife can also be a market commodity. Examine the statement in light of 'Water'.

Ans: The Dalits' age-old struggle for water has its origin in the people's perception of 'water' as a source of purity and the 'Dalits' as 'untouchables'. Though all living creatures have a right to share it, the upper caste society denies it to the Dalits for the only reason that they are Dalits.

The poet makes an attempt to trace the journey of water which begins as a symbol of purity in the life of the people and eventually ends up becoming a multinational market commodity. It also questions the wisdom of the people who deprived free access to water, an elixir of life, to the Dalits biasedly and eventually made it a multinational commodity and robbed them of their natural resources.

She presents a conflicting situation where Jesus, a Jew, asks for water from a Samaria woman, who is considered a lower caste woman. She also presents the instance of the Panchama, who is forced to wait with his pot all day near the well until a shudra comes to serve him.

She then presents the case of the Dalit girl, who gets humiliated by receiving water poured from above and getting her clothes drenched in water.

Next, she expresses the rage of the Dalit woman Munnangi Suvartamma, who goes to the rescue of the Dalit boy who objects to the Kamma youths washing their dirty buckets in their drinking water in Malapalle.

We learn how the Dalits crave a glass of water to quench their thirst. We also learn that the Dalits used to have a bath only once a week whereas the other people in the village enjoyed bathing luxuriously twice a day. We then learn how the Dalits had to walk miles and miles to fetch water from the big canal and carried back home heavy pots balanced on their heads with the muscles and veins in their neck straining and bursting.

She then says that quite a few thatched huts caught fire in Malapalle and were reduced to ashes, the only reason being the absence of a pot of water to douse the fire. Then we learn how people in Mahad municipality in Mumbai, asserted their right to public water under the leadership of Dr Ambedkar. All these instances are given to trace the journey of water from that of being a symbol to that of getting asserted as a fundamental right.

The poem also narrates the journey of 'water' in the life of the people in the last two decades. 'Water', which can save 'lives', can also devour lives in the form of a tsunami. It can also turn villages into dry deserts and inflict a lot of suffering on the people. At the same time, in some places water can take a toll on the lives of people in many villages in the form of floods.

In the last part of the poem, the speaker attempts to trace the journey of water into bisleri bottles as 'mineral water', becoming a multinational market commodity. Here again, such activity depletes the groundwater and affects the poor Dalits.

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